

THE COMPLETE HERMETIC  
& ROSICRUCIAN GRIMOIRE

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*Being an account of the Hermetic, alchemical, Solomonic and  
Rosicrucian traditions — with the sources of each dated and  
attributed, and the practices set out so that they may be  
performed*



SEVENTEEN CHAPTERS · WITH NINE DIAGRAMS

**The Complete Hermetic & Rosicrucian Grimoire.** This edition is assembled from primary and scholarly sources, each of which is dated and attributed in the Sources & Bibliography. Where a source is out of copyright this is marked; where it is not, it is cited rather than reproduced at length.

The text of the Emerald Tablet in Chapter 5 is Isaac Newton's, from Keynes MS 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, in the transcription of *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton* (Indiana University, 2010). The ritual texts in Chapters 6, 7, 12 and 17 are drawn from Mathers's translation of the *Key of Solomon* (1889) and from Crowley's *Liber O* (1909), both in the public domain. The planetary herbs in Chapter 17 are Culpeper's, from *The Complete Herbal* (1653). All diagrams were drawn for this book.

Four rounds of source verification were carried out on this text, the later ones adversarial. What they found — including the errors they found in the corrections themselves — is recorded in the note at the head of the bibliography rather than quietly removed.

Presented for historical, educational and research purposes as part of humanity's spiritual heritage.

*When a source tells you a text is ancient, check the date yourself. It is often findable in a few minutes, and it is frequently not what you were told.*

THE CLOSING ADVICE OF THIS BOOK

### Important Safety Warning

**This grimoire describes practices drawn from living and historical traditions. Approach it with care:**

- Proper preparation and protection are essential
- Use only for ethical intentions
- Respect the forces involved
- Follow all safety protocols
- Begin with beginner-level content only

### HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Every source in this grimoire is **dated and attributed**. Where a teaching commonly presented as ancient turns out to be medieval, early-modern or modern, the chapter says so and gives the date. This is not scepticism for its own sake — it is the only way a book claiming to rest on primary sources can be checked. Knowing that a practice was written in 1888 rather than in remote antiquity takes nothing away from it; it tells you what you are actually holding.

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CHAPTER I

## **Introduction to Hermetic Philosophy**

The Hermetic tradition is one of the most enduring systems of spiritual thought in Western history. Rooted in the meeting of Greek philosophy and Egyptian religion in Roman Alexandria, and transmitted through Arabic, Byzantine and Renaissance hands before reaching us, it offers a framework for thinking about the nature of reality, the structure of consciousness, and the relation between the human being and the divine. Its central conviction is that the cosmos is intelligible, that it is ordered by correspondence rather than by accident, and that a person willing to work at it can come to know that order directly rather than on authority.

That tradition is genuinely old. Some of what is taught in its name is not, and the honest place to begin is with the seven principles that almost every modern introduction — including the earlier version of this book — puts first.

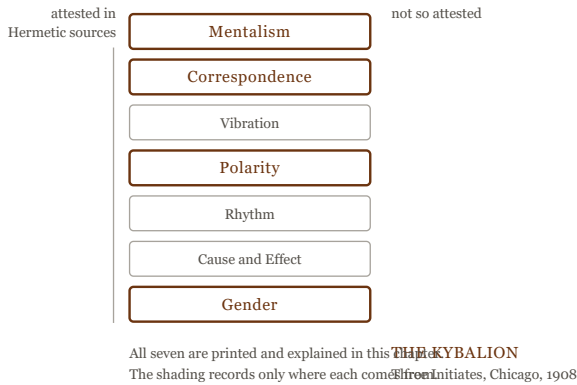


FIG. 1 — THE SEVEN PRINCIPLES, AND HOW MUCH OF EACH IS OLD. On Nicholas Chapel’s analysis, four of the seven have real footing in ancient and medieval Hermetic writing; three do not, and Vibration he traces to eighteenth-century associationist psychology rather than to Hermeticism at all. The chapter keeps all seven, because a source is not made worthless by being younger than advertised — but it says which is which. Drawn for this book from the analysis cited below.

### The Seven Hermetic Principles

- 1. The Principle of Mentalism:** "The All is Mind; the Universe is Mental." The fundamental nature of reality is mental, and all phenomena are manifestations of a Universal Mind.
- 2. The Principle of Correspondence:** "As above, so below; as below, so above." There is harmony and correspondence between the different planes of existence, such that what is learned of one informs understanding of another. (This is the one principle with a genuine older pedigree — though the familiar wording is itself a modern compression, as Chapter 5 sets out.)
- 3. The Principle of Vibration:** "Nothing rests; everything moves; everything vibrates." All matter and energy exist in constant motion, differing in frequency rather than in kind.

**4. The Principle of Polarity:** "Everything is dual; everything has poles; everything has its pair of opposites." Opposites are identical in nature and different only in degree, so that heat and cold, or love and hate, are positions on a single scale.

**5. The Principle of Rhythm:** "Everything flows, out and in; everything has its tides; all things rise and fall." Phenomena manifest in cycles, and the pendulum swing in one direction implies its return.

**6. The Principle of Cause and Effect:** "Every cause has its effect; every effect has its cause." Nothing happens by chance; what looks like chance is a cause not yet perceived.

**7. The Principle of Gender:** "Gender is in everything; everything has its masculine and feminine principles." All creation proceeds from the interaction of an active and a receptive principle, on every plane and not merely the physical.

## WHERE THESE PRINCIPLES ACTUALLY COME FROM

These seven principles derive from *The Kybalion*, published in 1908 under the pseudonym "Three Initiates" and generally attributed to William Walker Atkinson (1862–1932), a pioneer of the American New Thought movement. They are not found as a set in the ancient Hermetic writings.

Some of the material has genuine ancestry. Nicholas E. Chapel, in the most detailed study of the question, finds at least four of the seven principles clearly attested within Hermetic sources — mentalism, correspondence, polarity and gender have real footing in ancient and medieval Hermetic texts. Others do not. Chapel's specific claim about vibration is an argument about origin: the principle "originated in the middle of the 18th century with the British philosopher and medical doctor David Hartley (1705–1757)," and is by now so common in modern spiritual writing "that it bears no comment." That derivation is Chapel's own reconstruction across some hundred and sixty years; his supporting citation is to a study of Hartley's associationism rather than to anything linking Hartley to Atkinson, so it is given here as his argument rather than as a documented line of descent. His overall conclusion is that "the longstanding supposition that *The Kybalion* is consonant with Hermetic philosophy as an historical current is one that is erroneous and in need of revision."

The title is itself a puzzle. Chapel notes that the word "takes the form of a Greek noun, but has no meaning in that language or any other," and judges it "the more likely explanation that the title was chosen as an allusion" to Kabbalah or to Cybele, "to insinuate a link to antiquity."

None of which means the seven principles are worthless. They are a lucid, teachable summary that has introduced more people to Hermetic thinking than any ancient text ever did, and they are set out above in full for that reason. But they are a 1908 formulation, and a book that claims to rest on primary sources has to say so. Chapter 2 deals with the attested ancient material.

## What the tradition is for

Beneath the various formulations, ancient and modern, the Hermetic project is consistent in its aims. It holds that the universe is not inert — that it has structure, intelligence and direction, and that these can be investigated. It holds that the human being stands in a peculiar position, participating in both the material and the intelligible orders, and is therefore capable of understanding a cosmos that most of what exists cannot. And it holds that this understanding is transformative: to know the order of things truly is to be altered by knowing it.

This is why the tradition has always been simultaneously philosophical and practical. The meditations in Chapter 6 and the ritual structures in Chapter 7 are not decorations on the philosophy; they are how the philosophy is meant to be tested. The Hermetic claim is not that you should believe the cosmos is ordered, but that you can find out.

## On ethics

The ethical position of this literature deserves stating directly, because it is easy to lose among the warnings and the symbolism. Every serious current in this tradition treats knowledge as inseparable from the character of the person holding it. The Hermetic texts frame ascent as purification: what has to be put down is not ignorance in the abstract but greed, deceit, cruelty, self-importance. The Rosicrucian manifestos made the healing of the sick without payment their first practical commitment. Agrippa insisted the magus must also be a devout philosopher, and drew a hard line against sorcery. The *Ars Notoria* asks for memory and understanding, not for power over anyone.

The practical form this takes is simple enough to state and difficult to keep. Do not work to coerce, injure, deceive, or override another person's will — this rules out a considerable amount of what the historical grimoires happily supply, which is one reason this book presents that material descriptively. Do not treat other people's crises as an opportunity. Do not charge the desperate.

Do not confuse the sensation of insight with the fact of it, and keep the habit of checking your conclusions against something outside your own enthusiasm. Where a practice touches on health, treat it as a complement to medicine and never a substitute; Chapter 13 returns to this.

These are not rules imposed on the tradition from outside. They are what the sources themselves say, when read carefully — and they are considerably more demanding than any warning box.

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**Sources:** Three Initiates [William Walker Atkinson], *The Kybalion: A Study of the Hermetic Philosophy of Ancient Egypt and Greece* (Chicago, 1908) public domain. Nicholas E. Chapel, "The Kybalion's New Clothes," *Journal of the Western Mystery Tradition* No. 24, Vol. 3 (2013) — for the four principles attested in Hermetic sources, the David Hartley origin of vibration, and the reading of the title.

## CHAPTER II

## The Hermetica and Their Transmission

The genuine foundation of Hermetic philosophy is a body of Greek writing attributed to Hermes Trismegistus — "Hermes the Thrice-Greatest," a figure identified with the Egyptian Thoth and understood by his readers as an ancient Egyptian sage. These are the *Hermetica*. They are real, they are substantial, and their history of transmission is one of the more remarkable episodes in European intellectual life, largely because for two centuries everybody was wrong about how old they were.

### What the Corpus Hermeticum is

The *Corpus Hermeticum* is a selection of **seventeen Greek treatises** — numbered I to XVIII, with no treatise XV transmitted. It survives as a collection whose date and compiler are unknown; it is first attested in Byzantium, in the writings of Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078), who is a reader of the collection rather than its compiler, and the surviving manuscripts are late medieval and later. The religio-philosophical *Hermetica* themselves were, for the most part, produced in a relatively short span: **between the late first and the third century CE** on the common dating, though Christian Bull argues that some of the underlying material is older, stemming from at least as early as the first century BCE. They are the product of Roman-era Alexandria — Greek in language and philosophical vocabulary, Egyptian in much of their religious frame, and shaped by the Platonism of their period.

Alongside the *Corpus* proper stand several related texts. The *Asclepius* survives mainly in a Latin translation, with some Greek and Coptic fragments. The Nag Hammadi discovery yielded three Hermetic tractates in Codex VI: *The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6); the Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with its Scribal Note (VI,7a) — and that prayer also appears among the

Greek Magical Papyri, a connection worth noting; and a single continuous excerpt of the *Asclepius*, chapters 21–29 (VI,8). Further material survives as excerpts in Stobaeus and as papyrus fragments.

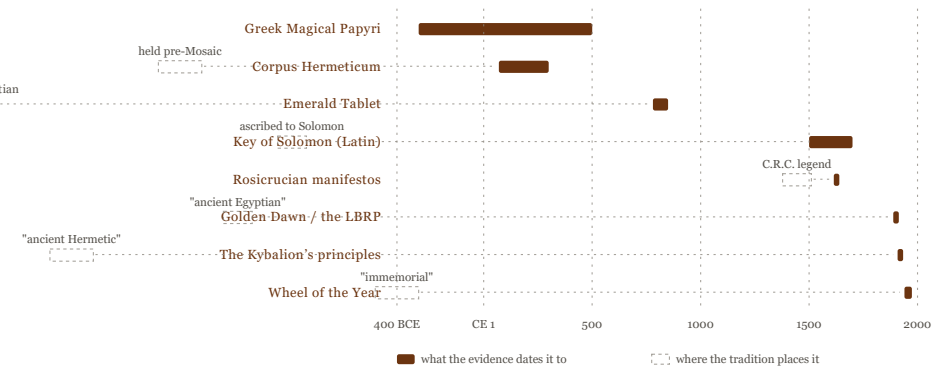


FIG. 1 — WHAT IS OLD, AND WHAT IS SAID TO BE OLD. Solid bars are the dates the evidence supports; dashed outlines are where the tradition has placed the same material. The distance between them is the subject of this book. Only the Greek Magical Papyri need no second bar. Note that the gap is not a measure of worth — the Kybalion is a useful book and the Wheel of the Year is a workable calendar; they are simply not what they are usually said to be. Compiled from the datings given in each chapter.

## The Divine Pymander

The first treatise of the *Corpus*, the *Poimandres* or Divine Pymander — the "Divine Shepherd" — describes the creation of the cosmos and the nature of the divine, and it remains the best entry point to the collection. Its teaching, in summary:

- The Divine Mind, *Nous*, is the source of all creation
- Human beings contain a divine element capable of being awakened
- Knowledge of the divine comes through direct experience rather than through belief

- The path to that knowledge runs through purification and contemplation

What makes the *Poimandres* compelling is that it is written as a report rather than a doctrine. The narrator describes an experience — a vision, a voice, a sequence of understandings — and the reader is invited to a method, not asked for assent. That posture runs through the whole collection and explains a great deal about the tradition it founded.

### **The transmission, and the great misdating**

Here is where the story becomes genuinely interesting. Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) had been set to translate the complete works of Plato into Latin for his patron Cosimo de' Medici — a commission of enormous significance for the Renaissance — when a manuscript of the *Corpus Hermeticum* reached Florence and Cosimo ordered him to translate Hermes first. The exemplar survives: Laurentianus LXXI, 33. He completed that translation — treatises I–XIV only, titled *Liber de potestate et sapientia Dei* and known ever after as the *Pimander* — in **1463**, dedicating it to Cosimo, who died the following year. It was first printed at Treviso by Gerardus de Lisa on 18 December **1471**, in an edition Ficino neither prepared nor authorised; that printing date is the one usually quoted, and it is not the date of the translation. Lodovico Lazzarelli (1447–1500) worked on the material as well.

Ficino interrupted Plato because he believed these texts were far older than Plato: the work of an Egyptian sage of remote antiquity, first of the *prisci theologi*, the ancient theologians, and the ultimate source from which Plato's own theology descended. Recovering them was therefore more urgent than translating a comparatively recent philosopher.

## A CORRECTION TO A STORY OFTEN TOLD ABOUT FICINO

It is frequently said — and this book said it in an earlier version — that Ficino believed the *Hermetica* *older than Moses*. He did not. Following Augustine's genealogy, which he reproduces at the head of his own preface, Ficino placed Hermes Trismegistus several generations *after* the time of Moses's birth. Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XVIII.39, has Hermetic philosophy flourishing long before the sages and philosophers of Greece but after Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph, "and even after Moses himself." The exact number of steps is not recoverable: the genealogy is corrupt in the received text of Augustine, and Yates calls Ficino's version of it garbled. The pre-Mosaic dating was one position available in Renaissance Hermeticism, and various later Hermetists and magi held it, but it should not be attributed to Ficino himself. What Ficino claimed was priority over the *Greeks*, not over scripture — which was quite enough to place these texts at the centre of European thought.

He was mistaken, and the correction came from Isaac Casaubon (1559–1614), the classical scholar. In his *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, **1614**) — written against Baronius's *Annales* — Casaubon argued that the Greek *Hermetica* were written not in ancient Egypt but partly out of Plato and the Platonists and partly out of Christian scripture, and that their vocabulary was later than the Greek current even around the birth of Christ. The English here is a summary of his argument rather than a translation of any single sentence; his own dating formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*, "in those first centuries of nascent Christianity." He gives no numeric range, and the ones often quoted in his name are modern glosses. The philology was decisive. The *Hermetica* were not primordial Egyptian revelation but Graeco-Egyptian writing of the Roman period.

## THE MISDATING IS THE REASON THE TRADITION EXISTS

It would be easy to file Casaubon's finding as a debunking and move on. That would miss the most important thing about it. *The error is what made Hermeticism matter.*

Had Ficino known these were second-century texts — roughly contemporary with the Church Fathers, plainly indebted to Platonism — he would very likely have finished the Plato first, and the *Corpus Hermeticum* might have remained a minor curiosity of late antique philosophy. Because he believed he was recovering the oldest wisdom in the world, the Hermetica were placed at the centre of Renaissance thought, and from there they shaped Ficino, Pico, Agrippa, Bruno, Dee, the alchemists, the Rosicrucian authors, and eventually every tradition covered in this book.

The dating was wrong. The influence was entirely real. And a tradition secure enough to record how it was founded on a philological mistake is in a stronger position than one that cannot mention it.

### The Emerald Tablet

One short text deserves separate treatment, and gets it: the Emerald Tablet, the *Tabula Smaragdina*, is the single most quoted item in the entire Hermetic literature, and Chapter 5 gives its full text, its transmission and its commentary tradition. The essential point belongs here, though, because it bears directly on the question of what "ancient Hermetic" means. The Tablet is not ancient Egyptian. It is **first attested in Arabic**, in the *Kitāb Sirr al-khalīqa wa-ṣanʿat al-ṭabīʿa* (the Book of the Secret of Creation), of the **late eighth or early ninth century**.

This places the Tablet firmly in the Arabic-Islamic tradition that preserved, developed and transmitted so much of this material to medieval Europe — a debt Western esoteric writing has often obscured. The Latin versions on which every later European reading depends are translations from Arabic, beginning in the twelfth century. When the Tablet is described as a text of remote Egyptian antiquity, an entire and decisive stage of the tradition is being erased.

### **Reading the *Hermetica* today**

For a reader who wants the primary texts rather than summaries, the standard modern scholarly translation is Brian Copenhaver's *Hermetica* (1992), which gives the Greek *Corpus* and the Latin *Asclepius* with a substantial introduction and notes; M. David Litwa's *Hermetica II* (2018) covers the Stobaeian excerpts, papyrus fragments and ancient testimonies. Walter Scott's four-volume *Hermetica* (1924–36) — completed after his death by A. S. Ferguson, who wholly authored the fourth volume — is older and its editorial choices are now contested, but it remains foundational. G. R. S. Mead's *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) is out of copyright and widely available online, which is why it is the version most readers encounter — but it is a Theosophically-inflected translation from before Scott's work, and it should be read alongside Copenhaver rather than instead of him.

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**Sources:** *Corpus Hermeticum*, 17 Greek treatises (numbered I–XVIII, no XV transmitted), composed between the late first and the third century CE; Christian H. Bull, *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus* (Brill, 2018), pp. 24, 330, 457, for the dating, for the older underlying material, and for Psellos as reader rather than compiler. Ficino's Latin translation of treatises I–XIV (the *Pimander*), completed 1463 on Cosimo's order, from Laurentianus LXXI, 33; first printed Treviso, 18 December 1471. Paul Oskar Kristeller, *Studies in Renaissance Thought and Letters*, p. 223, is the pioneering study of the translation. Lazzarelli (1447–1500). Casaubon, *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, 1614), Exercitatio I sect. X, on the dating; his formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*. Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078) for the collection's first attestation. Copenhaver, *Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius* (Cambridge, 1992) — in copyright. Litwa, *Hermetica II* (2018). Scott and A. S. Ferguson, *Hermetica*, 4 vols (1924–36). Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) public domain. Emerald Tablet — first attested in the *Sirr al-khalīqa*, late 8th / early 9th c. Nag Hammadi Hermetica: *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6), Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with Scribal Note (VI,7a), *Asclepius* 21–29 (VI,8).

CHAPTER III

## Sacred Geometry & Symbols

Sacred geometry is the study of the forms and proportions that recur throughout the natural world, understood in this tradition as evidence of an ordered cosmos. The claim is not that shapes possess power in themselves, but that certain forms appear so persistently — in crystal, in shell, in orbit, in the branching of plants — that they can be treated as the vocabulary in which the order of things is written. Symbols in this tradition are compressed arguments. Learning to read them is learning to hold a set of relations in mind at once, which is why they were taught as objects of contemplation rather than as decoration.

### The fundamental forms

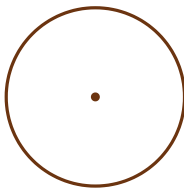
**The Circle** represents unity, wholeness and the infinite. Having neither beginning nor end, it stands for the eternal, and for that which contains without being contained. In practice it is also the boundary: the ritual circle of Chapter 7 and the Solomonic tradition is this figure put to work, defining an inside and an outside.

**The Triangle** represents the threefold structure that recurs across the tradition — heaven, earth and the human realm; or in alchemical terms the three principles of Chapter 4. Its orientation carries meaning: point upward for the ascent of the volatile and the aspiration of spirit, point downward for descent, manifestation and the fixed.

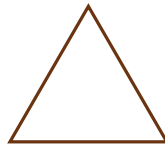
**The Square** represents stability, foundation, and the four elements. It is the figure of the material world and of earthly manifestation — four walls, four directions, four winds. Where the circle bounds, the square builds.

**The Pentagram** represents the five elements — the four with a fifth, quintessence or spirit, added — and the human microcosm. Drawn with a single unbroken line, it stands for the human being as a reflection of the cosmos, arms and legs and head at the five points. It is the central figure of the banishing practice in Chapter 12, where its specific documented history is given.

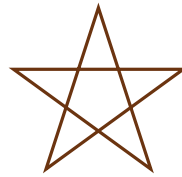
**The Hexagram**, two interpenetrating triangles, represents the union of the ascending and descending currents — the visual statement of "as above, so below." In alchemical contexts it also encodes the elements by their combination of upward and downward triangles with and without a bar.



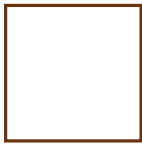
**CIRCLE**  
unity, the boundary



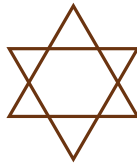
**TRIANGLE**  
the threefold



**PENTAGRAM**  
microcosm, five elements



**SQUARE**  
the four elements



**HEXAGRAM**  
macrocosm, above and below



**VESICA**  
the two made one

**FIG. 1 — THE FUNDAMENTAL FORMS.** The vocabulary described in this section. Each is a compressed argument rather than a decoration, and each recurs operatively later in the book: the circle as the ritual boundary of Chapter 7, the pentagram as the figure traced in Chapter 12, the hexagram as the six-rayed star of the same rite. Drawn for this book.

## The Tree of Life

The diagram that organises most Western ceremonial practice is the Qabalistic Tree of Life: ten *sephiroth*, or emanations, connected by twenty-two paths. It came into this tradition from Jewish mysticism, was extensively reworked by Christian Cabalists of the Renaissance, and reached modern practice through Agrippa and then the Golden Dawn, which mapped tarot, astrology, colour and Hebrew letter onto every path.

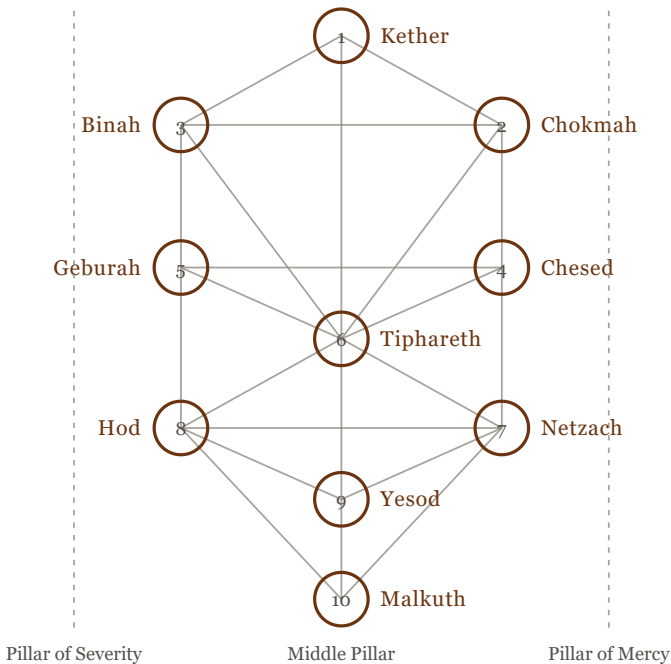


FIG. 1 — THE TREE OF LIFE. Ten sephiroth and the twenty-two paths that join them, arranged in three pillars. The numbering descends from Kether (1) to Malkuth (10). The path-count of twenty-two, matching the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, is standard in the Qabalistic literature; the assignment of particular tarot trumps and colours to particular paths is a Golden Dawn construction of the 1890s, as the paragraph below notes. Diagram drawn for this book.

Two points of honesty are owed here. First, the Christian and occult Cabala of the Renaissance is a genuine tradition with real intellectual achievements, but it is not identical to Jewish Kabbalah and should not be presented as though it speaks for it; the correspondences layered on by nineteenth-century orders are their own contribution. Second, the elaborate tables of correspondence familiar from modern handbooks — this path to that tarot trump, that sephirah to this planet and colour — are largely Golden Dawn constructions of the late nineteenth century. They are coherent, they are useful, and they are not ancient.

## **Proportion**

The proportional side of sacred geometry concerns ratios that recur in growth and in classical design: the relation of a diagonal to a side, the division of a line so that the whole is to the greater part as the greater is to the lesser, the interval ratios that produce consonance in music. The Pythagorean discovery that harmony can be expressed as simple whole-number ratios is the root of the whole enterprise, and it is the reason this tradition has always taken mathematics to be a spiritual discipline rather than a merely useful one. That a plucked string divided in half sounds the same note an octave higher is a fact about the world, and it was received as a revelation about the world.

A caution belongs here, in keeping with the rest of this book. A great deal of popular writing on sacred geometry claims to find the golden ratio in the Parthenon, the Great Pyramid, and the proportions of the human body, with a precision the measurements do not support. The genuine cases — in phyllotaxis, in certain spirals, in deliberate Renaissance design — are interesting enough without the invented ones. Contemplating a form for what it actually is remains the practice; contemplating a form for what a diagram claims about it does not.

**Sources:** Pythagorean ratio theory as transmitted through Platonic and Neoplatonic writing. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Books I–II, for elemental and celestial correspondence. Tree of Life correspondences in their modern form: Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (1888 onward), published in Regardie, *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40).

## CHAPTER IV

**Alchemical Foundations**

Alchemy is the art of transformation, and its literature is the most systematically misread body of writing in this tradition. The popular account — that alchemists were failed chemists trying to make gold — is too crude, but the correction usually offered for it is a matter of live scholarly dispute, and this book will not pretend otherwise. Lawrence Principe and William Newman have argued, in "Some Problems with the Historiography of Alchemy" (2001) and in Principe's *The Secrets of Alchemy* (2013), that reading alchemy as essentially an inner discipline is a nineteenth-century invention, traceable to Mary Anne Atwood in 1850 and to Ethan Allen Hitchcock, and that, in their words, they "find no indication that the vast majority of alchemists were working on anything other than material substances toward material goals." Against them, Hereward Tilton, Wouter Hanegraaff and others hold that this corrects too far and, as Mike Zuber summarises the critics, "downplays important topics in favour of chemical content and experimental technique." What almost nobody now defends is the sharp either/or; Stanton Linden, whom this chapter cites below, holds that all three goals — metallic, medical and spiritual — are at times simultaneously present in the same treatise. Metals are the language in which the work is described — metallurgy supplied a vocabulary of purification, dissolution and change of state that nothing else in the ancient world could match — and what else the metals were is exactly what is argued about.

One sentence often offered as evidence for the symbolic reading deserves to be traced, because this book printed it in an earlier version and it does not survive the tracing. The claim that neither Michael Maier nor Heinrich Khunrath ever claimed to have produced gold, and that their alchemy was therefore symbolic rather than operative, circulates as an unsourced sentence in the Wikipedia article on Rosicrucianism; no scholar is named for it there,

and none was named for it here. The specialists say something else. Hereward Tilton, Maier's biographer, writes that Maier "dedicated his life to the quest for the highest goal of alchemy: the philosophers' stone" — a substance held in Maier's day to "transmute lead into gold, heal the sick, and even reverse the aging process." Tilton records Maier's first laboratory experiments during his internship of 1592–95, his journey in 1603 to the gold and silver mines of Hungarian Carpathia and his first alchemical experiment at Easter 1604, his co-authorship in 1616 of Francis Anthony's printed defence of *aurum potabile*, and, in the last year of his life, his having produced an *aurum potabile* "far excelling" Anthony's. Peter Forshaw, reporting Tilton, notes that gold-making "may not have been the main goal of Maier's practice, which was more concerned with the use of gold as *aurum potabile* (drinkable gold) in chemical medicine, but it was nevertheless part of his training and repertoire," that "many of the quotes in *Atalanta fugiens* have their sources in medieval chrysopoetic literature," and that the tendency to relegate visual forms of alchemy to a "spiritual quest" "should also be reconsidered." Nor were these two men associates: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud, a *Betrüger*. The narrow claim, that no surviving text has either man announcing a successful transmutation, may well be true. The conclusion the popular account draws from it is not one any specialist draws.

### The three principles

**Sulfur — Soul.** The active principle: consciousness, will, the animating and combustible element that drives change. In the operator, that which initiates.

**Mercury — Spirit.** The mediating principle: intuition, imagination, the volatile element that passes between states and carries influence from one to another. In the operator, that which perceives and connects.

**Salt — Body.** The fixed principle: form, stability, the residue that remains after burning. In the operator, that which persists and can be built upon.

To these the tradition adds the four elements as states rather than substances — earth for the solid and fixed, water for the fluid and receptive, air for the mobile and mediating, fire for the transformative — and, in most systems, a fifth, quintessence, standing outside the four as their principle of coherence.



FIG. 2 — THE THREE PRINCIPLES. The *tria prima* in their conventional glyphs: sulfur, mercury and salt. The three-principle scheme is Paracelsian, sixteenth-century, and is layered over the older four elements rather than replacing them. Glyphs redrawn for this book from the standard early-modern forms.

## The stages of the work

The *magnum opus* is described in stages, most often by colour. The Latin names familiar from modern writing are conventionally set beside a Greek sequence that is among the oldest technical vocabulary in the tradition — exactly, for the first three; less so for the fourth:

- **Nigredo** — the blackening, Greek *melanosis*. Putrefaction and dissolution; the breaking down of what was.
- **Albedo** — the whitening, *leukosis*. Washing and purification; what remains once the dross is gone.
- **Citrinitas** — the yellowing, *xanthosis*. The transitional stage.

- **Rubedo** — the reddening, *iosis*. The completed work; the union of what had been separated.

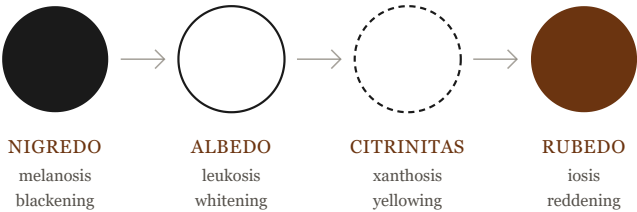


FIG. 3 — THE FOUR COLOUR STAGES. The *magnum opus* as the texts most often describe it, with the Greek terms that underlie the familiar Latin ones. The four-stage form is the older; from about the fifteenth or sixteenth century many writers absorb *citrinitas* into *rubedo* and work with three. *Iosis* is the odd one out. Liddell–Scott glosses it not as a reddening but as "refinement" — of gold, by oxidation of impurities — with a secondary sense "making of a tincture"; its root is *ios*, rust or verdigris. The familiar rendering "iosis (reddening)" descends from Jung, *Psychology and Alchemy* §333, not from a lexicon. The equation *iosis* = *rubedo* holds as a position in the sequence, both naming the last stage, rather than as a translation. Diagram drawn for this book.

Colour change of this kind is already the substance of the earliest surviving Greek alchemy. The *Physika kai mystika* attributed to pseudo-Democritus is concerned with whitening base metals to silver and yellowing them to gold; ancient testimony describes four books under the name — on gold, on silver, on stones and on purple. Whether all four of the Greek stage-names in the modern lists occur in that text is a question for its critical edition (Matteo Martelli, *The Four Books of Pseudo-Democritus*, 2013), which could not be obtained for this edition. Zosimos of Panopolis, who quotes Mary the Jewess constantly, is reported to have credited her with knowledge of the colour changes; the claim is widely repeated, and reaches this book through Raphael Patai's 1982 *Ambix* article, which could not be obtained and against which it was therefore not checked. How many stages there are was never settled. The four-colour form is the older, and from about the fifteenth or sixteenth century many writers reduced the colours to three, *citrinitas* being absorbed into

*rubedo* or simply dropped — which is why modern accounts differ on whether there are three or four. That dating reaches modern readers chiefly through Jung, *Psychology and Alchemy* §333, who hedges it as "about the fifteenth or sixteenth century" and attributes the change to "inner psychological reasons" rather than to anything in the texts.

Read as an account of interior change the sequence is uncomfortably recognisable. Something held together comes apart; there is a period in which nothing is left but the fact of having come apart; what survives is smaller and cleaner than what went in; and only afterwards is there any integration worth the name. The alchemists insisted the stages cannot be skipped and cannot be hurried, and that *nigredo* is not a failure of the work but its beginning. Whatever one makes of their metallurgy, that is a serious psychological observation, and it is why this literature found readers in the twentieth century among people with no interest in furnaces at all.

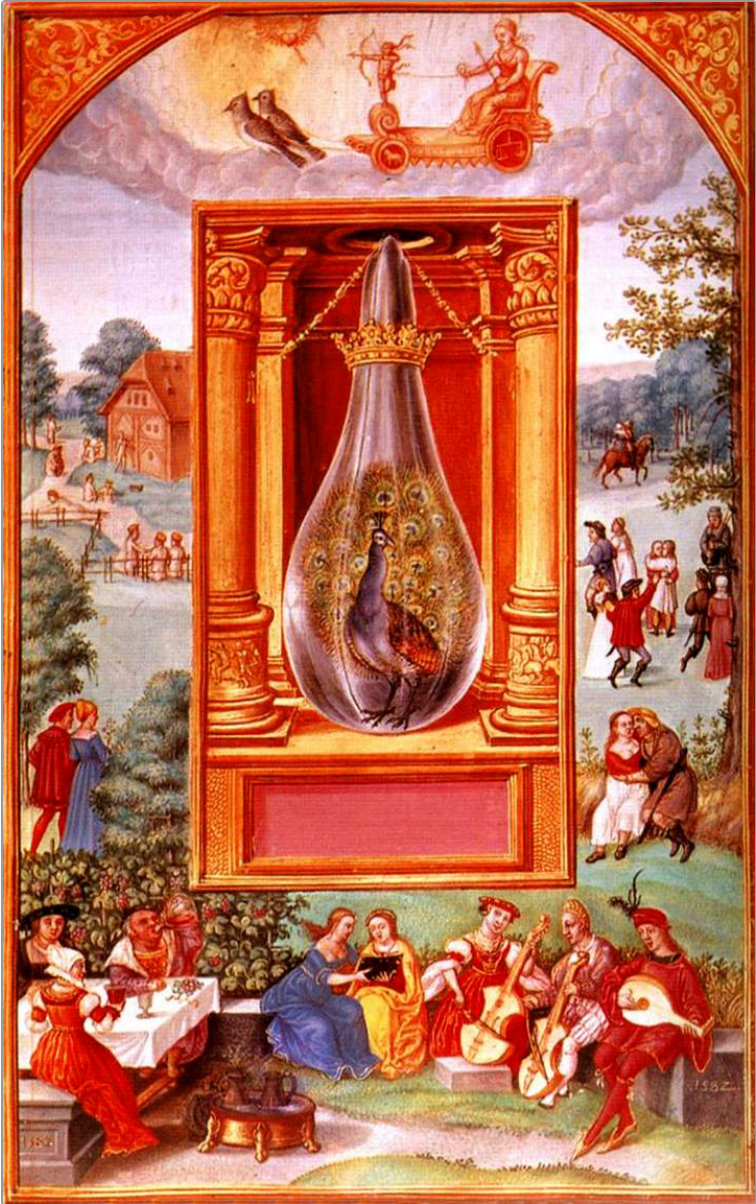


PLATE II — THE PEACOCK'S TAIL. The *cauda pavonis*, the iridescence reported between the whitening and the reddening, shown as a peacock standing

in the flask. The manuscript gives it a full page, which is a fair measure of how much the colour sequence mattered to the people who worked it. This stage sits outside the four-name scheme above, and different writers place it differently — which is the inconsistency Linden warns about.

*Splendor Solis*, illuminated manuscript, between 1532 and 1535. Public domain; Kupferstichkabinett, Berlin, via Wikimedia Commons.

## The operations

Alongside the colour stages the tradition describes sequences of *operations* — the named procedures by which the work advances. The most influential English list is George Ripley's **Twelve Gates**, from the *Compound of Alchymy* — a poem completed in 1471 and dedicated to Edward IV, but not printed for another hundred and twenty years, when Raph Rabbards set it forth in London from Thomas Orwin's press in 1591: calcination, solution, separation, conjunction, putrefaction, congelation, cibation, sublimation, fermentation, exaltation, multiplication, and projection. (The second gate is *Solution* in Ashmole's *Theatrum Chemicum Britannicum* of 1652, followed here, and *Dissolution* in the 1591 print.)

A rival scheme of fourteen stages goes under the name of Samuel Norton, great-grandson of Thomas Norton: it begins with purgation, sublimation and calcination and ends with multiplication in virtue and multiplication in quantity. Where it comes from is worth stating, because it is almost always mis-cited. It is not in Norton's English *Key of Alchemy* of 1578, which he says he "divided into eight several parts or treatises" and which contains no such list. The fourteen are the operations numbered through *Mercurius redivivus*, a Latin tract published at Frankfurt in 1630 by the York physician Edmund Deane, whose title page describes it as begun by Norton (*inchoatus*) and issued *auctor & perfectior*, enlarged and improved. How much of the numbering is Norton's and how much Deane's cannot be settled from the printed book; the names are Latin, and the English forms in circulation are translations.

A caution is owed here, and it comes from the scholarship rather than from scepticism. Stanton J. Linden, introducing *The Alchemy Reader* (Cambridge, 2003), p. 17, writes that "there is nothing approaching uniformity and consistency in the names assigned to these stages, or to the nature of the processes described, their order, or even their number." Anyone presenting a single definitive sequence of alchemical operations is presenting one author's scheme as though it were the tradition's. Ripley's twelve are worth knowing because they were widely copied, not because they are canonical.

What the operations do share is a shape. Something is broken down, separated into components, purified, recombined with what it was separated from, and then stabilised — with fermentation and multiplication at the end suggesting that a completed work becomes capable of propagating itself. Whether read as metallurgy or as biography, that arc is the same one the colour stages describe.



PLATE I — THE ORATORY AND THE LABORATORY. Khunrath's engraving puts the two in one room: a prayer desk at the left, a furnace and bench of glassware at the right, and a table of instruments between them. It is the best single answer to the dispute in this chapter's opening paragraphs, because it declines to take a side — the point of the image is that the praying and the distilling are one activity. Note also what it settles about Khunrath himself, whom this book once described as a symbolic rather than an operative alchemist: he drew himself a laboratory.

Hans Vredeman de Vries, from Heinrich Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae*, 1595. Public domain; digitised by the University of Wisconsin–Madison, via Wikimedia Commons.

## The Greco-Egyptian foundation

The earliest substantial alchemical material is Greek, from Roman Egypt, and two figures dominate it.

**Zosimos of Panopolis** (fl. c. 300 CE) is the earliest alchemical writer whose substantial corpus survives under his own name; the *Physika kai mystika* attributed to pseudo-Democritus is older but survives incompletely and under a pseudonym. He is the channel through which nearly everything earlier survives, and his writing is a strange and compelling mixture of technical procedure and recorded vision — the dream-sequences in which he is instructed by priests at an altar are among the oldest first-person accounts of anything resembling initiatory experience in this tradition.

**Mary the Jewess** (Maria Hebraea), whom Zosimos quotes as an authority already of the past, worked in Greco-Roman Egypt, most likely between the first and third centuries CE — the specialist literature declines to place her in a particular city, and the usual attachment to Alexandria comes from general reference works rather than from anything Zosimos says. F. Sherwood Taylor and Edmund von Lippmann place her among the first alchemical writers, no later than the first century; others read Zosimos's manner of quoting her as evidence for a later date. Nothing narrows it further. She is credited with describing three pieces of apparatus, and the credit is technical rather than legendary: the *tribikos*, a three-armed alembic for distillation, whose technical details Zosimos says were transmitted by Mary — hers is the earliest description that survives, though Zosimos does not call it the first, and whether she devised the still or only described it is not known; the *kerotakis*, a reflux vessel in which metals laid on a heated palette were exposed to rising vapours, a luted condensing cover returning the condensate to the base — it is often called airtight and often called the ancestor of Soxhlet's extractor of 1879, and neither belongs to the specialist literature on her apparatus, the cover being vented by a small hole and Soxhlet going unmentioned in the standard survey; and the *bain-marie*, the double boiler, whose name is hers: the medieval Latin *balneum Mariae* is thought to have been introduced by

Arnald of Villanova in the fourteenth century, and the lexicographers derive it from Marie-la-Juive, who is *said* to have invented or improved the technique. Said, not shown — von Lippmann pointed out that water-baths are described by Hippocrates, Theophrastus, Dioscorides and Pliny long before her. She is named among the alchemists listed in Ibn al-Nadīm's tenth-century *Kitāb al-Fihrist*. (The oddly specific figure of fifty-two, repeated in many popular accounts, could not be checked against Dodge's translation of the *Fihrist* for this edition, and is therefore not given here.)

Two sayings are attributed to her. One is a formula for union: *join the male and the female, and you will find what is sought*. The other is the celebrated Axiom of Maria: *one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth*. Neither is given in quotation marks here, and the reason is worth stating: they reach English through a chain of translations, and for the Axiom the wording everyone reproduces descends through Jung's *Psychology and Alchemy* rather than from any named translator of Zosimos. The union formula's English has not been traced to a named translator at all. Jung took the second seriously enough to build on it at length. Not everything attached to her name is sound — the Byzantine chronicler George Syncellus, writing about 810, reports the alleged initiation of Democritus in Egypt by Ostanēs, Mary the Jewess and Pammenes, which is chronologically impossible: Democritus belongs to the fifth century BCE — but the apparatus comes through Zosimos and stands. The Axiom does not: Jung traced it to the treatise ascribed to Christianos, whom Berthelot placed at about the beginning of the seventh century, and cited it from Berthelot's edition of the Greek alchemists rather than from Zosimos.

## **The operative tradition and its transmission**

Physical laboratory alchemy was, of course, also real, and it deserves its historical due. Its practitioners developed distillation, sublimation and crystallisation, identified acids and salts, built the apparatus — alembic, retort, athanor, the vessels above — and produced the observational groundwork on which chemistry was later built. Robert Boyle and Isaac Newton both worked in this tradition, and what kind of work it was is still argued. Lawrence

Principe's *The Aspiring Adept* (1998) argues that Boyle's alchemical interests were "serious and persistent, constituting a significant and influential dimension of his life, thought, and works," that his alchemy was of a distinctly traditional type grounded in chrysopoeia, and that Boyle took a keen interest in connections between alchemy and the supernatural. Newton wrote and transcribed about a million words on alchemy — laboratory notebooks, indices of alchemical substances, and transcriptions from other sources. The papers surfaced at a Sotheby's sale in 1936, and it took the twentieth century some time to absorb what they were: William Newman reads them as experimental chymistry rather than religious search, a reading not every scholar shares.

The textual lineage runs deep. Two of the key early documents, Leyden papyrus X and the Stockholm papyrus, came out of the same reconstructed Theban group as the Greek Magical Papyri of Chapter 8 — the clearest single piece of evidence that late antique alchemy and late antique magic were one enterprise. From there the tradition passes into Arabic hands, where it was transformed and considerably advanced: Jābir ibn Ḥayyān, Ibn Umayl, Abū Bakr al-Rāzī, and the *Sirr al-khalīqa* that carries the earliest text of the Emerald Tablet — the subject of Chapter 5. Latin Europe received the whole inheritance in translation from the twelfth century onward, beginning with Robert of Chester in 1144. The great early-modern flowering — Paracelsus, Sendivogius, Maier's *Atalanta fugiens*, the *Rosary of the Philosophers*, *Splendor Solis*, the emblem books with their images of kings drowning and suns turning black — builds on that Arabic foundation, a debt the European sources acknowledge far more readily than their modern popularisers do.

### **Safety Warning for Alchemical Practices**

Spiritual and contemplative alchemical work should be undertaken with proper preparation and, ideally, guidance; the process can be intense and should be approached gradually.

**Physical laboratory alchemy is a separate matter, and this book does not provide procedures for it.** The historical recipes call for mercury, antimony, lead, arsenic compounds and corrosive acids, handled with heat in unventilated rooms. These substances cause irreversible neurological and organ damage, and the harm is frequently cumulative and unnoticed until advanced. Chronic mercury poisoning is well documented among historical practitioners. There is no traditional protection, purification or intention that alters the toxicology. If the operative tradition interests you, read its history — and leave the handling of its materials to people with a fume hood, a chemistry qualification and a waste-disposal contract.

### **MODERN PRACTICE**

Contemporary practitioners work the alchemical sequence almost entirely as an interior discipline, often keeping a written record structured by the stages — noting what is dissolving, what is being washed, what has survived. Some work with plant alchemy or *spagyrics*, which uses herbal tinctures and distillation and stays within the safety envelope of ordinary kitchen chemistry. C. G. Jung's reading of the alchemical corpus as a symbolic account of individuation has been enormously influential and is how most readers now encounter this material; it is a twentieth-century interpretation of the texts rather than what their authors said they were doing, and it is worth holding both readings at once.

**Sources:** Zosimos of Panopolis; pseudo-Democritus, *Physika kai mystika*; Leyden papyrus X (P. Leid. I 397) and the Stockholm papyrus (P. Holm.) — 4th c. CE, from the reconstructed Theban group, cf. Ch. 8. Jābir ibn Ḥayyān; *Sirr al-khalīqa* (late 8th / early 9th c.). Maier, *Atalanta fugiens* (1617); Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (Hamburg 1595; Hanau 1609) — the two editions differ substantially, the 1609 being much expanded. On Khunrath's insistence that alchemy is prayed and worked at once, and on his laboratory chemistry, see Peter J. Forshaw, *The Mage's Images: Heinrich Khunrath in His Oratory and Laboratory*, 4 vols (Leiden: Brill, 2024–25), and Forshaw, "Subliming Spirits: Physical-Chemistry and Theo-Alchemy in the Works of Heinrich Khunrath (1560–1605)," in Stanton J. Linden (ed.), *"Mystical Metal of Gold": Essays on Alchemy and Renaissance Culture* (AMS Press). Maier and Khunrath do not form a single school: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud. Jung's individuation reading: 20th century, interpretive. On Mary the Jewess see Seth C. Rasmussen, "Mother of Invention: Maria the Jewess and Early Contributions to Chemical Apparatus," *Bulletin for the History of Chemistry* 47, no. 2 (2022), 179–185 (open access), and Raphael Patai, *The Jewish Alchemists* (Princeton, 1994), ch. 5, which could not be obtained for this edition. On Ripley: the *Compound of Alchymy* was completed 1471 and first printed London, 1591, ed. Raph Rabbards (STC 21057); the fourteen operations attributed to Samuel Norton are those of *Mercurius redivivus*, ed. Edmund Deane (Frankfurt, 1630), not of Norton's *Key of Alchemy* (1578).

## CHAPTER V

**The Emerald Tablet**

The Emerald Tablet is the shortest text in this book and the most consequential. In a few hundred words it supplied Western alchemy with its founding statement, its governing image, and its most quoted line. Nearly every alchemical work from the twelfth century to the eighteenth cites it, glosses it, or assumes it. Newton translated it. Jung read it. It has been printed thousands of times.

It is also not what most readers are told it is. It is not ancient Egyptian, it was not carved on emerald, and the sentence everybody knows from it is not in it. All three of those facts are well established, and none of them diminishes the text — they make its actual history considerably more interesting than the legend.

**The text**

Below is Isaac Newton's English rendering of the Tablet, from Keynes MS 28 in King's College Library, Cambridge (ff. 2r–v). The same manuscript carries the Latin text of the vulgate and Newton's own Latin commentary; B. J. T. Dobbs argued, mainly from the handwriting, that the English was made some years after the Latin and from a French version rather than directly from the Latin — the Newton Project's catalogue points to the *Bibliothèque des philosophes* (1672–8), which Newton owned and names on the same leaf. Newton's version is given here in preference to a modern one for three reasons: it is out of copyright, it is the rendering most often reproduced in popular anthologies and online, and Newton's choices as a translator are themselves part of the commentary tradition.

*Tis true without lying, certain & most true. That which is below is like that which is above & that which is above is like that which is below to do the miracles of one only thing*

*And as all things have been & arose from one by the mediation of one: so all things have their birth from this one thing by adaptation.*

*The Sun is its father, the moon its mother, the wind hath carried it in its belly, the earth is its nurse. The father of all perfection in the whole world is here. Its force or power is entire if it be converted into earth.*

*Separate thou the earth from the fire, the subtile from the gross sweetly with great indoustry. It ascends from the earth to the heaven & again it descends to the earth & receives the force of things superior & inferior.*

*By this means you shall have the glory of the whole world & thereby all obscurity shall fly from you. Its force is above all force. For it vanquishes every subtile thing & penetrates every solid thing.*

*So was the world created. From this are & do come admirable adaptations whereof the means (or process) is here in this.*

*Hence I am called Hermes Trismegist, having the three parts of the philosophy of the whole world. That which I have said of the operation of the Sun is accomplished & ended.*

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**Text:** Isaac Newton, Keynes MS. 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v, from *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), normalised transcription by John A. Johnson. Newton's spelling and ampersands are retained. The manuscript sets the text as eleven verses; they are grouped here into seven, and the full stop after "the whole world" is editorial — the manuscript has none there, nor after "one only thing." Newton wrote "(or process)" above the line as a gloss on "the means." The folio heading, three cancelled letters before "fly from you," and Newton's closing cross-references on f. 2v are not reproduced. An earlier printing of this book gave a modernised text ultimately derived from an encyclopedia rather than from the manuscript; this is the manuscript.

## Where it actually comes from

The Tablet is an Arabic text. Its oldest known recension appears in the *Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣanʿat al-Ṭabīʿa*, the *Book of the Secret of Creation and the Art of Nature*, compiled in Arabic in the late eighth or early ninth century. The precise dating is contested in the scholarship: Julius Ruska placed it in the sixth to eighth centuries, Paul Kraus around 813–833, Ursula Weisser around 750–800. The work presents itself as a translation of a treatise by Apollonius of Tyana — Bālīnūs in the Arabic — which is itself a pseudepigraphic frame rather than a real attribution.

The Tablet also appears, in a somewhat shorter version with lines missing, in the *Second Book of the Element of the Foundation* (*Kitāb Uṣṭuqus al-Uss al-Thānī*) attributed to Jābir ibn Ḥayyān. And it turns up in two further Arabic settings: Ibn Umayl's tenth-century *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth*, later translated into Latin as the *Tabula Chemica*, which quotes the Tablet and glosses it clause by clause; and towards the end of the long version of the pseudo-Aristotelian *Sirr al-Asrār*, the *Secret of Secrets*, also tenth century.

That discovery narrative belongs to the *Sirr al-Khalīqa* itself, not to any later source, and it is the origin of the story every popular account repeats. Bālīnūs is directed by an apparition — in Ruska's description, the heavenly archetype of Apollonius in the form of an old man — into a dark subterranean chamber beneath a statue of Hermes, where a figure seated on a throne holds an emerald tablet and a book. It is a literary device of the eighth- or ninth-century Arabic tradition, not a record of an excavation, and it is a vault rather than a pyramid: the pyramid of the popular retellings is a later accretion.

## How it reached Europe

The Latin transmission runs through several independent channels, and knowing which one a given version descends from explains most of the variation between printed texts:

- **Robert of Chester**, 1144 — the *Book on the Composition of Alchemy*, the Latin *Morienus*. Some manuscripts carry an explicit dating the translation to 11 February 1144, and that date is independent of the prologue. It is generally considered the first Latin translation of an Arabic alchemical treatise, and marks the point at which this whole literature enters Europe — but the attribution to Robert is less settled than the date: his name comes only from a prologue which Dapsens concludes is genuinely Robert's work yet was probably not written for this text.
- **The vulgate version**, probably twelfth century, tentatively attributed to Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–1145). It survives embedded in an anonymous Latin compilation of commentaries on the Tablet — known variously as the *Book of Hermes on Alchemy*, the *Book of Dabessus* or the *Book of the Rebis* — itself translated from a now-lost Arabic original. This is the most widely circulated version and the basis of every later edition — including the version behind Newton's English.
- **Hugo of Santalla**, c. 1145–1151 — translated the *Book of the Secret of Creation* itself, and so gives the Tablet closest to its oldest known Arabic form. It does not appear to have circulated widely: the translation survives in a single manuscript contemporary with the translator (Paris, BnF lat. 13951) and one copy, and the Tablet spread in Europe not from this version but from the *Secret of Secrets*.
- **Philip of Tripoli**, thirteenth century — translated the *Secret of Secrets*, which became, by some measures, the most popular book of the Latin Middle Ages, carrying the Tablet along with it.

What appeared in **1541** — in *De Alchemia*, from Johann Petreius at Nuremberg, edited by "Chrysogonus Polydorus", most likely a pseudonym for Andreas Osiander — is what the bibliographic literature calls the *editio princeps* of the Tablet, and it was the first to set the text beside the commentary of Hortulanus; that pairing shaped how the text was read for centuries. It was not, however, the Tablet's first appearance in print. A different Latin version, the one carried inside the *Secret of Secrets*, was already in print by 1501 at the latest — Alessandro Achillini's Bologna edition prints it

complete — and possibly in the incunable editions of the 1480s, though the collations are ambiguous on the alchemy section. The two are not the same translation: the *Secret of Secrets* version opens *Veritas ita se habet et non est dubium*, the vulgate *Verum sine mendacio certum et verissimum*.

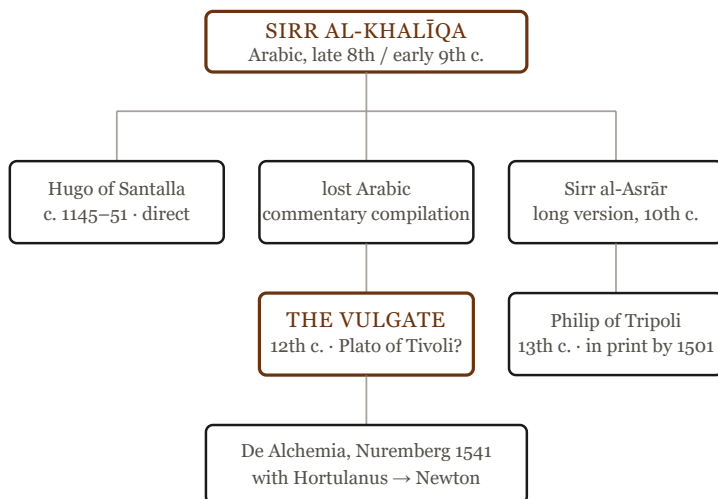


FIG. 4 — HOW THE EMERALD TABLET REACHED EUROPE. Four Latin channels out of one Arabic source, and they do not agree with one another: Hugo translates the *Book of the Secret of Creation* directly but is barely copied; the vulgate, which everyone later reads, arrives embedded in a compilation of commentaries translated from an Arabic original now lost; and the *Secret of Secrets* carries a different rendering into print forty years before the vulgate's own *editio princeps*. Diagram drawn for this book from the transmission set out in this chapter.

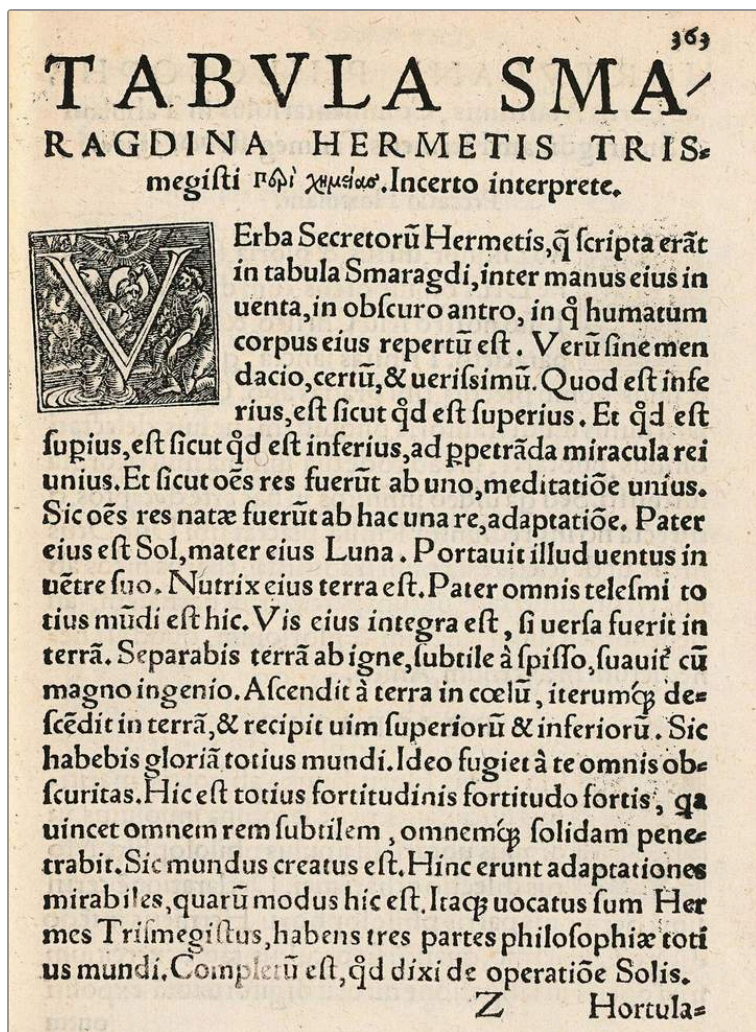


PLATE III — THE TABLET IN PRINT, 1541. The page from *De Alchemia* discussed above — the *editio princeps* of the Tablet as a free-standing text, and the printing that set it beside Hortulanus's commentary for the first time. Petreius, its printer, is the same Nuremberg house that published Copernicus's *De revolutionibus* two years later. Reading the Latin here against the English on the preceding pages is the quickest way to see how much a translator decides.

Johannes Petreius, Nuremberg, 1541. Public domain; digitised by e-rara /  
Zentralbibliothek Zürich, via Wikimedia Commons.

## The commentary tradition

The Tablet's history is largely a history of people disagreeing about what it means, and the disagreement divides along a fault line that runs through this entire book — laboratory or interior.

**Hortulanus** (Ortolanus), about whom almost nothing is known beyond what he says of himself, was probably active in the first half of the fourteenth century. His is the commentary that circulated most widely in print — published with the Tablet in 1541, reprinted in 1545, reissued in 1560 as the *Compendium alchimiae* under Johannes de Garlandia's name, and again in 1571 — and he read the text as an operative one: a cryptic recipe describing laboratory processes under cover names, in which the Sun and Moon stand for alchemical gold and silver. He could not translate the obscure word *telesmus* either. He left it standing and glossed it; in the Elizabethan English of *The Mirror of Alchimy* (London, 1597) the gloss reads that the Philosopher "callesh the worke, the Father of all the Telesme: that is, of all secret, or of all treasure of the whole worlde."

The word was obscure because it was not Latin. The vulgate's translator met the Arabic *ṭilasm*, could not place it, and transliterated it as *telesmus* — the texts spell it variously (*telesmus*, *telesmum*, *telesmi*, *thelesmi*; the 1597 English *telesme*). Behind the Arabic is a Greek word built on the verb *teleō*, to complete or to perform a rite, though the witnesses differ over its form; the same Arabic word reaches English as "talisman." The oldest Arabic recension calls the one thing *abū al-ṭilasmāt*, father of talismans.

**Albertus Magnus** commented on the vulgate in *On Minerals*, around 1250. **Roger Bacon** edited and annotated the Latin *Secret of Secrets* — Philip of Tripoli's version, not a translation of his own — believing it a genuine work of Aristotle. Robert Steele, its 1920 editor, held that Bacon cited it throughout his career; Steven Williams has since argued that the edition belongs to the end of

Bacon's life, around 1280, and Bacon's heavy use of the text is documented from the 1260s rather than from his earliest writings. Either way it illustrates how much intellectual weight a misattribution can carry.

**Johannes Trithemius**, in the early sixteenth century, moved the reading decisively away from the laboratory and toward metaphysics, identifying the Tablet's "one thing" with the Pythagorean monad and the *anima mundi*, the soul of the world. That is an early and influential instance of the metaphysical reading; Debus records it being taken up by Dee, Agrippa and Gerhard Dorn. Whether the twentieth-century psychological readings descend from it or merely resemble it is not something the scholarship establishes.

**Newton** made his own interpretive choice at that same word. Where the Latin vulgate reads *pater omnis telesmi*, Newton's own Latin copy of the Tablet, on a later leaf of the same manuscript, reads *pater omnis perfectionis*, and his English follows it: "The father of all perfection in the whole world is here." The substitution therefore stands in the Latin rather than in an act of Englishing, and whether the reading was his own or one he inherited is not settled. It is worth adding that Newton's commentary in the same manuscript reads the text as chemistry, in terms of mercury and sulphur. The word did not make a cosmologist of him.

## "AS ABOVE, SO BELOW" IS NOT IN THE EMERALD TABLET

The most quoted sentence in Western esotericism is a paraphrase, and a recent one. The vulgate's second verse, in Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer's translation, reads: "*That which is above is like to that which is below, and that which is below is like to that which is above.*" (Witnesses of the vulgate differ over which half comes first; the Latin behind Newton's version above begins with the lower. The sense is unaffected — the verse is symmetrical.) The oldest Arabic recension runs differently again: its second line, *inna al-a' lā min al-asfal wa-l-asfal min al-a' lā*, says that the uppermost is *from* the lowermost and the lowermost *from* the uppermost. (Arabic as edited by Ursula Weisser; the English here is a literal gloss rather than a published translation, and is given without quotation marks for that reason.)

Note that the Arabic says the levels *derive from* each other, where the vulgate says they *resemble* each other. The Latin translators did not agree among themselves: Hugo of Santalla, working directly from the *Book of the Secret of Creation*, has *Superiora de inferioribus, inferiora de superioribus* — "from", not "like" — and the *Secret of Secrets* version has the levels *respondent*, correspond. The vulgate was made from a different and now-lost Arabic compilation, so where the shift entered cannot be established.

The compressed form — "as above, so below" — was popularised by **Helena Blavatsky** in the late nineteenth century, and it was through her that it became the motto of modern occultism and later of the New Age. She does not present it as her own coinage: in *Isis Unveiled* (1877) she introduces it as something the reader already knows — "Remember the Hermetic axiom: 'As above, so below; as in heaven, so on earth'" (vol. 1, p. 294) — and where she translates the verse itself (vol. 1, p. 507) she renders it "What is below is like that which is above," not by the maxim. The wording is not the Tablet's; whether it is hers is not established. This

is the same pattern as the Kybalion of Chapter 1: a modern formulation, elegant and genuinely useful, circulating as an ancient one. The maxim is a fair summary of what the verse says. It is simply not a quotation from it.

## Reading it

Taken on its own terms, the Tablet describes a single process in a single substance. One thing is the origin of all things. It has a father and a mother, so its production requires a union. It must be separated — earth from fire, subtle from gross — and the separation must be done *sweetly, with great industry*, which is to say gradually and with attention rather than by force. It then ascends and descends, gathering the powers of what is above and what is below, and returns changed. The result penetrates everything.

Whether that is an account of a metallurgical operation, of the cosmos, or of a person is precisely the question the commentators have argued for eight hundred years, and the text is constructed so as not to settle it. That ambiguity is not a defect of the writing; on any reading of its purpose, it is the writing. The instruction that survives translation into every register is the one in the middle: separate patiently what has been confused, and expect to have to do it more than once.

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**Sources:** *Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣanʿat al-Ṭabīʿa*, late 8th / early 9th c. (Ruska 1926, p. 166: 6th–8th c.; Kraus 1942, vol. II, pp. 274–75: c. 813–833; Weisser 1980, p. 54: c. 750–800); the vault frame story at Ruska, pp. 166–67. Pseudo-Jābir, *Kitāb Uṣṭuqus al-Uss al-Thānī*. Ibn Umayl, *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth*, 10th c. (Latin *Tabula Chemica*); the Tablet quoted and glossed there at Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, *Ambix* 3 (1949), 69–90, sect. XXI at p. 81. Pseudo-Aristotle, *Sirr al-Asrār*, 10th c. (long version); the Latin text of the Tablet in Robert Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1920), pp. 115–17. Robert of Chester (1144); vulgate version, 12th c., tentatively Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–45); Hugo of Santalla (c. 1145–51), ed. Françoise Hudry, *Chrysopoeia* 6 (1997–99), 1–154; Philip of Tripoli (13th c.). First printing as a free-standing alchemical text: *De Alchemia*, ed. "Chrysogonus Polydorus" (probably Andreas Osiander), Johann Petreius, Nuremberg, 1541, with Hortulanus's commentary — but a different Latin version was already in print inside the *Secretum secretorum* by 1501 at the latest. Hortulanus, probably first half 14th c.; English of his commentary in *The Mirror of Alchimy* (London: printed by Thomas Creede for Richard Olive, 1597). Albertus Magnus, *On Minerals*, c. 1250; Roger Bacon, c. 1275–80, with Steven J. Williams, *Speculum* 69 (1994), 57–73, against Steele's dating; Trithemius, early 16th c., per A. G. Debus, *Alchemy and Early Modern Chemistry* (2004), p. 415. English of the vulgate's second verse: Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer, "The Emerald Table," *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine* 21 (1928), 485–501. Newton's rendering: Keynes MS. 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v, in *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), ALCH00017 public domain. "As above, so below" — popularised by Blavatsky, who quotes it as a received "Hermetic axiom": *Isis Unveiled* (1877), vol. 1, pp. 294, 306, 507.

CHAPTER VI

## Meditation Practices

Meditation is the foundation of everything else in this book. Every other practice here assumes an attention that can be directed and held, and that capacity is not native — it is trained. The ancient texts are explicit that the ascent they describe begins with stillness, and the practical writers of every later period agree. Skipping this chapter to reach the interesting ones is the most common mistake made with material like this, and it reliably produces practitioners who can recite correspondences and cannot sit still for ten minutes.

### Basic technique

1. Find a quiet place to sit, upright but not rigid, where you will not be interrupted.
2. Close your eyes and bring your attention to the breath — not controlling it, simply following it.
3. When thoughts arise, notice them and return attention to the breath. *This is the practice; the returning is not an interruption of it.*
4. Begin with ten to fifteen minutes daily and increase gradually.
5. Be consistent rather than ambitious. Ten minutes every day will take you further in a year than an hour once a week.

Two things worth knowing at the outset. The first is that a session in which you notice fifty distractions is not a failed session — noticing is the skill being built, and fifty noticings is fifty repetitions. The second is that progress in this practice is almost invisible from inside it. What changes is not the quality of the sitting but the quality of the rest of the day.

## **Contemplation of a form**

Once bare attention is reasonably stable, the tradition turns it toward an object. Take one of the forms from Chapter 3 — the circle, the triangle, a single sephirah — and hold it in mind, returning to it as you returned to the breath. The aim is not to think discursively about the symbol but to let it remain in attention until it begins to disclose relations you had not put there.

This is the technique the Hermetic texts assume when they describe knowledge arriving as vision rather than as argument. It is also where honest self-assessment becomes important: the felt sense of profound insight is not evidence of insight, and the practice includes writing down what you thought you saw and reading it again a week later when the atmosphere has worn off.

## **The discipline of the four elements**

A widely used progression takes the elements of Chapter 4 as meditative subjects in turn: sitting with earth as solidity and weight, water as flow and receptivity, air as movement and mediation, fire as transformation. Each is held for a period of days or weeks before moving on. The value of the exercise is diagnostic as much as devotional — most people find one of the four significantly harder than the others, and that difficulty is generally informative.

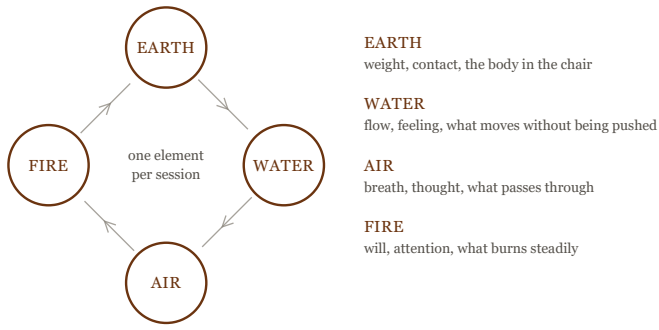


FIG. 1 — THE DISCIPLINE OF THE FOUR ELEMENTS. One element per sitting, in order, returning to earth. The sequence is not arbitrary: it runs from the most tangible to the least, so that attention is trained on something it can hold before being asked to hold something it cannot. Four sessions make one turn of the cycle; the tradition expects many turns. Drawn for this book.

**Vibration**

One technique deserves its own heading because everything ceremonial in this book depends on it, and because it is almost always taught badly. To *vibrate* a divine name is not to say it loudly. It is to sound it so that the body itself carries the sound — chest, throat, the bones of the face — and to hold the meaning of the name in attention while doing so.

The clearest published instruction is also one of the oldest available in English, from Crowley's *Liber O* of 1909, which prints it as a preliminary to assuming a godform:

**VIBRATING A DIVINE NAME — LIBER O (1909)**

1. Stand with arms outstretched.
2. Breathe in deeply through the nostrils, *imagining the name of the God desired entering with the breath.*
3. Let that name descend slowly from the lungs to the heart, the solar plexus, the navel, and so to the feet.
4. The moment it appears to touch the feet, advance the left foot, throw the body forward, and let the hands shoot out from beside the eyes, breathing the name out through the nostrils with all the force of which you are capable.
5. Withdraw the left foot and place the right forefinger upon the lips.

The text adds two tests, and they are worth quoting because they set an unusually concrete standard for a spiritual exercise. The first: it is a sign the student is doing it correctly "when a single 'Vibration' entirely exhausts his physical strength." The second, a sign of success perceptible only to the practitioner, is when the name is heard "vehemently roared forth, as if by the concourse of ten thousand thunders," and appears to proceed "from the Universe, and not from himself."

That is the ceremonial maximum. For ordinary daily practice, a great deal less will do: sound the name on a single sustained out-breath, low in the chest, until the breath runs out, and feel where in the body it resonates. The rest of this book assumes you can do that much. The full form is worth attempting occasionally, if only because it makes the difference between vibrating a name and merely pronouncing one impossible to miss.

## Recording the work

Keep a record. Date each session, note its length, and write a sentence or two on what happened without embellishing it. The reason is practical rather than ceremonial: memory is unreliable about interior states, and it edits in the direction of a good story. A written record is the only means you have of distinguishing genuine development from the impression of it, and it is the closest thing this tradition has to an experimental notebook.

### MODERN PRACTICE

The technique above is essentially what the sources describe, and it needs little updating — but the surrounding context has changed in ways worth naming. Contemporary practitioners have access to a large body of clinical research on meditation that no historical author had, and it broadly supports the basic claims about attention, stress response and emotional regulation while saying nothing either way about the metaphysics. Many now use timers or apps for the practical business of sitting, which is a straightforward improvement over guessing. The one genuinely modern caution: intensive practice can destabilise people with certain psychiatric histories, a risk the historical literature does not discuss because it had no framework for it. If you have a history of dissociation, psychosis or severe trauma, extend the timelines and work with a professional rather than alone.

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**Sources:** The vibration exercise is Aleister Crowley, *Liber O vel Manus et Sagittae sub figura VI*, section III, first printed in *The Equinox* I, no. 2 (1909) public domain; the quoted phrases are his. The remaining practices in this chapter are described rather than quoted, and are common to the contemplative literature of several traditions; no single historical source is claimed for them.

## CHAPTER VII

## Ritual Foundations

Ritual is structured action undertaken to mark, focus and contain a piece of inner work. Its function is to establish a boundary in time and space: within these words and this hour, attention is on one thing only. That framing is what does the work, and it is why ritual structure is remarkably consistent across traditions that share no content at all.

### The basic structure

1. **Preparation** — cleanse yourself and the space. Bathe; clear the room of clutter and interruption; put away anything not needed. Historically this stage was elaborate: the *Key of Solomon* devotes considerable attention to ablution, abstinence and prayer before any operation begins.
2. **Opening** — define the space and invoke protection. This is the circle of Chapter 3 made operational, and it is where a banishing such as the one in Chapter 12 is normally performed.
3. **Main work** — the central action: a meditation, a contemplation, a stated intention, a consecration.
4. **Closing** — give thanks, and close the circle deliberately. Closing matters as much as opening. A ritual left open is a working left unfinished, and in practical terms it means the frame that was meant to contain the work now has nothing to contain it.

## **Why the frame works**

It is worth being clear about the mechanism, because the tradition is not, at its better moments, mystifying about it. A ritual makes an intention expensive. It requires preparation, time, specific words in a specific order, and the deliberate exclusion of everything else. Anything held to that standard is held with a seriousness that a passing wish cannot reach. The consistency of ritual structure across unconnected cultures is easier to explain by the reliability of that effect than by any shared descent.

This is also why the historical sources are so insistent on precision. Instructions about the hour, the direction faced, the material of an instrument, the exact form of words — these are not arbitrary hurdles. They are the means by which an action is made deliberate. Whether one takes the planetary hours of the Solomonic literature literally or as a discipline of timing, the effect on the operator is much the same.

## **Tools**

The traditional instruments — knife, wand, cup, disc, censer, lamp — correspond to the elements and to the functions of a working: to divide, to direct, to receive, to establish. The grimoire tradition specifies their making and consecration in great detail, often requiring specific materials, timings and inscriptions.

Two practical notes. First, tools are not required to begin; a clear space, an hour and a stated intention are sufficient, and every historical tradition contains practitioners who worked with almost nothing. Second, where the historical instructions call for animal sacrifice, blood, or materials obtained by harming anything, they should be read as history and not followed — the ethical position set out in Chapter 1 takes precedence over textual fidelity, and no serious modern practice depends on those elements.

## Washing, and what it is for

Nearly every operative text in this tradition begins with a bath. The *Key of Solomon* devotes a chapter to it: go to running water, or have warm water ready in a private room, and recite psalms while undressing — Psalm 27, *The Lord is my light and my salvation*, among them. The garments are then linen, or silk if you can afford it, and white; the book specifies that linen thread should have been spun by a young woman, which is the sort of detail that tells you the text is early modern rather than ancient.

What the washing is *for* is worth stating without mystification, because the tradition is not consistent about it and the modern practitioner has to decide. Read one way it is purification in a literal sense. Read another it is a boundary marker: the point at which ordinary time stops. The second reading is the one that survives translation into a life with plumbing, and it is the reason the instruction is worth keeping even if you do not believe the first. Wash, deliberately, before you begin. Put on something you wear for nothing else.

### THE EXORCISM OF THE WATER, FOR THE BATH

From the *Key of Solomon*, Book II, chapter 5. Undressing, the operator recites Psalms 27, 54, 69, the Song of the Sea (Exodus 15), and 106. Entering the water, they say:

*I exorcise thee, O creature of Water, by him who hath created thee and gathered thee together into one place so that the dry land appeared, that thou uncover all the deceits of the enemy, and that thou cast out from me all impurity and uncleanness, so that no phantasm may enter therein.*

Then dress in the consecrated garment and cense yourself before beginning.

## Consecrating water and salt

This is the most useful single operation in the grimoire literature, because the result — a bowl of salted water — is what every subsequent purification uses. The *Key of Solomon* gives it in Book II, and what follows is that procedure, with the text as Mathers printed it in 1889.

### THE CONSECRATION OF WATER AND SALT

1. Prepare the censer in the day and hour of Mercury, with the incense of the art (see Chapter 17 for reckoning the hour).
2. Take a vessel of tin or earthenware and fill it with clear spring water. Have salt ready.
3. Say over the salt:  
*TZABAOth, MESSIACH, EMANUEL, ELOHIM GIBOR,  
YOD HE VAU HE; O God, who art the Truth and the Life,  
deign to bless and sanctify this creature of salt, to serve unto  
us for help, protection and assistance in this art, experiment  
and operation, and may it be a succour unto us.*
4. Cast the salt into the water, and say Psalms 102, 54, 6 and 51.
5. Make a sprinkler of vervain, fennel, periwinkle, sage, valerian, mint, marjoram, basil and rosemary, gathered in the day and hour of Mercury with the Moon increasing, and bind it with thread spun for the purpose.

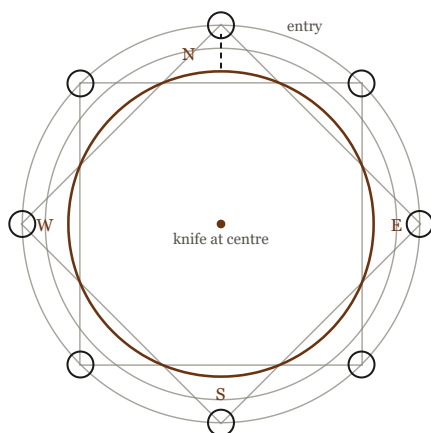
Two notes on the text. The divine names in step three vary considerably between manuscripts — Mathers's reading is given above; other witnesses have *Zeuaod*, *Messiah*, *Jehova*, *Nghimmanuel*, *Nghelion*, *Gibor* and several further variants, which is characteristic of this literature and a reminder that no

single wording is *the* wording. And the psalm numbers are given here in the English numbering; the manuscripts use the Vulgate numbering, which runs one lower through most of the Psalter.

If you keep nothing else from the operative tradition, keep this: consecrated water, made deliberately, sprinkled at the start of a working and used to close it. It costs a bowl and five minutes and it does the work that elaborate ceremony is usually reaching for.

## **The circle**

The *Key of Solomon's* circle is a construction of some complexity, and it is worth seeing in full before deciding what to do with it. Book II, chapter 9: drive the knife into the centre of the working place; take a cord of nine feet; describe the circumference. Mark four regions within it, east, west, south and north. Beyond that circle describe another, leaving an opening toward the north to enter and leave by; beyond that a third at a foot's distance, with the same opening; and beyond these, pentagrams with the names of the Creator, surrounding the whole. Then a square outside the circles, and a second square set at forty-five degrees to the first so that its angles point to the four quarters, with a censer of lighted charcoal at each of the eight corners.



nine-foot cord  
 three concentric circles  
 two squares, offset 45°  
 eight censers at the corners  
 names of God between the rims  
 one opening, to the north

FIG. 3 — THE CIRCLE OF THE *KEY OF SOLOMON*. Book II, chapter 9, drawn to the text's own specification. The figure is included not because anyone is likely to build it but because it makes the logic visible: a marked centre, a bounded interior, a single controlled entrance, the quarters distinguished, and divine names at the perimeter. Every practical modern circle abbreviates this. Drawn for this book.

That is a nine-foot radius, an eighteen-foot circle, and eight burning censers. Almost nobody has ever done it. What the description does establish is the *logic* of a circle in this tradition: a marked centre, a definite boundary, a controlled point of entry, the quarters distinguished, and the names of God at the perimeter. Every practical modern circle is an abbreviation of that logic, and the abbreviation is legitimate as long as you know which parts you are abbreviating.

## A working rite you can actually perform

What follows is **this book's own synthesis**, not a historical text — assembled from the elements above and from the banishing of Chapter 12, and offered because a grimoire that describes procedures without ever putting one together is not much use. Every component is dated in the sources line; the arrangement is modern and is mine.

## OPENING

1. **Prepare.** Wash. Put on the garment. Clear the space and set out what the working needs — no more than that.
2. **Set the centre.** Stand where the work will be done. Three slow breaths. Say, aloud, in your own words, what this hour is for. Aloud matters; the difference between a stated intention and a held one is most of what ritual is doing.
3. **Purify.** Sprinkle the consecrated water at the four quarters and over yourself, beginning in the east and moving sunwise.
4. **Mark the boundary.** Walk the circle sunwise, tracing it with the hand or the knife, returning to where you began. See it as a boundary of light, closed and complete.
5. **Banish.** Perform the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram (Chapter 12), or, if you do not use it, name the four quarters in turn and ask that the space be clear.
6. **Light and incense.** Kindle the lamp, then the censer. The *Key of Solomon* exorcises the fire before the incense goes on it; the practical residue is that you light the fire attentively rather than absently.

## CLOSING

1. **Finish the work.** Stop before you are tired, not after.
2. **Give thanks,** in whatever terms you honestly hold — to the source of the work, and to anything you called on.
3. **Banish again.** The same rite as at the opening. The closing banishing is the one practitioners skip and the one that matters: it is what returns the space to ordinary use.
4. **Open the circle.** Walk it widdershins, or simply declare it open, and mean it.
5. **Extinguish** the lamp and the coals. Check them.
6. **Ground.** Eat something. Write down what happened before you interpret it. See Chapter 12.

Twenty minutes, and it is a complete ceremonial frame. Elaboration is available in every direction — a longer purification, a full Solomonic circle, planetary timing, consecrated instruments — and none of it is a substitute for having done the short form regularly.



### Ritual Safety

Begin with simple rituals and work up gradually. Do not attempt advanced or evocatory rituals without proper preparation and grounding. Practical matters deserve equal attention: open flames and candles want a stable surface and a clear space above them, incense wants ventilation, and long periods kneeling or standing in one position want a realistic assessment of your own body. The commonest injuries in ceremonial practice are burns and falls, not spiritual ones.

## MODERN PRACTICE

Where the historical sources assume a private room, a full night, and access to consecrated ground, most contemporary practitioners have a bedroom and forty minutes. The adaptations are sensible and near-universal: shortened forms of the longer rituals, electric light where open flame is unsafe or prohibited, substituted materials where the traditional ones are unobtainable, protected or endangered. Many practitioners now work seasonally rather than by planetary hour, simply because a calendar is easier to keep than an ephemeris. What has not changed — and what the modern shortcuts most often lose — is the deliberate closing. Practitioners who abbreviate a ritual almost always abbreviate the end of it, and that is the one part the sources treat as non-negotiable.

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**Sources:** *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th; see Chapter 9), trans. S. L. MacGregor Mathers as *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) public domain — Book II, ch. 5 for the bath, its psalms and the exorcism of the water, ch. 6 for the garments, ch. 8 for the instruments, ch. 9 for the circle, ch. 10 for the incense and the exorcism of fire, ch. 11 for the consecration of water and salt and for the sprinkler. Manuscript variants of the divine names in the salt formula are recorded in Joseph H. Peterson's edition of Mathers's text. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book III, for ceremonial framing. The opening and closing rite given above is this book's own arrangement of those elements and is not a historical text.

## CHAPTER VIII

**The Greek Magical Papyri**

Everything else in this book is a reconstruction, an interpretation, or a tradition about a tradition. This chapter is different. The Greek Magical Papyri are the working papers of practising magicians of the Graeco-Roman world, written on papyrus in their own hands, surviving in museum cases in London, Paris, Berlin and Leiden. They are not a later account of what ancient magic might have been. They are ancient magic, in its own words, with the abbreviations and marginal notes still in place.

Scholars call the collection the *Papyri Graecae Magicae*, abbreviated PGM. The extant texts run from the late fourth century BCE — PGM XL, the curse of Artemisia, an isolated early outlier — and the first century BCE, down to the fifth century CE, with Christian magical texts extending into the sixth on a dating that should be treated as provisional. The bulk of the corpus, however, is **third to fifth century CE**, and it is worth holding that concentration in mind: this is predominantly the magic of late Roman Egypt, not of the Ptolemies. The texts are written mostly in ancient Greek, but also in Demotic Egyptian, in Old Coptic, and in passages of hieratic script and cipher. Individual texts are cited by volume and item number, so that PGM IV. 1266 refers to a specific line of a specific papyrus, the way one would cite any other classical text.

**How they came to light**

There was never an ancient library called "the Greek Magical Papyri." The corpus is a modern scholarly assembly, and knowing how it was put together matters for reading it. The papyri surfaced through the antiquities trade from the eighteenth century onward. The largest single group — the so-called Anastasi collection — was assembled by Jean d'Anastasi, who was vice-

consul and from 1828 Consul-General of Sweden and Norway at Alexandria, as well as a grain merchant and antiquities dealer at the court of the Ottoman viceroy Muhammad Ali Pasha. He acquired the papyri through local agents at an unknown date before 1828; the first documented transfer is the purchase of the collection, consigned to Livorno in 1826, by the Dutch government in 1828 for the Rijksmuseum van Oudheden at Leiden. He said he had obtained them at Thebes, modern Luxor, and further material went to the British Museum, the Louvre, the Bibliothèque Nationale and the Staatliche Museen in Berlin.

Hans Dieter Betz, who edited the standard English translation, suggests — hedged, and as one of two possibilities alongside a temple library — that about half a dozen of the Anastasi papyri may have come from the collection of a single Theban scholar-bibliophile. The ownership of what is now called the Theban Magical Library remains disputed, and other scholars argue for multiple collectors rather than one. What is not disputed is that the same Theban material included Leyden papyrus X and the Stockholm papyrus, both of them alchemical — fourth-century codices written in the same hand, or very nearly, as PGM XIII. (Two Leiden papyri are easily confused and should not be: Leiden X, P. Leid. I 397, is the alchemical one; Leiden W, P. Leid. I 395, is PGM XIII. The Stockholm papyrus, P. Holm., is now in the Kungliga Biblioteket.) That detail is worth pausing on: the alchemy of Chapter 4 and the magic of this chapter came out of the same context. In late antique Egypt these were not separate disciplines.

Publication was slow, piecemeal and, in one instance, tragic. The first pieces of the corpus into print were PGM XL in 1826 (Petrettini) and PGM XIV in 1843 (Leemans). PGM XII and XIII — often wrongly said to have come first — were described in selections by C. J. C. Reuvens in his *Lettres à M. Letronne* (1830) and published in full, Greek text with Latin translation and commentary, by Conrad Leemans in 1885. The first scholarly publication in English is credited to Charles Wycliffe Goodwin, who translated PGM V with commentary for the Cambridge Antiquarian Society in **1852**. The critical edition is Karl Preisendanz's, published in two volumes in 1928 and 1931. A projected third volume, containing new texts and the indices, reached galley

proofs with a preface dated "Pentecost 1941"; Teubner's Leipzig house was bombed on 4 December 1943. The proofs themselves survived and circulated as photocopies — most papyrological institutes hold the volume — and the 1941 preface was reprinted in the second edition. A revised edition, with Albert Henrichs, appeared in 1973–74, incorporating the lost third volume's papyri but omitting the indices. Betz's English translation, including the Demotic texts, was published by the University of Chicago Press in 1986. Preisendanz's numbering runs to PGM LXXXI; later finds have been given further numbers by convention.

## What is in them

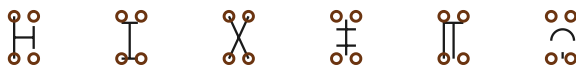
Most of these fragments are pages from spell books. Broadly they fall into two kinds. Some are compilations assembled by collectors — scholarly gatherings of magical writing, made out of interest or for study. Others read like the working manuals of travelling practitioners: a repertoire, formulae for all occasions, the common phrases abbreviated because the owner already knew them by heart.

The range is much wider than the popular image of ancient magic allows. There are summonings of gods and daemons of real gravity, and there are parlour tricks. There are fatal curses and there are love charms. There are cures for impotence and remedies for minor medical complaints. There are folk recipes sitting on the same page as elaborate theurgy. The best known single text in the whole corpus is the invocation now generally called the Mithras Liturgy — a sustained ritual of ascent, and the piece most often anthologised.

Certain features recur throughout and are worth recognising on sight:

- *Voces magicæ* — strings of words with no meaning in Greek, Egyptian or Hebrew, to be spoken exactly as written. Their power was understood to lie in the sound and the precision, not in any sense they carried.

- **Charaktêres** — written signs resembling letters with small circles at their terminals, used as a script of their own.
- **Assumption of a divine identity** — rituals in which the practitioner takes on the identity of a deity, through invocation and visualisation, as part of an ascent or an operation.
- **Figurines** — repeatedly referenced, in judicial, erotic and curse workings alike, made of materials chosen to suit the spell. Surviving examples turn up across the Mediterranean, generally in places the Greeks associated with the underworld: graves, sanctuaries, bodies of water. Some were found inside lead coffins with the spell inscribed on the outside.
- **Prayers** alongside all of it, including the Prayer of Thanksgiving — a text that also turns up among the Nag Hammadi Hermetica.




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letter-like forms, terminating in small rings

FIG. 1 — *CHARAKTÊRES*. The signs that recur through the papyri and on curse tablets: shapes built like letters but belonging to no alphabet, each stroke ending in a small ring. They are not a cipher for words and no one has read them. The forms drawn here are schematic — the point is the visual grammar, not any particular sign, and reproducing actual sequences from a working papyrus is outside what this chapter does. Drawn for this book.

The formulae are often strikingly close to those found on *defixiones* — curse tablets or binding spells, *katadesmoi* in Greek — inscribed on ostraka, amulets and sheets of lead. Some of those tablets date from as early as the late sixth and early fifth centuries BCE — the oldest are Sicilian, from Selinous and probably Himera — and they have been recovered from Sicily, Athens, Asia Minor, Rome and Egypt, in over a thousand texts. Some collections frame the

corpus more conservatively as fifth century BCE to fifth century CE. That continuity matters: it means the papyri are not an Egyptian curiosity but a window onto practice across the Graeco-Roman world.

## **The Headless Rite**

One text from the papyri is printed here in full, and the decision to print it needs stating. The rest of this chapter is descriptive, for the reason given below. This one is an exception because it is the single most consequential text in the corpus for everything later in this book — the ancestor of the ceremonial tradition of Chapter 11 and Chapter 12 — and because it asks nothing of anybody but the operator.

It is PGM V. 96–172, an exorcism. The translation is Charles Wycliffe Goodwin's, made for the Cambridge Antiquarian Society in 1852 and long out of copyright — the first scholarly publication of any part of this corpus in English, and the same edition this chapter cites above.

### AN ADDRESS TO THE GOD DRAWN UPON THE LETTER

I call thee, the headless one, that didst create earth and heaven, that didst create night and day, thee the creator of light and darkness. Thou art Osoronnophris, whom no man hath seen at any time; thou art Iabas, thou art Iapos, thou hast distinguished the just and the unjust, thou didst make female and male, thou didst produce seeds and fruits, thou didst make men to love one another and to hate one another. I am Moses thy prophet, to whom thou didst commit thy mysteries, the ceremonies of Israel; thou didst produce the moist and the dry and all manner of food. Listen to me: I am an angel of Phapro Osoronnophris; this is thy true name, handed down to the prophets of Israel. Listen to me, ... hear me and drive away this spirit.

I call thee the terrible and invisible god residing in the empty wind, ... thou headless one, deliver such an one from the spirit that possesses him. ... strong one, headless one, deliver such an one from the spirit that possesses him.

The gaps are in the printed translation, where the papyrus is damaged or Goodwin left the magical names untransliterated. The Greek continues with the passage the modern tradition took up: *egō eimi ho akephalos daimōn en tois posin echōn tēn horasin* — "I am the headless daemon, having sight in my feet."

## IT IS THE HEADLESS RITE, NOT THE BORNLESS RITE

Modern occultism knows this text as the *Bornless Ritual*, and under that name it has been one of the most widely performed pieces of ceremonial magic of the last century. The Greek word is *aképhalos*: *a-*, without, and *kephalē*, head. Goodwin translated it correctly in 1852 as "the headless one," and the rite's own imagery — a daemon with its sight in its feet — only makes sense of a figure that has no head.

"Bornless" is not what the word says. This book does not attempt to establish how the reading arose, because it could not verify the usual account; what can be shown is only that the earliest English translation says headless, that the Greek says headless, and that the popular name says something else. That is the pattern of Fig. 1 in miniature — a modern rendering circulating as the ancient one — and it is a fitting thing to find in the one genuinely ancient chapter of this book.

## A syncretism, not a survival

The religion of the papyri is a genuine blend rather than a pure inheritance. Greek, Egyptian, Jewish and later Christian elements sit together, sometimes in a single formula. Olympian gods take on the attributes of Egyptian counterparts, or Egyptian deities are addressed by Greek names — Aphrodite, associated with Hathor, is given the epithet *Neferihri*, from the Egyptian *nfr-iry.t*, "nice eyes" (PGM IV. 1266). Betz observes that the Greek gods here are frequently not the Hellenised aristocrats of contemporary literature but something closer to the figures of folklore: chthonic, demonic, dangerous.

Betz's own summary is careful about what this mixture represents: in it, he writes, the indigenous Egyptian religion "has in part survived, in part been profoundly hellenized," reduced and simplified to ease its assimilation — while Greek traditions were in turn Egyptianised. He is candid that the Jewish material resists explanation, calling its origin and nature "far from clear." He concludes that what we have is specifically a Greco-Egyptian syncretism

rather than a general Greco-Roman one. Janet H. Johnson made the complementary point in 1996: the texts cannot be fully understood from the Greek alone, because the Demotic passages carry part of the argument.

The papyri also sit at the centre of a live scholarly disagreement that any honest reader should know about. Betz treats them as a fraction of a much larger lost literature, a kind of "underground literature" subject to book-burning — citing Acts 19:19, Augustus's order to burn magical books reported by Suetonius, and later Christian burnings. David Frankfurter reads them very differently: as the productions of innovative members of the Egyptian priesthood during the third- and fourth-century collapse of the temple infrastructure, and therefore far less "underground" than Betz allows. Alan F. Segal goes further still, using the hymns embedded in these supposedly magical texts to question whether the distinction between magic and religion holds up at all in the Hellenistic world. The people who copied these pages, on Segal's reading, saw no such line.

### **WHY THIS CHAPTER IS NOT A SET OF INSTRUCTIONS**

With the one exception printed above, the PGM are presented here descriptively, and deliberately so. These are historical documents whose interest lies in what they tell us about the people who wrote them — their cosmology, their anxieties, their remarkable willingness to file a summoning of a god next to a cure for a headache. The line this book draws is not between safe and unsafe texts but between operations that act on the operator and operations aimed at somebody else. Reproducing a binding spell against a named person would not make this book more authentic; it would only make it worse. The Headless Rite is on the other side of that line, and is given in full for the reason set out there. Read them as what they are: the most direct access we have to the ancient practice that everything later in this tradition claims to descend from.

**Sources:** Preisendanz, *Papyri Graecae Magicae*, 2 vols (1928, 1931; vol. 3 reached galley proof, preface dated Pentecost 1941, Teubner's Leipzig house bombed 4 Dec 1943, proofs surviving in photocopy; 2nd ed. with Henrichs, 1973–74) — vol. 1 available at the Internet Archive. Betz (ed.), *The Greek Magical Papyri in Translation, Including the Demotic Spells* (University of Chicago Press, 1986; 2nd ed. 1992) — in copyright. Charles Wycliffe Goodwin, *Fragment of a Graeco-Egyptian Work upon Magic, from a Papyrus in the British Museum* (Cambridge Antiquarian Society, 1852) public domain — the first scholarly publication of any part of the corpus in English, and the source of the Headless Rite as printed above, PGM V. 96–172. Earlier partial publication: Petrettini, PGM XL (1826); Reuvsen, *Lettres à M. Letronne* (1830); Leemans, PGM XIV (1843) and PGM XII–XIII in full (1885). Frankfurter, "Ritual Expertise in Roman Egypt and the Problem of the Category 'Magician'" (1997). Segal, "Hellenistic Magic: Some Questions of Definition" (1981). Fowden, *The Egyptian Hermes* (1986). Christopher A. Faraone and Sofia Torallas Tovar (eds), *Greek and Egyptian Magical Formularies*, vol. I (California Classical Studies, 2022) — open access; renumbers the formularies and supersedes Preisendanz. Jessica L. Lamont, "Orality, Written Literacy, and Early Sicilian Curse Tablets," *Greece & Rome* 69, no. 1 (2022), 27–51, for the dating and provenance of the earliest tablets.

## CHAPTER IX

**The Solomonic Tradition**

If the Greek Magical Papyri are ancient magic without a famous name attached, the Solomonic literature is the reverse: a large, influential and genuinely important body of texts attached to a name that did not write any of them. Every book in this tradition is pseudepigraphic — attributed to King Solomon, composed many centuries after him, by authors who are almost entirely anonymous. That is not a scandal to be exposed. It was a convention of the genre, and a claim about authority rather than a claim about history. But it does mean that the phrase "the magic of Solomon" describes a literary lineage, not a Judaeic one.

**The Key of Solomon**

The *Clavicula Salomonis*, the *Key of Solomon*, is the central text. It probably dates to the fourteenth or fifteenth century, in the Italian Renaissance, and it is a model example of Renaissance magic — heavily ceremonial, concerned with purification and consecrated instruments, framed throughout in devotional Christian language. Its introduction supplies the traditional legend: that Solomon wrote the book for his son Rehoboam. That is the document's backstory, not its provenance.

The manuscript tradition is rich and worth knowing, because "the *Key of Solomon*" is not one fixed book but a family of related texts that differ from copy to copy. The surviving manuscripts date mostly from the late sixteenth to the eighteenth century. Among the notable witnesses are a fifteenth-century Greek manuscript in the British Library (Harley MS 5596), an important Italian manuscript in the Bodleian (Michael MS 276) of around 1600, and an English translation, "The Clavicle of Solomon, revealed by Ptolomy the Grecian," dated 1572. The Greek text is generally known separately as the

*Magical Treatise of Solomon*; Armand Delatte transcribed one Athens manuscript of it in his *Anecdota Atheniensia* (1927) — not, it should be said, the Harley manuscript. Its contents closely resemble the *Clavicula*. Priority is not finally settled, but the specialist literature leans to the Greek as the ancestral form, and it is almost certain that the earliest Western version was translated from it.

The version most modern readers have met is S. L. MacGregor Mathers's English edition of **1889**, based on manuscripts in the British Museum — the British Library did not exist until 1973, and the anachronism is a common one. Mathers's edition is important for a reason beyond its scholarship: he was one of the three founders of the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, and it was largely through him that this medieval and early-modern material entered modern ceremonial practice. Nearly every twentieth-century magical order that uses circles, pentacles and consecrated tools is drawing, at some remove, on Mathers's reading of these manuscripts.

The practical content of the *Key* is broadly consistent across versions. It concerns the preparation of the operator through ablution, abstinence and prayer; the drawing of the circle as the defined space of the working; the making and consecration of instruments — knife, wand, censer, parchment — each with its own procedure and timing; the planetary hours governing when a given operation may be attempted; and the pentacles, the engraved figures that give the tradition its visual signature.

### **The Lesser Key, or Lemegeton**

The *Lesser Key of Solomon* is a separate and later compilation, assembled in the **mid-seventeenth century** from materials several centuries older. Despite the name it is not an abridgement of the *Key*; it is its own anthology, in five books:

1. ***Ars Goetia*** — the evocation of seventy-two spirits, each with a name, a rank and a sigil. This is the part of the *Lemegeton* that everyone has heard of, and the part that has done most to shape the popular idea of grimoire magic.

2. *Ars Theurgia Goetia* — spirit princes organised by the points of the compass.
3. *Ars Paulina* — angels assigned to the hours of the day and to the degrees of the zodiac.
4. *Ars Almadel* — angelic contact by means of a wax tablet and scrying.
5. *Ars Notoria* — prayers to strengthen memory, eloquence and understanding.

The layering here is instructive. The *Ars Notoria* is substantially older than the compilation that contains it: Véronèse's critical edition traces it from a thirteenth-century version A through a glossed version that appeared at the end of the thirteenth century and survives in three fourteenth-century manuscripts, with the core *Flores aurei* possibly redacted as early as the later twelfth. What survives as book five is a seventeenth-century composite of that older material. And the *Ars Goetia*, the most notorious section, has a traceable and rather deflating pedigree. Its ultimate ancestor is the list in Johann Weyer's *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum* — but not directly. The proximate source is the English translation printed in Reginald Scot's *Discoverie of Witchcraft*, which Peterson attributes to Abraham Fleming rather than to Scot, and whose exemplar he identifies as the expanded edition of 1665, established by the unique errors and spellings that edition introduced. As Peterson puts it, the *Goetia* "does, in fact, seem dependant on Scot, faithfully copying his frequent mistranslations, elaborations, and omissions." The list is reordered, four spirits added and one dropped.

Weyer's own purpose is the sharpest irony in this chapter. Johann Weyer (1515–1588) was a Dutch physician — city physician of Arnhem, later court doctor to the Duke of Cleves — and he catalogued demons in the course of arguing *against* the witch trials. His *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563) criticised the *Malleus Maleficarum* and the witch-hunting of the civil and ecclesiastical authorities, and he was among the first to publish systematic arguments against the persecutions. His position was narrower than it is usually reported to be, and the precision matters. Weyer *affirmed* the reality and power of demons — fallen angels who used supernatural powers against

the kingdom of Heaven and who needed no human help — and concluded on that ground that the pact was pointless and legally void. What he voided was the pact and the *maleficia*, not the devil. He allowed that alleged acts might be fraud or poisoning, did not object to judicial enquiry of accused witches, and attributed apparently supernatural illness variously to melancholy, poisoning, malingering or unmediated demonic action. He also held learned magicians genuinely culpable, accusing popes, bishops, priests and monks of being magicians in league with the devil — one historian judges him "determined to find a theory by which to inculcate magicians, far more than ... to construct a theory by which to exculpate women."

He was also, from about the age of fourteen, a live-in student of Agrippa's in Antwerp — which is why his denunciation of the spurious *Fourth Book* carried weight. So the most notorious demon-catalogue in Western magic was compiled by a sceptical physician trying to stop people being burned, by a man who had studied under Agrippa and defended his teacher's actual work against forgery. It was then lifted, more or less wholesale, into the working grimoire that has carried it ever since.

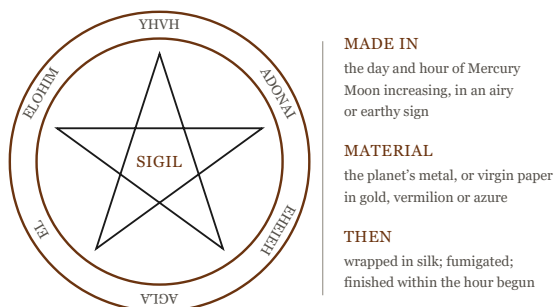


FIG. 1 — THE FORM OF A SOLOMONIC PENTACLE. Not a reproduction of any particular pentacle, but the shape they share: two concentric rings with divine names written in the space between them, and a figure or sigil at the centre. The names used here are the four of the banishing in Chapter 12 plus two more; the *Key of Solomon* tells the operator to choose names "which thou shalt think fit and proper" for the work in hand, so no fixed set exists. The conditions at the right are the text's own, and are set out in full in Chapter 17. Drawn for this book.

## Agrippa and the Renaissance transmission

The channel through which all of this reached later practitioners is Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486–1535), whose *De occulta philosophia libri tres* is the single most important synthesis of Renaissance magical thought. Book I appeared in 1531, published at Paris, Cologne and Antwerp; the complete three books followed at Cologne in **1533**. The English translation by "J.F." — probably John French, possibly James Freake — appeared in 1651 and is the version through which the work entered the English-speaking tradition.

The three books ascend deliberately through the levels of a magical cosmos. Book I treats natural or elemental magic: the properties of stones, herbs, animals and the human body, and the "occult virtues" Agrippa held to arise from hidden correspondences between the material world and higher

principles. Book II treats celestial magic — stellar and planetary influence, and the construction of talismans to capture it. Book III treats intellectual or divine magic: theurgy, Kabbalah, ceremonial practice. Agrippa insists throughout that the true magus must also be a devout priest-philosopher, and he draws a firm line between holy magic and demonic sorcery, *goetia*.

That line is worth holding on to, because the *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* crosses it. Its earliest known imprint is Marburg, 1559 — twenty-four years after Agrippa's death — and it was falsely attributed to him, and contains explicit spirit-summoning instructions of a kind entirely absent from the authentic three books. Weyer, Agrippa's own former student, identified it as a forgery. Much of what circulates as "Agrippa" in later grimoire literature is in fact this spurious fourth book — which means readers have often taken a pseudonymous appendix for the thing it was attached to.

### WHAT THE DATINGS ADD UP TO

Laid end to end, the Solomonic tradition runs: a legend of Solomon; a fourteenth- or fifteenth-century Italian text claiming him as author; a sixteenth-century sceptic's demon catalogue; a seventeenth-century compilation that absorbed it; a spurious fourth book attached to a genuine 1533 masterwork; and a nineteenth-century translation by a founder of the Golden Dawn, through which the whole assemblage reached the modern world. Not one link in that chain is ancient. Every link is real, documented, and has a date. That is a more interesting story than the legend, and it is a true one.

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**Sources:** *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th; Mathiesen 2007) — MSS incl. Bodleian Michael 276 and BL Sloane 3847 (English, 1572); Mathers (trans.), *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) public domain. Delatte, *Anecdota Atheniensia* (1927), pp. 397–445, for one Athens manuscript of the Greek *Magical Treatise of Solomon*, whose sixteen or seventeen witnesses include BL Harley 5596; fuller editions in Torijano (2002) and Marathakis (2011). *Lemegeton / Lesser Key of Solomon*, mid-17th c.; Crowley's 1904 *Goetia* (Book One only, Mathers's translation uncredited) public domain; Peterson (ed.), *The Lesser Key of Solomon* (2001) for the whole five-book work. Weyer, *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum*, appended to *De praestigiis daemonum* from the fifth edition (Basel, 1577). Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia libri tres* (Book I 1531; complete Cologne 1533); trans. "J.F." (1651) public domain. *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* — spurious.

CHAPTER X

## Rosicrucian Mysteries

The Rosicrucian tradition is the most influential body of Western esoteric thought whose founding organisation probably never existed. That sentence needs stating plainly at the outset, because almost everything written about the Rosicrucians for four hundred years has depended on which half of it the writer chose to emphasise. The manifestos are real, dated and enormously consequential. The Brotherhood they describe cannot be shown to have existed at all.

### The three manifestos

Three anonymous texts appeared in Germany and then across Europe in quick succession:

- ***Fama Fraternitatis Rosae Crucis*** (The Fame of the Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross) — circulating in manuscript among German occultists from around 1610, and published at Cassel in **1614**. It announces the existence of a secret brotherhood and narrates the travels, education and death of a figure called "Father Brother C.R.C."
- ***Confessio Fraternitatis*** (The Confession of the Brotherhood of R.C.) — printed at Cassel by Wilhelm Wessel in **1615**, in Latin, appended to Philippus a Gabella's *Secretioris Philosophiae Consideratio brevis*, responding to the confusion and criticism the *Fama* had provoked and elaborating the programme further.
- ***The Chymical Wedding of Christian Rosenkreutz*** — published in **1616**: an allegorical romance in seven days, structurally quite unlike the two documents preceding it.

What they promised was a universal reformation of humanity, by means of a science built on esoteric truths of the ancient past — knowledge concealed from ordinary understanding that offered insight into nature, the physical universe and the spiritual realm, and which had supposedly been kept secret until the intellectual climate was ready for it. The programme was set out extensively but cryptically, in the languages of Qabalah, Hermeticism, alchemy and Christian mysticism — precisely the subjects the learned readership of the period was studying most avidly. The stated aims were the ones the earlier version of this chapter listed, and they are worth keeping: universal reformation, the advance of spiritual and scientific knowledge, the healing of the sick, and the teaching of divine wisdom.

### **The legend of C.R.C.**

As the manifestos tell it, Christian Rosenkreuz was born in 1378 and lived 106 years. He studied in the Middle East under a succession of masters — a detail that has invited speculation about Sufi influence, which shaped a number of Western esoteric currents. During his lifetime the order was said to comprise no more than eight members, each of them a physician and all "bachelors of vowed virginity." Each swore to heal the sick without accepting payment, to keep the fellowship secret, and to find a replacement for himself before he died. Three such generations were said to have passed between about 1500 and about 1600 — by which time, the *Fama* claims, scientific, philosophical and religious liberty had grown enough that the public might finally benefit, and the brotherhood was now seeking good men.

Read as literature this is superb: a lineage, a rediscovered tomb, a sealed vault of knowledge, and an open invitation the reader has no way to accept. Read as history it has no corroboration of any kind.

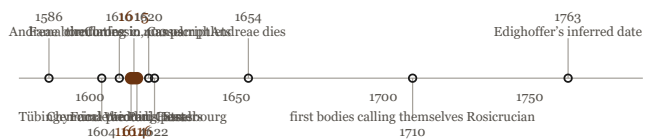


FIG. 1 — THE ROSICRUCIAN CHRONOLOGY. The three manifestos in filled circles; everything else in outline. The shape of the thing is visible at a glance: two years of publication, six years of uproar, and then nearly a century before any organisation calling itself Rosicrucian can be documented. The brotherhood the manifestos describe is placed by them in the fifteenth century, off the left of this chart, and cannot be shown to have existed at all. Drawn for this book.

The furore

The reception is the part of this story that actually happened, and it was extraordinary. Europe in 1614 was sliding toward the Thirty Years' War; the promise of a spiritual and intellectual transformation landed in a continent primed for it. Between 1614 and 1620 roughly **four hundred** books, pamphlets and manuscripts were published discussing the Rosicrucian documents, favourably and otherwise. Serious philosophers took up the worldview — Michael Maier, Robert Fludd, Thomas Vaughan, later Elias Ashmole. The manifestos drew on Heinrich Khunrath's *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (first printed Hamburg, 1595), itself indebted to John Dee's *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564); the invitation that opens the *Chymical Wedding* is marked with Dee's Monas symbol.

The peak came in **1622**, when two mysterious posters appeared on walls in Paris within days of each other. The first began: "We, the Deputies of the Higher College of the Rose-Croix, do make our stay, visibly and invisibly, in this city." The second closed: "The thoughts attached to the real desire of the seeker will lead us to him and him to us." Nobody has ever established who put them up.

One consequence outlived all the others. The idea of an invisible college of natural philosophers, corresponding across borders and pooling discoveries, was taken up by the network around Kepler, Dee, Rheticus and Tycho Brahe, and passed into the group that met weekly in London from about 1645 to conduct experiments. Robert Boyle wrote of "the cornerstones of the Invisible (or as they term themselves the Philosophical) College." That body became the Royal Society in **1660**. The Rosicrucian manifestos are, by a genuinely traceable route, among the ancestors of the modern scientific academy.

### **Who wrote them**

The attribution is not what the manifestos claim, though it is less settled than it is often made to sound. Roland Edighoffer, writing in the Brill *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (2005), traces the manifestos to the "Learned and Christian Society" that Johann Valentin Andreae established at Tübingen in 1610 — a small circle of close friends, notably Christoph Besold and Tobias Hess, who together conceived of and constructed the Rosicrucian myth. Recent scholarship refines this rather than overturning it: Andreae is widely accepted as the principal author, probably working with Tobias Hess, while Besold's participation has been specifically doubted, and a minority of scholars exclude Andreae altogether. What is not seriously contested is that the manifestos came out of this Tübingen milieu rather than from an existing brotherhood.

Andreae (1586–1654) went further than being suspected. In his autobiography — the *Vita ab ipso conscripta*, unpublished in his lifetime and printed only much later — he acknowledged the *Nuptiae Chymicae* as his own work, listing it among juvenilia he assigns to 1602–1603. He gives no age; born 17 August 1586, he was then about sixteen or seventeen. And he was dismissive about it. Of that group of youthful writings he says the others perished, but this one survived:

... *Superfuerunt e contra Nuptiae Chymicae, cum monstrorum foecundo foetu, **ludibrium**, quod mireris a nonnullis aestimatum et subtili indagine explicatum, plane futile et quod inanitatem curiosorum prodat.*

Rendered as literally as the difficult clauses allow: *the Chymical Wedding survived by contrast, with its foetus fruitful of monsters — a **ludibrium**, which you may wonder was esteemed by some and expounded with subtle investigation, plainly futile, and disclosing the emptiness of the curious.* Waite, reading the phrase about monsters, took it to refer not to the book's contents but to its *progeny* — the ridiculous commentaries it spawned. Elsewhere Andreae is blunter still: in the *Vita*'s second book he speaks of his Invitations to the Fraternity of Christ as set in opposition to "that Rosicrucian *ludibrium*," and in the *Menippus* of 1617 the Fraternity is "only a *ludibrium* for the curious," in which those who followed an artificial path instead of the simple way of Christ were deceived.

## WHAT *LUDIBRIUM* MEANS — AND WHAT IT DOES NOT

Everything in this chapter's reading of Andreae turns on one Latin word, and it is worth being careful with it. Lewis & Short give *ludibrium* (from *ludus*, play) as mockery, derision, wantonness; a laughing-stock, butt, jest or sport; and abuse done to a woman. Neither "hoax" — a fraud passed off as true — nor "lampoon" — a satire against a named target — is what the Latin says, and no authority cited here translates it either way: Waite renders it "jest" or "fantasy," Yates "a play, a comic fiction." Those two popular glosses are also incompatible with each other. A classical lexicon cannot by itself bound a word written in the seventeenth century, so the strongest form of the point is about the record rather than the dictionary: the harder English is read *back* into Andreae. (Waite 1924, p. 188, does at one point list the possibilities as "jest, hoax or fantasy," and the one study devoted to the word — Willard, 2010 — argues a Menippean-satire reading.)

The scholarship divides. Paul Arnold (1935) translated it "une farce" and concluded Andreae had told us the whole affair was a joke; Charles Webster (1970) calls the *ludibrium* phrases "derisive terms." Frances Yates argued at length for a different reading: *ludibrium* "could be a play, a comic fiction," and given Andreae's high regard for theatre as a moral and educative instrument, she read the Rosicrucian material as "not a hoax, but a dramatic presentation of a profoundly interesting religious and intellectual movement."

The defensible statement is therefore narrower than "Andreae called it a hoax." Andreae's later references to the Rosicrucian material are genuinely dismissive and at times derisive — *plane futile* is his own phrase. But he called it a jest or a fiction, not a fraud, and the stronger English glosses have been read back into him.

Two further cautions belong here, and both cut against the simple story. First, the text published at Strasbourg in 1616 cannot be the unrevised juvenile draft: it contains references to the manifestos of 1614 and 1615, so whatever Andreae wrote as a teenager was substantially reworked, and Yates doubted the two were the same work at all. Second, A. E. Waite is routinely miscited on this. His 1887 sentence that Andreae "considered the Rosicrucian manifestoes a reprehensible hoax" (*The Real History of the Rosicrucians*, p. 240) is a report of Andreae's *contempt*, deployed as an argument *against* his authorship — and in the same book Waite rejects both the "frolicsome imposture" reading of the manifestos (p. 225) and the *ludibrium* reading of the *Chymical Marriage* (p. 234). In *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (1924) he argued at greater length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped (pp. 122 n., 207), while continuing to insist on Andreae's disdain (p. 206). He was never the authority for the hoax reading he is quoted as supplying.

Some scholars have suggested Andreae distanced himself from the movement to protect a clerical career from the religious and political authorities of the day, and that reading cannot be ruled out. That reading is at least as old as Waite, who proposed a secret-society oath as the reason (1887, pp. 240–41); it remains a conjecture, and the evidence for it is thin.

## WHEN DID REAL ROSICRUCIANS APPEAR?

Edighoffer is blunt on the central question: "there is no proof that the Brotherhood of the Rose Cross described in the *Fama Fraternitatis* ever existed, and it is only in the 18th century that actual organizations calling themselves 'rosicrucian' first come into existence." He dates the first creation of a Rosicrucian order in Germany to 1763 — though that date deserves a footnote of its own. Edighoffer infers it from a later controversy between "Phoebron" (Bernhard Joseph Schleiss von Loewenfeld) and Baron von Ecker und Eckhofen, whose pamphlet *Der Rosenkreuzer in seiner Blösse* Edighoffer dates 1782 and the British Library 1781. It is an inference from a polemic, not a documented act of foundation, and Edighoffer does not name the body in the sentence itself; the surrounding discussion indicates the Gold- und Rosenkreuzer, the Order of the Golden and Rosy Cross. He offers three other candidate moments in the same entry — 1710, 1761 and 1777, of which he says only 1777 "signal[s] the 'official' foundation." Renko Geffarth's archive-based study of the order is summarised by its reviewer as covering circles that existed "from around 1760 until sometime after 1790" (Michael Driedger, *H-German*, Feb. 2010) — a statement about their duration, not a rival founding date. Every Rosicrucian order that has ever operated — the Order of the Golden and Rosy Cross, formally constituted in the 1760s–1770s out of a Rosicrucian literary milieu traceable to about 1750, the Societas Rosicruciana in Anglia from the 1860s, the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (1888), the Rosicrucian Fellowship (1909), AMORC (incorporated 1915) — postdates the manifestos by at least 140 years. They are its descendants, not its survivors.

## What survives the correction

Almost everything of value, as it happens. A literary invention that produced four hundred books in six years, drew in Fludd, Maier and Ashmole, seeded the Invisible College, and still animates active orders four centuries later is not

diminished by being an invention — it is one of the most productive fictions in European intellectual history. Andreae's contempt for what he had started is a fact about Andreae, not a verdict on what his readers built.

A point often made about the alchemical writing of the Rosicrucian circle should be handled with care. It is true, so far as the surviving texts go, that neither Maier nor Khunrath announces a successful transmutation, and Maier does present the Brothers of the Rose Cross as existing to advance the inspired arts and sciences. The inference usually drawn from this — that their alchemy was therefore symbolic rather than operative — is not one the specialists draw; it circulates as an unsourced sentence in the Wikipedia article on Rosicrucianism, and the tracing that undoes it is set out in Chapter 4. Nor were Maier and Khunrath associates: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud.

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**Sources:** *Fama Fraternitatis* (Cassel, 1614); *Confessio Fraternitatis* (Cassel, 1615); *Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (1616). Gorceix, *La Bible des Rose-Croix* (1970) — translations of all three. Andreae, *Vita ab ipso conscripta*, Lib. I, p. 10, ed. F. H. Rheinwald (Berlin, 1849) — first published in German translation by D. C. Seybold (Winterthur, 1799). Roland Edighoffer, "Rosicrucianism I: First half of the 17th Century," in Wouter J. Hanegraaff (ed.), in collaboration with Faivre, van den Broek and Brach, *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2005), 1009–1014, at 1009 and 1014; and Edighoffer, "Rosicrucianism II: 18th Century," *ibid.*, 1014–1017, at 1015, for the 1763 date. Waite, *The Real History of the Rosicrucians* (London: George Redway, 1887), p. 240 for "a reprehensible hoax" and p. 232 for "before he was sixteen" public domain — but see *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (London: William Rider & Son, 1924), pp. 122 n., 207, where Waite argues at length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped — a position already implicit in 1887 (pp. 225, 234), so this is a restatement rather than a retraction. Yates, *The Rosicrucian Enlightenment* (1972; Routledge Classics ed., pp. 43, 68, 182–85, the edition to which those page numbers belong) — in copyright; see also Brian Vickers, "Frances Yates and the Writing of History," *Journal of Modern History* 51, no. 2 (1979), 287–316, not consulted for this book. Arnold, *Histoire des Rose-Croix* (1935), p. 50; Webster, *Acta Comeniana* 26 (1970), p. 149. *Ludibrium* lexicography: Lewis & Short, s.v. *ludibrium*; and cf. Thomas Willard, "Andreae's *ludibrium*: Menippean Satire in the *Chymische Hochzeit*," in Classen (ed.), *Laughter in the Middle Ages and Early Modern Times* (De Gruyter, 2010), 767–90 — not consulted for this book. Andreae defends his own method at *Vita* Lib. II, pp. 46–47: not from a mocking spirit, but by the art many pious men have used, "ut per lusum et ingeniosa allectamenta seria agerem" — that through play he might treat serious matters. Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (Hamburg 1595; Hanau 1609). Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564). Maier, *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617).

## CHAPTER XI

**Advanced Practices**

Advanced practice in this tradition means sustained work with techniques that assume the foundations are already in place — a stable attention, a reliable ritual frame, and enough self-knowledge to notice when you are deceiving yourself. What follows is descriptive: these are the practices the sources contain, with their actual provenance, so that a reader can tell what they are looking at and decide what is worth pursuing under proper guidance.

One general observation belongs first, and it reorganises this whole chapter. Most of what circulates as "advanced Hermetic practice" is not ancient. It was systematised by the **Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn**, founded in 1887–88 by three Freemasons — William Robert Woodman, William Wynn Westcott and Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers — with the Isis-Urania Temple formally established in London in 1888. The order's foundational documents, the CIPHER Manuscripts, were written in English in Trithemius cipher; Westcott decoded them in 1887 after receiving them from A. F. A. Woodford the previous year. Those manuscripts outline the grade rituals and set out a graduated curriculum covering Hermetic Qabalah, astrology, divinatory tarot, geomancy and alchemy — outlines rather than full texts, from which the rituals as performed were elaborated. That curriculum is, in substance, the modern Western magical syllabus.

**The grade structure**

The Golden Dawn organised its teaching into ten numbered grades across three tiers, each mapped to a sephirah of the Tree of Life and running downward from 10 to 1, preceded by a preliminary Neophyte grade (0=0) that stands outside the series:

- **First Order:** Neophyte (0=0), Zelator (1=10), Theoricus (2=9), Practicus (3=8), Philosophus (4=7)
- **Second Order:** Adeptus Minor (5=6), Adeptus Major (6=5), Adeptus Exemptus (7=4)
- **Third Order:** Magister Templi (8=3), Magus (9=2), Ipsissimus (10=1)

The First Order taught theory — correspondence, symbolism, divinatory systems — and the Second Order taught magic proper, including scrying, astral travel and alchemy. The Third Order was, in practice, understood as belonging to those beyond ordinary membership. The graduated structure is itself the point: material was withheld until earlier material had been demonstrated, which is a pedagogical judgement this book endorses even where it declines to reproduce the content.

## The practices

**Scrying.** Sustained soft-focus attention on a reflective or featureless surface — black mirror, bowl of water, crystal — until imagery arises. The *Ars Almadel* of the *Lemegeton* uses a wax tablet for a related purpose, and scrying is among the techniques the Golden Dawn's Second Order explicitly taught. What the technique actually reliably produces is the mind's own imagery under conditions of reduced sensory input; whether it produces more than that is the question the tradition exists to ask, and it is not answerable by assertion in either direction. The discipline is to record what arises before interpreting it.

**Assumption of godforms.** Building the image of a deity around oneself in visualisation and speaking or acting from within it. This has a genuine ancient parallel — the Greek Magical Papyri contain rituals in which the practitioner assumes the identity of a deity through invocation and visualisation, as part of an ascent or operation (see Chapter 8) — which makes it one of the few advanced techniques here with attested antiquity behind it, even if its modern form is a Golden Dawn reconstruction rather than a continuous inheritance.

**The Middle Pillar and pathworking.** The Middle Pillar exercise circulates energy through the central sephiroth of the Tree; pathworking traverses the twenty-two paths in structured visualisation, using the correspondences described in Chapter 3. Both belong to the modern Qabalistic system rather than to any ancient source. Their fullest published form comes through Israel Regardie, whose *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order* appeared in four volumes between **1937 and 1940** — the publication that broke the order's secrecy and made this entire body of technique publicly available. It remains in print.

**The Enochian material.** The system of angelic communication and language recorded by John Dee and Edward Kelley in the 1580s, subsequently reworked by the Golden Dawn into something considerably more systematic than Dee left it. Anyone working with Enochian material should know which layer they are handling — Dee's diaries and the Golden Dawn's redaction are different objects.

### **Working the practices**

Descriptions are of limited use without procedure, so three of the above are given here as procedures. All three are modern — that is the finding of this chapter, not a caveat bolted onto it.

### THE MIDDLE PILLAR

1. Stand or sit upright. Perform the banishing of Chapter 12.  
Breathe evenly until the breath is regular.
2. **Above the head**, formulate a sphere of brilliant white light, and vibrate *Eheieh* (eh-heh-YEH) — the name of Kether. Hold it until it is steady.
3. **At the throat**, a sphere of soft grey. Vibrate *YHVH Elohim* (ye-ho-WAU e-loh-HEEM) — the name of Daath.
4. **At the heart**, a sphere of gold. Vibrate *YHVH Eloah ve-Daath* (ye-ho-WAU e-LOH-ah ve-DAH-ath) — Tiphareth.
5. **At the groin**, a sphere of violet. Vibrate *Shaddai El Chai* (shah-DYE el KHYE) — Yesod.
6. **At the feet**, a sphere of olive, russet, citrine and black. Vibrate *Adonai ha-Aretz* (ah-doh-NYE ha-AH-retz) — Malkuth.
7. When all five stand, circulate: bring the light down the left side of the body on the out-breath, up the right on the in-breath, several times; then up the front and down the back; then draw it from the feet up the central column and let it fountain from the crown to fall around you.
8. Let the images go. Ground as in Chapter 12.

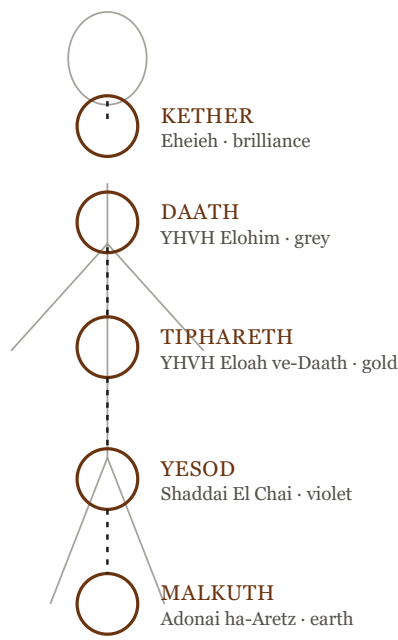


FIG. 2 — THE MIDDLE PILLAR. Five centres on the body’s central axis, each with the divine name vibrated at it. Daath, at the throat, is not one of the ten sephiroth but the “non-sephirah” of the Tree; it appears here because the exercise uses the central column of Fig. 1 rather than the sephiroth as such. Drawn for this book.

A word on provenance, since this book insists on it. The Middle Pillar in this form was published by Israel Regardie in *The Middle Pillar* (1938) and his text is in copyright; what is given above is a description of the procedure rather than his wording. The divine names are the standard Qabalistic names of the sephiroth concerned and are much older than the exercise that arranges them.

## SCRYING

1. Work at night or in low, even light, with the speculum — black mirror, dark bowl of water, crystal — at a comfortable distance, angled so that it reflects nothing in particular. A reflection of your own face defeats the exercise.
2. Banish. State what you are seeking, once, aloud, and then set the question down.
3. Rest the eyes on the surface with the focus slightly soft. Blink normally. Do not stare: staring produces eye strain and afterimages, which are the commonest thing mistaken for a vision.
4. Wait. Twenty minutes is a session. Cloudiness, dimming or a sense of depth usually precede imagery, and often nothing else follows, which is normal.
5. When imagery arises, **do not interpret it in the moment.** Note it. If it is a figure, it is legitimate to ask it to name itself and to test whether it remains consistent; inconsistency under questioning is information.
6. Close deliberately: cover the speculum, banish, write the record, then eat something.

The reason for the discipline in step five is not superstition about spirits. It is that the material is generated at least partly by you, and interpretation offered while the imagery is still arriving contaminates what arrives next. Record first, interpret later — days later, for preference.

### ASSUMPTION OF A GODFORM

1. Choose the form before you begin, and know its attributes, its posture and its name. Do not improvise this.
2. Banish. Stand in the posture of the form.
3. Build the image around you, not in front of you: the size, the headdress, the colours, the weight of it. Take the time this needs — it is the whole exercise.
4. Vibrate the name as set out in Chapter 6, feeling it fill the form rather than the body.
5. Speak or act from within it, briefly. Brevity is a safety measure, not modesty.
6. **Take it off.** Let the image dissolve deliberately; state your own name aloud; banish; ground. This step is not optional and is the one that gets skipped.

The ancient parallel noted above is real — the papyri contain rituals of exactly this shape — but the modern form is a Golden Dawn reconstruction, and the Egyptian godforms it uses are the Egypt of the nineteenth-century imagination as much as of the monuments.

## A NOTE ON WHAT IS AND IS NOT ATTRIBUTED

The Golden Dawn's founding, dates, grade structure, Cipher Manuscripts and curriculum are well documented, as is Regardie's publication. What is *not* settled — and this book will not pretend otherwise — is exactly which of these techniques the order invented outright and which it inherited or adapted from earlier sources. The scholarly record establishes that the Second Order taught scrying, astral travel and alchemy; it does not cleanly establish the origin of each individual exercise. Where this chapter says "Golden Dawn," read it as "systematised and transmitted by the Golden Dawn," which is defensible, rather than "invented there," which in several cases is not yet demonstrated.

### Advanced Practice Warning

These practices assume extensive preparation and, in their original setting, years of graded work under supervision. The graded structure existed for a reason and its removal by publication was not an unmixed improvement. Two specific cautions. Sustained visualisation and evocatory work can be genuinely destabilising, and the tradition's own literature contains ample evidence of practitioners who came apart; if you have a history of psychosis, dissociation or mania, this material is not for solitary work. And the commonest failure here is not dramatic — it is the slow inflation of the practitioner's sense of their own significance, which the grade systems were partly designed to check.

## MODERN PRACTICE

Regardie's publication changed this material permanently: what was once transmitted in a temple over years is now available in a single volume, and every modern practitioner is in some sense working from a leaked syllabus. Contemporary orders descended from the Golden Dawn still use graded curricula, while a large majority of practitioners now work solo from published sources. The honest assessment is that solitary work loses the two things the original structure supplied — pacing, and someone else's eyes on your conclusions — and that practitioners who compensate deliberately, through written records and a peer or teacher who will disagree with them, do markedly better than those who do not.

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**Sources:** Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, founded 1887–88 (Woodman, Westcott, Mathers); Isis-Urania Temple, London, 1888; the original order fractured in 1903. Cipher Manuscripts (Trithemius cipher; decoded by Westcott 1887). Ellic Howe, *The Magicians of the Golden Dawn* (1972), for the grade numbering — the descending 10–1 series maps the ten sephiroth, with a preliminary 0=0 outside it. Regardie, *The Golden Dawn*, 4 vols (1937–40) — in copyright; note that Regardie was not first into print, Crowley having published order material in *The Equinox* (1909–13). Dee and Kelley's Enochian diaries (1580s) — BL Sloane MS 3188 runs 22 December 1581 to 23 May 1583 and opens with Barnabas Saul, not Kelley, as scryer. PGM for the ancient parallel to godform assumption (Betz, 1986). The Middle Pillar exercise as given here follows the procedure published by Israel Regardie, *The Middle Pillar* (1938) in copyright — described, not quoted; the sephirotic divine names are older than the exercise. The scrying and godform procedures are this book's own arrangement of practices the order's published papers describe.

## CHAPTER XII

**Protection & Banishing**

Protection and banishing are the practical hygiene of this tradition. Their function is to clear a space before work and to close it afterwards, and in ordinary use they have less to do with repelling hostile forces than with establishing a definite beginning and end. A practitioner who banishes reliably is a practitioner who does not carry the residue of one working into the next, or into the rest of their life.

**Basic techniques**

1. **Visualisation** — establish an image of light surrounding you, bounded and complete. Simple, portable, and requires nothing.
2. **Prayer** — call upon whatever you understand the divine to be, in your own words or a traditional form. The overwhelming majority of historical protective practice is prayer.
3. **Salt** — used across many traditions for purification and boundary-marking, whether scattered, dissolved in water, or laid at a threshold.
4. **Herbs** — sage and rosemary are the most commonly used in this tradition, burned or hung. Ventilate if burning, and note that white sage in particular is both ecologically pressured and culturally specific to practices this book does not claim; garden sage and rosemary do the same work in a Hermetic frame.

These four are genuinely sufficient for ordinary purposes, and a practitioner who does them consistently is better protected than one who performs an elaborate ceremony occasionally.

## The Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram

The most widely used banishing in Western ceremonial practice is the LBRP, and it comes from the original Golden Dawn — which places it in the late nineteenth century, not antiquity. It belonged to the **First**, or Outer, Order: apart from the grade ceremonies it was the only ritual revealed at that level, disclosed to neophytes immediately after initiation, and on R. A. Gilbert's assessment the nearest thing to a purely magical ritual in the outer curriculum. Its skeleton is genuinely in the Cipher Manuscripts — the banishing-pentagram concept appears on page 14, in what looks like a different hand, and the archangel, element and cardinal-point correspondences are already there — though the Cipher MS nowhere sets the ritual out in full. Its structure has four movements:

1. **The Qabalistic Cross.** The practitioner traces a cross on the body, touching forehead, breast and each shoulder while vibrating Hebrew words drawn from the doxology of the Lord's Prayer, each position corresponding to a location on the Tree of Life.
2. **Formulation of the pentagrams.** Beginning in the east and proceeding around the quarters, a pentagram is drawn at each cardinal point while a divine name is vibrated: YHVH in the east, Adonai in the south, Eheieh in the west, AGLA in the north.
3. **Evocation of the archangels.** Standing with arms outstretched in the form of a cross — the posture the Golden Dawn called the Calvary Cross, and the position of the godform "Osiris Slain" — four archangels are named at the quarters: Raphael before (east), Gabriel behind (west), Michael at the right hand (south), Auriel at the left (north). The declaration continues in the same breath: "Before me flames the pentagram, behind me shines the six-rayed star," locating the magician between the pentagram of the microcosm and the hexagram of the macrocosm.
4. **The Qabalistic Cross repeated**, closing the ritual as it opened.

Set out in full, and in a form you can work from, it runs as follows. The Hebrew is given unpointed, the pronunciation as the earliest printed version gives it.

## THE LESSER BANISHING RITUAL OF THE PENTAGRAM

1. **The Qabalistic Cross.** Face east. Touch the forehead, then the breast, then the right shoulder, then the left, then clasp the hands at the breast, vibrating at each:

**אתה** *Ateh* ah-TAH — "unto Thee"

**מלכות** *Malkuth* mal-KOOTH — "the Kingdom"

**וגבורה** *ve-Geburah* ve-ge-boo-RAH — "and the Power"

**וגדולה** *ve-Gedulah* ve-ge-doo-LAH — "and the Glory"

**לעולם אמן** *le-Olahm, Amen* le-oh-LAHM, ah-MEN — "to the ages, amen"

2. **The pentagram in the east.** Trace a banishing earth pentagram in the air — beginning at the lower left point, up to the top, and round — with the extended fingers or the wand. Bring the point of the wand to the centre and vibrate:

**יהוה** *YHVH* ye-ho-WAU

3. **South.** Turn sunwise, carrying a line of light at shoulder height from the centre of the eastern pentagram. Trace the same figure and vibrate:

**אדני** *Adonai* ah-doh-NYE

4. **West.** The same, and vibrate:

**אהיה** *Eheieh* eh-heh-YEH

5. **North.** The same, and vibrate:

**אגלא** *AGLA* ah-goo-LAH

6. **Close the circle.** Complete the line back to the east, so that the four pentagrams stand joined in a ring of light at shoulder height.

7. **The archangels.** Return to face east. Extend the arms sideways in the form of a cross — the posture the order called the Calvary Cross, and the godform of Osiris Slain — and say:

*Before me Raphael. Behind me Gabriel. On my right hand Michael. On my left hand Auriel. For before me flames the pentagram, and behind me shines the six-rayed star.*

8. **The Qabalistic Cross repeated,** exactly as at the opening.

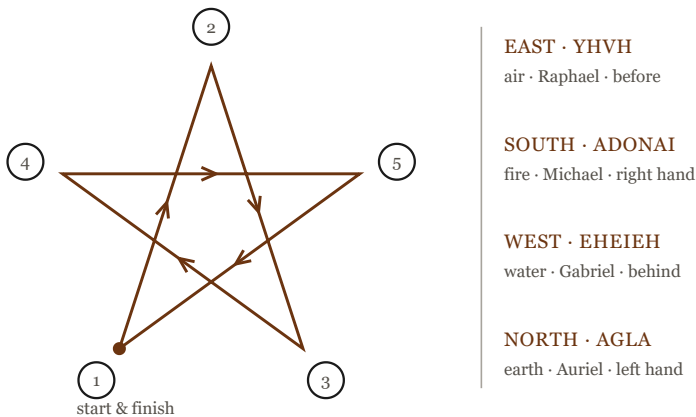


FIG. 5 — THE BANISHING PENTAGRAM OF EARTH, AND THE FOUR QUARTERS. The tracing order is the whole point of the figure: begin at the lower left, go up to the apex, and continue in one unbroken line, closing the angle where you began. The same figure is drawn at each of the four quarters with a different divine name. The requirement that the angles be closed is, on Graham Wheeler's reconstruction, the one element of the ritual borrowed from a work of fiction — Mephistopheles is held in Faust's study by a pentagram whose angle was left open. Drawn for this book.

## TWO TEXTUAL POINTS, SINCE THIS BOOK IS ABOUT TEXTS

The wording of the archangel declaration is not stable. The Golden Dawn form is the one given above, and Graham Wheeler notes that "behind me shines the six-rayed star" is regularly altered in modern versions to "in the column shines the six-rayed star" — the column being the middle pillar of the Tree, with which the magician is identifying. Wheeler dates that variant to Crowley's "Star Ruby" of 1913. The text of *Liber O* as it now circulates online in fact reads "*For about me flames the Pentagram, and in the Column stands the six-rayed Star,*" which would push the variant back to 1909 — but this book has not checked that text against the 1909 printing of *The Equinox*, and an online transcription may carry a later editor's emendation. The point is recorded here unresolved rather than smoothed over.

The pronunciations are those printed in *Liber O*: "Ye-ho-wau, Adonai, Eheieh, Agla." They represent one nineteenth-century English convention, not Hebrew as spoken anywhere. YHVH is not pronounced at all in Jewish practice, and a reader who finds the convention uncomfortable is in good company; substituting *Adonai* or a silent intention is a recognised solution and the ritual does not stop working.

The ritual's stated purpose is to banish chaotic or impure forms of the elements from the working space. Its components are plainly Christian and Qabalistic: the Lord's Prayer doxology, Hebrew divine names, the four archangels, and an association of the quarters with the classical elements by way of the biblical four living creatures.

## WHAT IS DOCUMENTED AND WHAT IS NOT

The LBRP is attributed to the original order of the Golden Dawn, and its structure and content are well attested. Two questions remain genuinely open: who first assembled the formula, and exactly when. Mathers is credited as the principal hand by convention rather than by demonstration — R. A. Gilbert has argued for a larger role for Westcott — and the composition process, in Graham John Wheeler's words, "remains obscure: the evidence simply does not survive" (*Correspondences* 8, no. 1, 2020, p. 8). Nothing resembling the ritual existed before the 1880s, and the earliest located manuscript text is datable to the 1890s.

The third question — which earlier materials shaped it — is no longer open, and an earlier version of this book conceded more ground here than it needed to. Wheeler's 2020 source-analysis — by his own account the first anyone has attempted — identifies the ingredients in detail. **Eliphas Lévi** above all: he first noticed the resemblance between the doxology of the Lord's Prayer and the sephiroth, and he gives the Qabalistic Cross gesture in recognisable form — the order's replication of his Hebrew solecisms makes the dependence close to certain. Behind Lévi stand Matthew 6:13 and 1 Chronicles 29:11, by way of a Zohar passage *Mathers himself translated in 1887*. **Agrippa**, reaching the order through Barrett's *Magus*, supplies the archangel–element correspondences; **Ptolemy's Tetrabiblos** supplies the element–direction correspondences onto which Agrippa's were mapped. Solomonian grimoire practice supplies the divine names at the quarters and the ritual dagger; Freemasonry the circumambulation; medieval rabbinic material the four archangels surrounding the divine throne. The rule about closing the angles of the pentagram appears to come from Goethe's *Faust* — the one element borrowed from a work of fiction.

One derivation often repeated should be resisted: the archangel invocation does not descend from the bedtime Shema. What the two share is an earlier ancestor — the Jewish motif of four archangels surrounding God's throne, the throne being the detail that discriminates — and the

before/behind/right/left formula itself runs back through the *Seder Rav Amram Gaon* to a second-millennium-BCE Mesopotamian exorcism. Claims that the ritual descends from ancient Egyptian or Solomonic practice remain unsupported; the ritual is modern. But its ingredients are now traceable, and the tracing is more interesting than the agnosticism it replaces.

## The Lesser Ritual of the Hexagram

The banishing of the pentagram has a companion, and this book has referred to it twice without printing it — the six-rayed star named in the fourth movement above. *Liber O* gives it immediately after the pentagram ritual, with the instruction that it "is to be performed after the *Lesser Ritual of the Pentagram*." It opens with the passage known as the Analysis of the Keyword, which is the most theatrical thing in Western ceremonial practice and also the most compressed: a Latin inscription, read as Hebrew letters, read as a sequence of Egyptian gods, resolving into a single word of light.

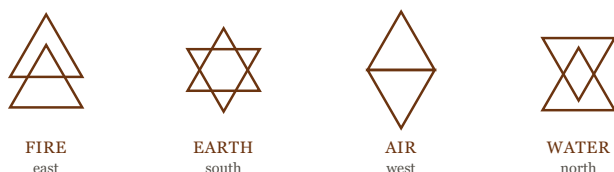


FIG. 2 — THE FOUR HEXAGRAMS. Two interlocked triangles, arranged differently at each quarter, as *Liber O* describes them. Where the pentagram of Fig. 1 is the sign of the microcosm, the hexagram is the sign of the macrocosm — which is what the two rituals together are for: the pentagram sets the practitioner's own boundary, the hexagram addresses what is outside it. Drawn for this book from the descriptions in the text.

## THE LESSER RITUAL OF THE HEXAGRAM

1. **Stand upright**, feet together, left arm at the side, right across the body, holding the wand upright in the median line. Face east.

2. **The Analysis of the Keyword.** Say:

*I.N.R.I. Yod. Nun. Resh. Yod.*

*Virgo, Isis, Mighty Mother.*

*Scorpio, Apophis, Destroyer.*

*Sol, Osiris, Slain and Risen.*

*Isis, Apophis, Osiris, IAO.*

3. **The signs.** Extend the arms in the form of a cross: *the Sign of Osiris Slain*. Raise the right arm to point upwards and lower the left to point downwards, elbows square, head turned over the left shoulder so the eyes follow the left forearm: *the Sign of the Mourning of Isis*. Raise the arms at sixty degrees to each other above the head, head thrown back: *the Sign of Apophis and Typhon*. Cross the arms on the breast and bow the head: *the Sign of Osiris Risen*.

4. **Extend the arms again** as in the first sign, then cross them again as in the last, saying:

*L.V.X., Lux, the Light of the Cross.*

5. **The four hexagrams.** Trace the hexagram of Fire in the east, of Earth in the south, of Air in the west, of Water in the north, as drawn above, vibrating at each:

**ארריתא** *ARARITA* ah-rah-REE-tah

The name is an acrostic: "One is His Beginning: One is His Individuality: His Permutation is One."

6. **Repeat** the Analysis of the Keyword and the signs, exactly as at the opening.

**To banish rather than invoke**, the ritual is identical except that the direction in which each hexagram is traced is reversed.

### THE GREATER RITUAL OF THE HEXAGRAM

1. Used to invoke or banish a **planet** or a sign of the zodiac rather than an element. Only the hexagram of Earth is used.
2. Begin tracing from the point of the figure attributed to the planet in question, sunwise, completing the lower triangle; then trace the upper triangle from its own attributed point and complete it.
3. Trace the astrological sigil of the planet in the centre of the hexagram.
4. For a sign of the zodiac, use the hexagram of the planet that rules the sign, but draw the sigil of the *sign* in the centre rather than the planet's.

The point attributions are those of Crowley's table 777. For which planet governs what, and for choosing the hour, see Chapter 17.

### Grounding

The most useful protective skill is also the least ceremonial: the ability to return deliberately to ordinary awareness. Eat something. Wash your hands and face. Put your attention on physical sensation — feet on the floor, weight in the chair. Write down what happened and then stop. Speak to someone about something unrelated.

Practitioners who neglect this are the ones who get into difficulty, and the difficulty is nearly always the same: not an external attack but a failure to fully come back, accumulating over weeks into distraction, poor sleep, and a steadily thinner grip on ordinary priorities. If that is happening, the correct response is to stop practising for a while. That option is always available and using it is not a failure.

### MODERN PRACTICE

Most contemporary practitioners use the LBRP or an abbreviated version of it as a daily practice rather than reserving it for ceremonial occasions, which is a departure from its original place in a graded curriculum and generally a productive one — done daily it becomes a reliable frame rather than a special event. Practitioners uncomfortable with the ritual's explicitly Judaeo-Christian content have developed numerous adaptations substituting other divine names or dispensing with them; these work, and their existence is worth knowing about, though the version above is the documented one. The broader modern shift is a demystified reading of what banishing accomplishes: many practitioners now describe it frankly as a psychological boundary-setting technique, and find that describing it that way does not reduce its usefulness in the least.

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**Sources:** Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram — attributed to the original Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (founded 1887–88); a First Order ritual; first printed in Crowley, *Liber O* (1909), then Regardie, *The Tree of Life* (1932) and *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40). The Lesser and Greater Rituals of the Hexagram, the Analysis of the Keyword and the four hexagram forms: Crowley, *Liber O* (1909), section V public domain; the wording of the Analysis and of the hexagram instructions is his. For the sources of the pentagram ritual's components: Graham John Wheeler, "A Microcosm of the Esoteric Revival: The Histories of the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram," *Correspondences: Journal for the Study of Esotericism* 8, no. 1 (2020), 5–44 — open access under CC BY-NC 4.0, which is not the same as public domain. R. A. Gilbert for the argument that Westcott's hand was larger than convention allows. Who assembled the formula, and when, remains unresolved; see the note above.

CHAPTER XIII

## Healing & Wellness

Healing occupies a central and honourable place in this tradition. It is worth remembering that the Rosicrucian manifestos made it the first practical commitment of the brotherhood they described: each member was sworn to heal the sick *without accepting payment*. Of everything those documents promised, this is the part that has aged best, and it sets the tone for the chapter.

### Principles of Hermetic healing

- All healing is understood to come from the divine source; the practitioner does not generate it
- The healer functions as a channel rather than an originator — which is also a safeguard against self-importance
- Healing addresses the whole person: body, mind and spirit, none of them treated in isolation
- Prevention is better than cure, and regimen matters more than intervention

The fourth of these is worth dwelling on, because it is where the historical tradition and modern medicine agree most completely. The Hermetic and Paracelsian writers took sleep, diet, air, exercise, work and companionship to be the substance of health rather than its background. That is an unglamorous position and it was correct.

## The historical practice

Historically, healing in this tradition drew on several strands. Herbalism, systematised through the doctrine of correspondences that assigned plants to planets and planets to organs — the material of Agrippa's first book. Astrological medicine, timing treatment by the heavens and reading the chart for constitutional tendency. Amulets and charms, ubiquitous in the ancient evidence: a substantial portion of the Greek Magical Papyri consists of remedies and phylacteries for entirely ordinary complaints, alongside the grander material. Prayer and laying on of hands, the oldest and most widespread element. And Paracelsian iatrochemistry, which took the alchemical tradition into medicine and, for all its errors, moved European practice toward specific remedies for specific conditions.

The physicians of the Rosicrucian legend were, in the setting of the manifestos, ordinary doctors — the healing described was practical care given freely, not miracle-working. That framing is a useful corrective to how the subject is often presented now.

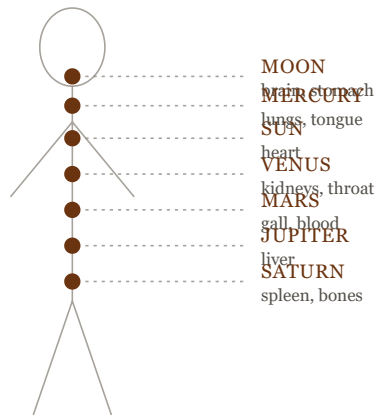


FIG. 1 — THE PLANETARY BODY. The scheme underlying Renaissance astrological medicine: each planet governs organs and functions, so the choice of herb, the timing of treatment and the reading of a chart all belong to one system. The particular assignments vary between authorities — these are the commonest — and the whole framework is a historical one. It is given here because the herbal correspondences of Chapter 17 are unintelligible without it, not as a guide to treating anything. Drawn for this book.

**Energetic work**

Contemporary practice in this area centres on directing attention and intention toward another person, whether by laying on of hands, at a distance, or through visualisation of light. If you do this work, a few things follow from the tradition's own commitments. Ask permission — working on someone without their knowledge violates the ethical position of Chapter 1 whatever the intention behind it. Ground afterwards, as in Chapter 12. Make no diagnostic or prognostic claims. And attend to your own state: practitioners who do this work while depleted tend to make it about themselves.

### On Health and Medicine

**Nothing in this chapter is a substitute for medical care.** Do not delay diagnosis or treatment, and do not discontinue prescribed medication, in favour of any practice in this book. Do not offer prognoses, discourage anyone from seeing a doctor, or represent spiritual practice as treatment for a serious condition — the historical record of harm here is extensive and it falls hardest on the frightened and the desperate.

Herbal preparations are not exempt from this: plants contain active pharmacology, several traditional remedies are outright toxic, and interactions with prescribed drugs are common and sometimes severe. Consult a physician or pharmacist before combining them with medication, and treat historical herbals as history rather than as dosing guidance.

Used as a complement to proper care — for calm, for meaning, for the considerable value of attentive presence — this material has a real contribution to make. Used as a replacement, it kills people.

## MODERN PRACTICE

Responsible contemporary practitioners position this work explicitly as complementary, and many now work alongside conventional care rather than in competition with it — in hospice and chaplaincy settings, in pain management, in support of patients under active treatment. That represents a genuine and fairly recent maturation of the field. Practitioners also now have research literature on placebo effects, therapeutic presence and the measurable value of unhurried attention, which offers a plausible and unembarrassing account of why sitting with a frightened person helps. Where the historical tradition claimed to cure, the honest modern claim is narrower and more defensible: this work can reliably reduce suffering, and it does not treat disease.

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**Sources:** *Fama Fraternitatis* (1614) on healing the sick without payment. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book I, on herbal and planetary correspondence. PGM for ancient remedies, amulets and phylacteries (Betz, 1986). Paracelsus (1493 or 1494–1541) for iatrochemistry.

CHAPTER XIV

## Prosperity & Abundance

Prosperity in the Hermetic tradition is not merely material wealth but the sufficiency of all good things — health, wisdom, love, competence, and spiritual growth. That definition is not a euphemism for having less money; it is a claim that money is one good among several and behaves badly when treated as the only one.

### Principles of prosperity

- Prosperity follows from alignment with the order of things rather than from force applied against it
- Service to others creates abundance — a claim about how goods actually circulate, not only a moral instruction
- Gratitude reorients attention toward what is present rather than what is absent
- Generosity multiplies prosperity, and hoarding reliably impoverishes the hoarder in the ways that matter

### Where this chapter has to be careful

This is the subject on which the tradition has been most thoroughly commercialised, and the dating work of this book bears directly on it. The modern "law of attraction" — the doctrine that thought directly produces material circumstance — is not ancient Hermeticism. It comes from the same New Thought movement of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries that produced *The Kybalion* in 1908, and its lineage runs from there through

twentieth-century positive-thinking literature to the contemporary prosperity-teaching industry. Recognising that lineage is useful, because it explains why the doctrine feels Hermetic while sitting awkwardly with the actual texts.

The ancient *Hermetica* are not about acquisition. Their concern is the ascent of the soul and the shedding of what binds it — and among the things to be shed, in the *Poimandres*'s account, is greed. A tradition whose foundational vision treats acquisitiveness as an impediment cannot straightforwardly be made into a wealth technique, and the attempt requires quietly dropping most of what the source says.

The practical harm is specific and worth naming. Doctrines that make prosperity a direct product of correct thinking imply, unavoidably, that poverty is a product of incorrect thinking — which blames the poor for structural conditions and lands hardest on people already in difficulty. It is also the mechanism by which a great deal of money is extracted from desperate people by teachers selling the technique. Where a practice in this area asks for significant payment on the promise of return, that is the point to stop.

## Practice

What the tradition genuinely supports here is modest and useful. A gratitude practice — the deliberate daily enumeration of what is actually present — reliably shifts attention, and attention shapes judgement. Clarity of intention: writing plainly what you are working toward and what you are prepared to do for it, which is more often revealing than motivating. Regular generosity, fixed in advance rather than decided by mood. And the discipline of examining what you actually want, since a good deal of what presents itself as a desire for money is a desire for security, or standing, or the freedom to stop doing something — all of which have more direct routes.

None of this is a technique for obtaining money without working, and the tradition never claimed otherwise. What it offers is a defensible relationship to material things: enough is a real quantity, it is generally nearer than it appears, and the pursuit of more than enough has a documented history of costing people the other goods on the list.

**Sources:** *Corpus Hermeticum* I (*Poimandres*) on the shedding of greed in the soul's ascent. *The Kybalion* (1908) and the New Thought movement as the origin of modern attraction doctrine — cf. Ch. 1.

CHAPTER XV

## Seasonal Celebrations

Seasonal observance connects practice to something outside the practitioner's own schedule. The solstices and equinoxes are astronomical facts — the actual turning points of the year, determined by the tilt of the planet — and marking them anchors a practice to a cycle that does not care whether you are enthusiastic this month. That is precisely their value: they arrive on time regardless.

### The four solar stations

- **Spring Equinox** (around 20 March in the northern hemisphere) — renewal and new beginnings. Light and dark in balance, with light increasing. Traditionally a point for starting work and for setting intentions that will be tested over the growing season.
- **Summer Solstice** (around 21 June) — the peak of solar energy, the longest day. A point of fullness, and, in most traditional readings, of recognition that fullness is also a turning: the light begins to withdraw from here.
- **Autumn Equinox** (around 22 September) — harvest and gratitude. Balance again, with dark increasing. A point for assessment: what actually came of the year's work, honestly counted.
- **Winter Solstice** (around 21 December) — inner light and contemplation, the longest night. Traditionally the most inward of the four, and the one most widely marked across cultures, since the return of the light after the longest night is the most reliably consoling fact available to people without calendars.

Practitioners in the southern hemisphere should reverse these: the astronomical events are shared but the seasons are not, and observing a "spring" equinox in March in Australia inverts the meaning of the whole cycle. A surprising amount of published material silently assumes the northern hemisphere.

## The cross-quarters

Many practitioners also mark the four traditional British and Irish season-opening quarter days, at the beginning of February, May, August and November: Imbolc (1–2 February), Beltane (1 May), Lughnasadh or Lammas (1 August) and Samhain (1 November). These are conventionally called cross-quarter days, but they are not true midpoints — as Hutton notes, the eight dates form "two equal-armed crosses, imposed on each other in a slightly crooked pattern, some five weeks apart and some seven weeks apart." Together with the four solar stations they make up the eightfold "Wheel of the Year."

It should be said plainly that the Wheel as a unified system is a **mid-twentieth-century construction**, and that it was assembled by stages rather than designed in one act. In Wicca the quarter days came first, standing alone in the earliest surviving liturgy of the 1940s; the solstices were added around 1953; the equinoxes only after *Witchcraft Today* went to press in 1954; and the eight reached equal status in early 1958, when Gardner's coven objected collectively and Gardner gave way — a sequence Ronald Hutton reconstructs from the testimony of four surviving members. Ross Nichols's Order of Bards, Ovates and Druids is a recipient rather than a co-originator: on Hutton's account Nichols seceded in 1964 and promptly instituted "the new Wiccan pattern of eight festivals" as one of his Druidic innovations. The often-repeated story that Gardner and Nichols harmonised the calendar together during a naturist retreat is unsourced, and the reverse claim — that Nichols conceived it first — comes from a rival Druid order rather than from scholarship. The phrase "Wheel of the Year" was in use for the cycle of eight observances by the mid-1960s.

Three of the eight names are later still, and not British. **Yule** is a genuinely old midwinter name, but **Ostara**, **Litha** and **Mabon** were applied to the spring equinox, summer solstice and autumn equinox by the Californian Wiccan Aidan Kelly — by his own account for a "Pagan-Craft" calendar of 1974 — and spread through the magazine *Green Egg*, only entering British Pagan usage in the 1980s. The words themselves are older: Litha and Ostara are Bede's month-names (Ostara reaching modern usage via Jacob Grimm), and Mabon is Mabon ap Modron of Welsh myth, a derivation Hutton notes British scholars might find "preposterously inappropriate." What Kelly did was apply existing words, not coin them.

The individual festivals have genuine historical antecedents of varying strength — the Gaelic quarter days are attested, the solstices are astronomical — but the eightfold wheel as a single system is recent, and it is not Hermetic in origin at all. This is worth stating because the Wheel is frequently presented as an unbroken ancient inheritance. It is a good framework, genuinely useful, well balanced, and now the practice of a great many people. It is also about seventy years old. Both things are true and neither needs hiding.

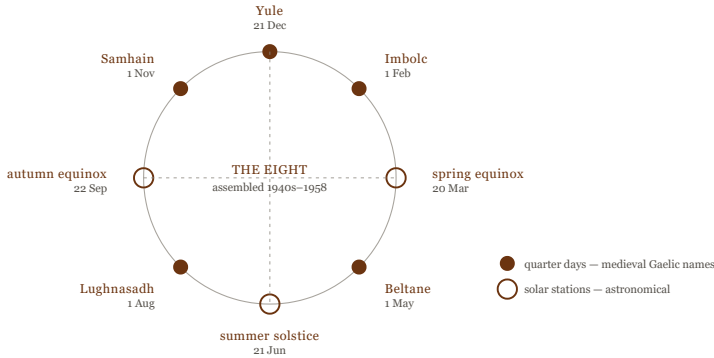


FIG. 1 — THE WHEEL OF THE YEAR. Four solar stations and four quarter days. The geometry is the point: as Ronald Hutton observes, the eight are not evenly spaced but form "two equal-armed crosses, imposed on each other in a slightly crooked pattern, some five weeks apart and some seven weeks apart." The quarter-day names are medieval Gaelic and genuinely old; the solar stations are astronomical facts. What is modern is the *wheel* — the decision to observe all eight as one cycle, reached by stages between the 1940s and 1958. The names Ostara, Litha and Mabon are not shown, because they were applied to the equinoxes and midsummer in California around 1974. Drawn for this book.

## Observance

What to actually do is simple, and the tradition's own emphasis falls on regularity rather than elaboration. Mark the day. Note where the sun rises and sets, which is the observation the whole system rests on and which almost nobody makes. Review the season that is ending and name what you are carrying into the next. Eat something appropriate to the time of year. If you keep the record recommended in Chapter 6, read back to the previous station — four entries a year, read in sequence, will tell you more about your own development than any amount of daily introspection.

A single structure serves all eight stations, which is the practical advantage of an eightfold wheel over eight unrelated festivals. What changes between them is the question asked, not the form.

### AN OBSERVANCE FOR ANY OF THE EIGHT

1. **Observe first.** Go outside near sunrise or sunset and note where on the horizon the sun stands. Write it down. Over a year these notes become the only part of this that is not interpretation.
2. **Open** as in Chapter 7 — the short form is sufficient and appropriate here.
3. **Light** one candle for the season closing and one for the season opening. At the winter solstice, light the second from the first.
4. **Read back** to your record from the previous station. Read it aloud. This is the heart of the practice and it takes five minutes.
5. **Name**, aloud, one thing the closing season completed and one thing it did not. Neither needs to be significant.
6. **Ask the question of the station** (below), and write the answer without editing it.
7. **Eat** something of the season, deliberately, as part of the rite rather than after it.
8. **Close** as in Chapter 7. Extinguish the first candle; let the second burn down safely.

| STATION                          | APPROX. DATE | THE QUESTION                                                  |
|----------------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Winter solstice</b><br>(Yule) | 21 Dec       | What is worth carrying through the dark?                      |
| <b>Imbolc</b>                    | 1–2 Feb      | What has begun that is not yet visible?                       |
| <b>Spring equinox</b>            | 20 Mar       | Where am I out of balance, and in which direction?            |
| <b>Beltane</b>                   | 1 May        | What am I willing to commit to in public?                     |
| <b>Summer solstice</b>           | 21 Jun       | What is at its height, and what does that cost?               |
| <b>Lughnasadh</b><br>(Lammas)    | 1 Aug        | What is ready to be harvested, and what am I refusing to cut? |
| <b>Autumn equinox</b>            | 22 Sep       | What is finished? Say it plainly.                             |
| <b>Samhain</b>                   | 1 Nov        | Who and what am I carrying that is no longer here?            |

The questions are this book's own, not traditional. The dates are for the northern hemisphere; in the southern, the solar stations shift by six months and the quarter days conventionally follow them.

The names *Ostara*, *Litha* and *Mabon* are deliberately absent from that table: as the dating above establishes, they were applied to the solar stations in California in the 1970s. Use them if you like them — many practitioners do, and nothing depends on it — but the solstices and equinoxes had no such names before then, and the table above says only what can be dated.

The deeper purpose of seasonal practice is the correspondence of Chapter 1 put to use: the cycles of the year, of a life, and of the alchemical work of Chapter 4 are held to be the same pattern at different scales. Winter is *nigredo*. Whether one takes that as metaphysics or as metaphor, it is a genuinely steadying thing to have available in February.

**Sources:** Solstices and equinoxes — astronomical. Ronald Hutton, "Modern Pagan Festivals: A Study in the Nature of Tradition," *Folklore* 119, no. 3 (2008), 251–74 — for the staged assembly of the cycle (quarter days 1940s, solstices c. 1953, equinoxes after 1954, equal status early 1958), the "two equal-armed crosses" geometry, Nichols's 1964 adoption, and Aidan Kelly's application of Ostara, Litha and Mabon in the 1970s. Kelly's own account dates his calendar to 1974. Ethan Doyle White, *Wicca: History, Belief, and Community in Modern Pagan Witchcraft* (Sussex Academic, 2015), ch. 13. Individual festivals have antecedents of varying documentation; the unified eightfold system does not.

CHAPTER XVI

## Greater Mysteries

Every tradition in this book claims a summit — a body of knowledge reserved for those who have prepared for it, spoken of in the sources with deliberate reticence. This chapter is about what that reticence has actually meant historically, and what it means for a reader holding a book that claims to contain the whole thing.

### The Path of Initiation

The path to the Greater Mysteries, as the tradition describes it, involves:

1. Mastery of the foundational practices
2. Purification of body, mind and spirit
3. Development of the spiritual faculties
4. Service to humanity
5. Direct experience of the divine

Two features of that list deserve notice. It is sequential, and the sequence is not decorative: nothing in the tradition suggests the later items are available to someone who has skipped the earlier. And service sits fourth — before the culmination, not after it. Whatever else the Greater Mysteries were held to be, they were not understood as a private attainment.

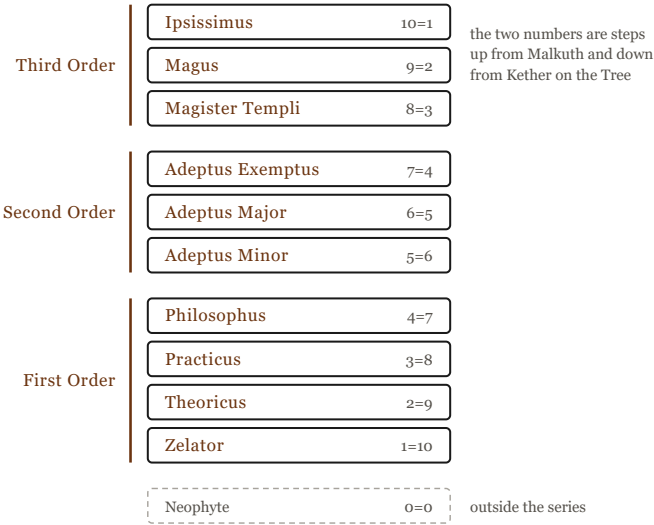


FIG. 1 — THE GRADE LADDER. Ten numbered grades in three tiers, each mapped to a sephirah of the Tree in Chapter 3, with a preliminary Neophyte standing outside the series. The paired numbers are the two ways of counting the same position: steps up from Malkuth, and steps down from Kether — so 5=6 is the sixth sephirah counted either way, Tiphareth. The structure is late nineteenth century, not ancient, and the withholding it encodes is the subject of this chapter. Drawn for this book.

### What "mystery" meant

The word carries a specific historical sense that has largely been lost. In the ancient mystery cults — Eleusis, Samothrace, the Mithraic grades — a *mystery* was not a puzzle or a secret doctrine but something *undergone*. The initiate at Eleusis was not told a fact; they were put through an experience, and the prohibition on disclosure concerned that experience rather than any proposition about it. This is why ancient sources can be simultaneously insistent about secrecy and unembarrassed about publishing their philosophy: the philosophy was never the secret.

The Hermetic texts inherit this structure. The *Poimandres* reports a vision rather than arguing a case, and its claim that knowledge of the divine comes through direct experience and not through belief is a statement about method. What cannot be transmitted in writing is not information being withheld; it is an experience that writing cannot contain. Michael Maier, defending the Rosicrucians in 1617, placed their origins in exactly this lineage — "the mysteries of Eleusis and Samothrace, the Magi of Persia, the Pythagoreans" — a genealogy that says more about how the seventeenth century understood itself than about actual descent, but which locates the aspiration accurately.

### **Grades and the structure of withholding**

The organisational expression of all this is the graded system: the ten Golden Dawn grades of Chapter 11, the Rosicrucian degrees, the Masonic rites. Their logic is pedagogical before it is dramatic. Material is withheld until earlier material has been demonstrated, because the earlier work is what makes the later work legible — and because a technique reached too early tends to be absorbed into whatever the practitioner already wanted to believe.

The systems also functioned, less admirably, as instruments of authority. Grades create hierarchy, hierarchy creates deference, and the history of esoteric orders is substantially a history of schism over who held which grade legitimately. The original Golden Dawn fractured in exactly this manner in 1903, fifteen years after its founding, when Waite and Blackden took possession of Isis-Urania at that spring's annual meeting. Nothing was dissolved: Waite ran his branch until he closed it in 1914, and the Stella Matutina and Alpha et Omega continued for decades, mostly moribund by the Second World War. A reader encountering claims of high initiatory rank is entitled to notice that such claims have a poor historical record and are unfalsifiable by design.

## THE HONEST POSITION OF THIS CHAPTER

A book cannot confer initiation, and this one does not claim to. What has actually happened over the last century is that nearly all of the material formerly reserved to the grades has been published — Regardie's four volumes of Golden Dawn ritual between 1937 and 1940, Mathers's editions of the Solomonic texts, Betz's translation of the Papyri, critical editions of the Hermetica. The secrets are in print. Anyone can read them today.

And the result is instructive: the availability of the material turned out not to be the thing that mattered. What the grade systems supplied was not information but sequence, supervision, and other people who would tell you when you were wrong. Those remain scarce, and they were never in the books to begin with. The genuine Greater Mystery, on the evidence of the century since publication, is that reading the syllabus and doing the work are entirely different activities.

### **Greater Mysteries Warning**

This material is not to be taken lightly. It assumes dedication, preparation and — in every historical setting — guidance. Approach it with respect, and with a working suspicion of your own conclusions. The characteristic failure at this level is not danger but self-deception: the practitioner who has read everything, experienced something, and concluded that they have arrived. The tradition's own remedy is the fourth item on the list above, which is difficult to fake and tends to correct the rest.

**Sources:** Ancient mystery cults — Eleusis, Samothrace, Mithraic grades. *Corpus Hermeticum* I on direct experience over belief. Maier, *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617) for the claimed genealogy. Golden Dawn grade structure (1888–1903); Regardie, *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40) for the publication of the reserved material.

CHAPTER XVII

## Correspondences, Timing & Materials

Everything operative in this book eventually needs three things the earlier chapters have only gestured at: *when* to work, *what to work with*, and *how to make the object*. This chapter supplies them. It draws almost entirely on one source — the *Key of Solomon* in Mathers's 1889 translation, out of copyright and freely available — because a single coherent system used consistently is worth more than a synthesis assembled from six systems that disagree.

One caution before the tables. Correspondence tables have a way of acquiring an authority they have not earned. As Chapter 3 notes, the elaborate tables in modern handbooks are largely Golden Dawn constructions of the late nineteenth century, and even the older material below varies between manuscripts. These are the attributions of a tradition, recorded and dated. They are not laws of nature, and a practitioner who cannot say where a correspondence comes from is not using a tradition but repeating one.

### The planetary hours

This is the oldest and most useful piece of magical timekeeping, and it is genuinely simple once the one counter-intuitive part is understood: **a planetary hour is not sixty minutes.**

The *Key of Solomon* sets out the doctrine directly. The hours of day and night together are twenty-four, and each is governed by one of the seven planets "in regular order, commencing at the highest and descending to the lowest." The order it gives is the Chaldean order, by apparent speed, slowest first — and it gives the Hebrew names with them:

| ORDER | HEBREW     | PLANET  | METAL       | DAY RULED |
|-------|------------|---------|-------------|-----------|
| 1     | Shabbathai | Saturn  | Lead        | Saturday  |
| 2     | Tzedeq     | Jupiter | Tin         | Thursday  |
| 3     | Madim      | Mars    | Iron        | Tuesday   |
| 4     | Shemesh    | Sun     | Gold        | Sunday    |
| 5     | Nogah      | Venus   | Copper      | Friday    |
| 6     | Kokav      | Mercury | Mixed metal | Wednesday |
| 7     | Levanah    | Moon    | Silver      | Monday    |

The rule of the planets "begins from the dawn at the rising of the Sun on the day which takes its name from such planet," and each following hour goes to the next planet in the order, returning to the top of the list after the seventh. So on Saturday, Saturn rules the first hour, Jupiter the second, Mars the third, the Sun the fourth, Venus the fifth, Mercury the sixth, the Moon the seventh — and Saturn the eighth, and so on round.

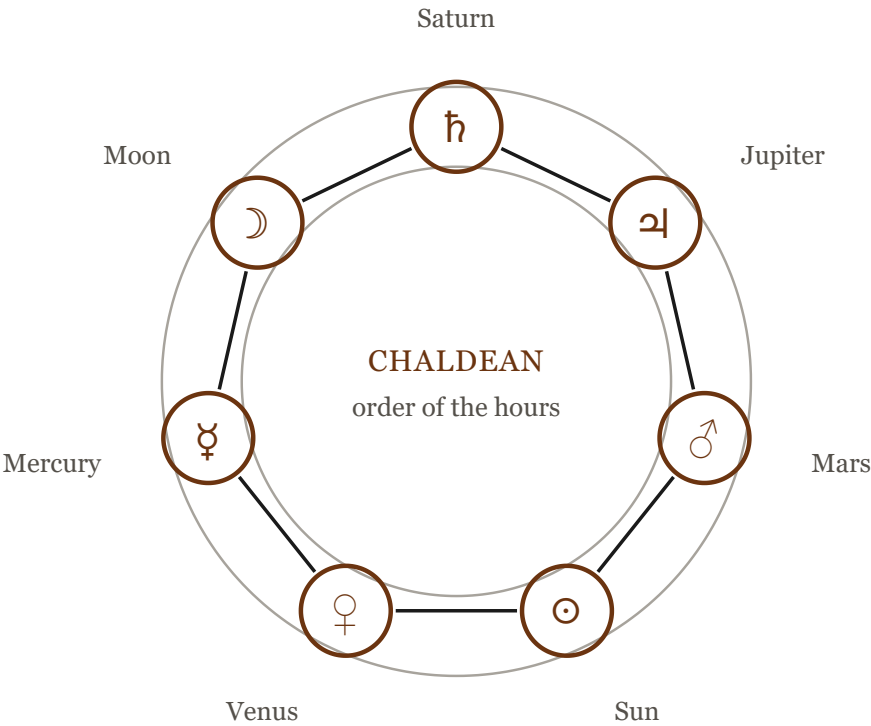


FIG. 1 — THE CHALDEAN ORDER. The seven planets by apparent speed, slowest first, as the *Key of Solomon* gives them. Each hour hands to the next planet clockwise; after the Moon it returns to Saturn. Because 24 is not a multiple of 7, counting twenty-four hours forward lands three places on — which is exactly how the days of the week are ordered. The week and this wheel generate each other. Drawn for this book.

## RECKONING THE HOUR

1. Find today's **sunrise and sunset** for your location, and tomorrow's sunrise.
2. **Daylight length**  $\div 12$  = the length of one hour of the day.  
**Night length**  $\div 12$  = one hour of the night. In London in June the day-hour runs to about eighty-two minutes and the night-hour to about thirty-eight; at the equinoxes both are sixty. This is what "unequal hours" means and it is why the reckoning has to be done afresh each time.
3. The **first hour of the day begins at sunrise** and is ruled by the planet of the weekday.
4. Count forward through the Chaldean order, one planet per hour, wrapping round after the Moon.
5. The **first hour of the night begins at sunset** and simply continues the count — hour 13 of the day-and-night sequence.

**Worked example.** A Wednesday on which the sun rises at 06:00 and sets at 18:00. Daylight is twelve hours, so each day-hour is sixty minutes. Wednesday is Mercury's, so 06:00–07:00 is Mercury; 07:00–08:00 the Moon; 08:00–09:00 Saturn; 09:00–10:00 Jupiter; 10:00–11:00 Mars; 11:00–12:00 the Sun; 12:00–13:00 Venus; and 13:00–14:00 Mercury again. The eighth hour of any day returns to the day's own planet, which is a useful check on your arithmetic.

A consequence worth noticing, because it is the elegant part of the system: count twenty-four hours forward from sunrise on any day and you land on the planet that rules the *next* day of the week, in exactly the order the week actually runs. The seven-day week and the Chaldean order generate each other.

What each planet is held to govern

The *Key of Solomon's* own list, condensed. It is given here as the text gives it, including the parts a modern practitioner will decline to use — the book's position on those is set out below the table.

| PLANET  | PROPER TO                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Saturn  | Summoning the souls of those who died naturally; fortune good or ill to buildings; familiar spirits in sleep; success or failure in business, possessions, goods, seeds and fruits; acquiring learning; and — the text is candid — destruction, death, hatred and discord. |
| Jupiter | Obtaining honours; acquiring riches; contracting friendships; preserving health; "arriving at all that thou canst desire."                                                                                                                                                 |
| Mars    | War; military honour; courage; overthrowing enemies; and ruin, slaughter, cruelty and discord.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Sun     | Temporal wealth, hope, gain, fortune, divination, the favour of princes; dissolving hostility and making friends.                                                                                                                                                          |
| Venus   | Forming friendships; kindness and love; "joyous and pleasant undertakings"; travelling.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Mercury | Eloquence and intelligence; promptitude in business; science and divination; apparitions; answers about the future; also thefts, writings, deceit and merchandise.                                                                                                         |
| Moon    | Embassies, voyages, envoys, messages, navigation; reconciliation; love; acquiring merchandise by water.                                                                                                                                                                    |

Roughly a fifth of that list is for harming people. The book prints it because a source should be reported as it stands rather than tidied, and because pretending the grimoire tradition was uniformly benign is its own kind of falsification — this is a literature that contains cursing, and Chapter 8 has already shown the same range in the ancient material. The ethical position of Chapter 1 is not suspended for interesting sources. Read those entries; do not work them.

## Planetary herbs

The standard English source for this is Nicholas Culpeper's *The Complete Herbal* of 1653, which assigns nearly every plant it treats to a planet in the opening line of its "Government and virtues" section — "It is an herb of Mercury," "under the dominion of the Moon." Culpeper is worth using rather than a modern table for three reasons: he is out of copyright, he states the attribution for each plant individually so it can be checked, and he is arguing a case rather than reciting one. He was a radical who translated the College of Physicians' Latin pharmacopoeia into English against their wishes, and the astrology is load-bearing in his medicine, not decorative.

The table below was compiled by reading his attributions directly, plant by plant, and is a selection rather than the whole herbal.

| PLANET         | HERBS, AS CULPEPER ASSIGNS THEM                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Saturn</b>  | Comfrey, crosswort, mullein, black hellebore, amaranthus, wintergreen, polypody of the oak, mosses                                                                                           |
| <b>Jupiter</b> | Agrimony, houseleek (sengreen), liverwort, scurvygrass, samphire, dandelion, costmary, clove gilliflowers, roses, chicory, henbane                                                           |
| <b>Mars</b>    | Anemone, masterwort, mustard, hyssop, barberry, sweet basil, carduus benedictus, gentian, madder, all-heal, crowfoot, horseradish, savine                                                    |
| <b>Sun</b>     | Angelica, marigold, celandine, saffron, garden rue, peony, centaury, lovage, tormentil, mistletoe, butterbur, holly                                                                          |
| <b>Venus</b>   | Alkanet, mugwort, daisy, coltsfoot, ground ivy (alehoof), columbine, foxglove, herb Robert, catmint, pennyroyal, parsnip, wood sage, dwarf elder, filipendula                                |
| <b>Mercury</b> | Fennel, parsley, horehound, liquorice, sweet marjoram, wild marjoram, calamint, elecampane, eyebright, germander, lily of the valley, wall rue, smallage, pellitory of the wall, honeysuckle |
| <b>Moon</b>    | Chickweed, cleavers, watercress, white lily, water lily, purslane, cucumber, clary, wild clary, coralwort, lady's smock, water caltrops, rattle grass                                        |

Three cautions, and they matter more than the table does.

**Culpeper is not always consistent with himself.** Plantain, for instance, is assigned to different planets in different places in the herbal, and where his own text disagrees it has been left out above rather than resolved by picking a favourite. Where other writers disagree with Culpeper — and they frequently do — there is no adjudicating authority. That is a fact about the tradition, not a defect in this table.

**These attributions are for ritual correspondence, not for medicine.** That distinction is not one Culpeper drew, and it matters here. Several plants in the table are seriously poisonous: black hellebore, henbane, foxglove and savine are all capable of killing an adult, and savine was used as an abortifacient at doses close to lethal ones. Others interact dangerously with prescribed drugs. Use them as symbols, as things to have on the altar or in the incense, and treat any suggestion in a seventeenth-century herbal about taking a plant internally as a historical statement rather than a dosage.

**A herb chosen for correspondence is a mnemonic and a focus.** It ties a working to a planet, a day, an hour and a metal in a coherent set, and coherence is most of what a correspondence system is for. Nothing in this book claims the plant acts on the working by an occult virtue of its own; the tradition does claim that, and the reader is at liberty to. What is not at liberty is the pharmacology.

## **Making a talisman**

A talisman — the grimoires say *pentacle* or *medal* — is a physical object carrying names, figures or characters, made under specific conditions. The *Key of Solomon* is unambiguous about how much weight it puts on these: "the whole science and understanding of our Key dependeth upon the operation, knowledge, and use of pentacles."

### THE PROCEDURE, FROM THE KEY OF SOLOMON

1. **Timing.** Make them "in the days and hours of Mercury, when the Moon is in an aerial or terrestrial sign" — Gemini, Libra or Aquarius; Taurus, Virgo or Capricorn — "she should also be in her increase."
2. **Place.** A room set apart and newly cleaned, where you will not be interrupted, incensed beforehand. The text asks for a clear sky.
3. **Material.** Either the metal proper to the planet (see the table above), or virgin paper — paper used for nothing else and handled by nobody else.
4. **Colours.** "Gold, cinnabar or vermilion red, and celestial or brilliant azure blue." Where the metal itself is used, the text says the colour rule need not be observed.
5. **Completion.** Finish within the hour you began in if you possibly can. If you must break off, wait for the proper day and hour to resume — do not simply carry on.
6. **Consecration.** Wrap the finished pentacle in fine silk. Set a censer of charcoal with frankincense, mastic and aloes. Standing in a circle with the names of God written between its two rims, face east and hold the pentacle in the smoke, reciting Psalms 8, 19, 27, 22, 32, 51, 29, 72, 54 and 134.
7. **Keeping.** Keep it in the silk. The tradition treats a consecrated object as spent if it is handled carelessly, which is a practice worth keeping whatever one thinks of the metaphysics.

Two remarks. First, the psalm numbers above are the English numbering; Mathers gives eight of them and the manuscripts give ten, which is a fair illustration of how much a "standard" grimoire text can vary. Second, notice what the procedure actually consists of: a defined material, a defined window, a requirement of unbroken attention, and a rule that a lapse means starting again at the proper time. Whatever else it is doing, it is an unusually well-designed instrument for making a person concentrate.

## **Incense**

The *Key of Solomon* divides perfumes simply — "those which are of sweet odour are for the good, those which are of evil savour are for the evil" — and for the good gives incense, aloes, nutmeg, gum benjamin and musk, with the manuscripts adding saffron, myrrh, costus and nard. Frankincense, mastic and aloes are named for consecrating pentacles.

The fire is kindled fresh, with flint and steel, in a newly glazed earthen vessel, and both fire and spices are blessed before use. For a modern practitioner the durable elements are: charcoal in a heatproof vessel on a stable surface, resins rather than perfumed sticks if you want the historical thing, and a window open. See the safety note in Chapter 7; incense in an unventilated room is a genuine respiratory hazard and the tradition, which worked in larger and draughtier rooms than yours, is no guide here.

## MODERN PRACTICE

Most contemporary practitioners keep the planetary hours and drop nearly everything else in this chapter, and that is a defensible reading of what the system is for. The hours cost nothing but arithmetic — there are calculators everywhere, though doing it by hand once is worth the twenty minutes — and they supply the thing the tradition is really offering: a reason to begin at a particular moment rather than whenever you get round to it. Talismans are made now in paper and ink far more often than in engraved metal, which the text itself permits. And the requirement to finish within the hour, or else wait for the next proper one, turns out to be the single most useful instruction in the chapter for anyone whose difficulty is not belief but consistency.

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**Sources:** *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th), trans. S. L. MacGregor Mathers, *The Key of Solomon the King* (London: George Redway, 1889) public domain. Book I, ch. 2 for the hours, the Chaldean order with its Hebrew names, the day rulerships and the operations proper to each planet; Book I, ch. 8 for the construction of pentacles, their timing, colours, consecration and psalms; Book I, ch. 18 for the planetary metals; Book II, ch. 10 for the incense and the exorcism of fire. Quotations are Mathers's wording. Manuscript variants throughout are recorded in Joseph H. Peterson's edition of that translation. Nicholas Culpeper, *The Complete Herbal* (London, 1653) public domain — the planetary herbs, compiled by reading his "Government and virtues" attributions plant by plant rather than from a secondary table; the selection is this book's, the assignments are his. The unequal-hour arithmetic, the worked example and the seasonal questions of Chapter 15 are this book's own; the remaining tables are the sources'.

CHAPTER XVIII

## **Sigils, Seals & Symbols**

A sigil is a name or an intention compressed into a line. That is the whole of the idea, and everything else in this chapter is a method for doing the compressing. The tradition has several, of different ages and very different standing, and they are worth keeping apart: some are ancient scripts nobody can read, some are Renaissance number-work, and one is a twentieth-century invention that most people now assume is old.

A caution belongs at the head of this chapter rather than buried in it. The meanings given below are the meanings the tradition assigns. They are conventions — widely shared, long-lived, internally coherent conventions, but conventions. A symbol does not carry its sense the way a stone carries its weight.

### **How the planetary glyphs are built**

The seven planetary signs are not arbitrary marks. They are assembled from three elements, and once that is visible they stop needing to be memorised.

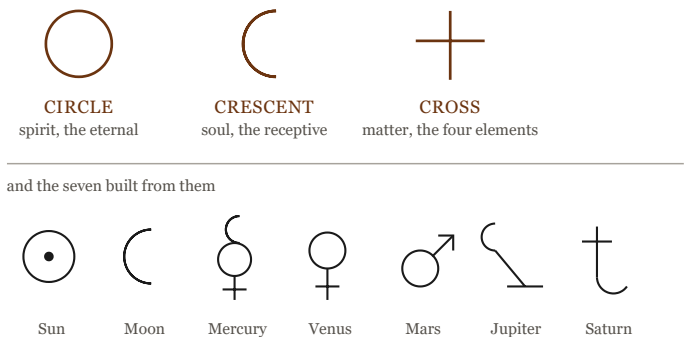


FIG. 1 — THE PARTS, AND THE SEVEN. Circle for spirit, crescent for soul, cross for matter. The Sun is spirit alone with its centre marked; the Moon is soul alone. Mercury is all three — crescent above circle above cross — which is why it is the mediating principle of Chapter 4. Venus is spirit over matter; Mars the same pair with the cross drawn as an arrow. Jupiter and Saturn are crescent and cross in the two possible orders: soul rising from matter, and matter weighing on soul. Drawn for this book; the reading of the parts is the traditional one.

## The planets and what they signify

| GLYPH | PLANET         | SIGNIFIES                                           | METAL       | DAY       |
|-------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------|-----------|
| ☉     | <b>Sun</b>     | the centre, vitality, the self that does not change | gold        | Sunday    |
| ☾     | <b>Moon</b>    | reflection, cycle, memory, the tidal part of a life | silver      | Monday    |
| ☿     | <b>Mercury</b> | speech, exchange, crossing between states           | quicksilver | Wednesday |
| ♀     | <b>Venus</b>   | attraction, harmony, what draws things together     | copper      | Friday    |
| ♂     | <b>Mars</b>    | severance, force, the cut that separates            | iron        | Tuesday   |
| ♃     | <b>Jupiter</b> | expansion, mercy, increase and its dangers          | tin         | Thursday  |
| ♄     | <b>Saturn</b>  | limit, time, structure, the boundary of a thing     | lead        | Saturday  |

The metals and the days are the *Key of Solomon's*, set out with the hours in Chapter 17. The significations are the common stock of the astrological and magical literature and cannot be traced to a single author.

## The elements, the principles and the metals

The alchemical symbols of Chapter 4 work on the same logic of assembly. The four elements are one triangle with one modification:

| SIGN | ELEMENT | THE RULE                                            |
|------|---------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| ◊    | Fire    | triangle, apex up — ascending, hot and dry          |
| ◻    | Water   | triangle, apex down — descending, cold and moist    |
| ◊̄   | Air     | fire's triangle with a bar — ascending, but bounded |
| ◻̄   | Earth   | water's triangle with a bar — descending, bounded   |

Two triangles and two bars encode four things and their relations to each other, which is an efficient piece of design and the reason the scheme lasted. Superimpose the fire and water triangles and you have the hexagram of Chapter 3: everything above and everything below, in one figure.

Seals from the squares

The most systematic sigil method in the Western tradition is Renaissance, and it is arithmetic. Each planet is assigned a *kamea* — a magic square whose rows, columns and diagonals all sum alike — of a size matching the planet's order in the Chaldean sequence: Saturn 3×3, Jupiter 4×4, Mars 5×5, Sun 6×6, Venus 7×7, Mercury 8×8, Moon 9×9. The scheme is set out in Agrippa's *De occulta philosophia*, Book II, in the chapter titled "Of the tables of the Planets, their virtues, forms, and what Divine names, Intelligencies, and Spirits are set over them."

| THE SQUARE OF SATURN |   |   | READING IT                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------|---|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4                    | 9 | 2 | Every row, column and diagonal sums to <b>15</b> ; the whole square sums to 45. This is the only 3×3 magic square that exists, up to rotation and reflection — a mathematical fact, not a magical claim, and one reason the figure impressed people who met it. |
| 3                    | 5 | 7 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 8                    | 1 | 6 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

### TRACING A SEAL ON A KAMEA

1. **Choose the planet** whose nature suits the work, from the table above.
2. **Write the name** — of the intelligence, the spirit, or the intention — in Hebrew letters, and take each letter's numerical value.
3. **Reduce each value** to fall within the square: for the 3×3 of Saturn, values run 1 to 9, so 300 becomes 3 and 40 becomes 4. The conventions for reducing differ between authorities, and this is where two practitioners working "the same" method get different figures.
4. **Mark the first number** on the square with a small circle, then draw a line to the cell of the next number, and so on to the last, ending with a short bar.
5. **The resulting figure is the seal.** It is drawn on the metal or the paper of Chapter 17, in the planet's hour.

What the method actually does is turn a word into a path. Nothing about the line is arbitrary once the name and the square are fixed — but nothing about it is inevitable either, since the reduction rules are conventions.

### Signs nobody can read

Against all that stands the oldest layer, the *charaktères* of Chapter 8: letter-like shapes with small rings at their terminals, thick through the magical papyri and the curse tablets, and not decipherable. They are not a cipher for words, they encode no name, and no key has ever been found — which makes them

the honest limit of a chapter about meanings. Some signs in this tradition mean something. Some are older than the traditions that explain them, and the explanations came later.

Between the two sits **John Dee's *Monas Hieroglyphica*** (Antwerp, 1564), a single composed glyph — Moon, Sun, cross and the sign of Aries stacked into one figure — about which Dee wrote a whole book of theorems. It is the most ambitious sigil in the tradition: an attempt to compress the entire cosmos into one mark, made by a man who thought the compression would be legible to anyone who understood it. Almost nobody has.

### MODERN PRACTICE

The method most people now mean by "sigil magic" is none of the above. It was set out by the artist **Austin Osman Spare** in the early twentieth century: write the intention as a sentence, strike out repeated letters, and combine what remains into a single abstract figure, which is then charged and deliberately forgotten. It is elegant, it works on its own terms, and it is about a hundred years old — not medieval, not Solomonic, and owing nothing to the kameas. It is included here because it is what a reader is most likely to encounter, and because a book that dates the Kybalion ought to date this too. Spare died in 1956, so his own writings remain in copyright; the method is described here rather than quoted.

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**Sources:** The construction of the planetary glyphs from circle, crescent and cross is the traditional reading, and is not attributable to a single author. Planetary metals and days: *Clavicula Salomonis*, trans. Mathers (1889), Book I, chs. 2 and 18 public domain. The kameas and the seal-tracing method: Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book II — **the text of Book II was not obtained for this edition**; the chapter title is quoted from the table of contents of the 1651 English translation, and the method is described from the general literature rather than from Agrippa's own words. The 3×3 square and its uniqueness are mathematical. *Charaktères*: see Chapter 8. Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (Antwerp: Willem Silvius, 31 March 1564) public domain. Austin Osman Spare (1886–1956) in copyright — method described, not quoted.

## Sources & Bibliography

Every source cited in this grimoire is listed below with its date, its author or translator where known, and its copyright status where that affects availability. Entries are grouped by period so that the shape of the tradition's actual chronology is visible at a glance — which is, in itself, the argument of this book.

## ON WHAT "VERIFIED" MEANS HERE

Each entry below was checked for author, date and status before being included. That checking was done at two different depths, and the difference is worth stating. A first pass used reference scholarship and encyclopedic sources. A second pass went to primary materials — the 1849 Rheinwald edition of Andreae's *Vita*, Waite's 1887 and 1924 volumes in full text, Yates, Chapel's 2013 article — for the claims this book's argument actually rests on: the Kybalion attribution, the dating of the *Hermetica*, Casaubon's redating, Andreae's *ludibrium*, Edighoffer on the Brotherhood, and the provenance of the Papyri. Entries touched only by the first pass are therefore less securely verified than those touched by the second. A third pass, adversarial by design, sent independent readers to attack the results of the second, and a fourth did the same for the chapters on alchemy and the Emerald Tablet.

That second pass corrected this book in several places, including two of its own load-bearing claims — Ficino's completion date, and the widespread belief that he thought the *Hermetica* older than Moses. It also found that several sentences previously presented here as scholars' words were in fact encyclopedic paraphrase in quotation marks. Those have been re-sourced or unquoted. The lesson generalises, and it is the reason this section exists: a paraphrase acquires false authority the moment it is given quotation marks and a name.

The third pass is worth reporting too, because it found something the second could not see. Correcting a source is where over-correction happens. Three of the second pass's own fixes were themselves wrong — a lexicon cited for a word that is not in it, a causal chain no scholar asserts, and a hedge hardened into a flat denial — and each was introduced in the act of repairing something else. The failure mode of careful revision is not carelessness; it is momentum.

A fifth pass, over the alchemy chapter, found the defect this book had been least equipped to catch. Every earlier sweep looked for encyclopedic paraphrase *in quotation marks*. The worst sentence in Chapter 4 had no quotation marks at all: it reproduced an unsourced paragraph from an encyclopedia closely enough to be recognisable, attributed it to "researchers of the Rosicrucian circle" — a body this book invented — and called it "the historical record of the alchemists themselves." A quotation-mark sweep will never find that. Worse, the sentence was load-bearing: it was the evidence offered for the chapter's opening claim, and the specialists turn out to say close to the opposite. That claim has been rewritten to report the dispute instead of settling it, which is what this book promises to do and had not done here.

The fourth pass found the same three failure modes recurring in its own proposed corrections — a lexicon cited for a sense it does not carry, two causal chains no scholar asserts, and three hedges hardened into flat denials — and blocked all of them before they reached the page. It also found the worst single defect in this book: the text of the Emerald Tablet printed in Chapter 5 had been taken, character for character, from an encyclopedia, while the sentence above it claimed it came from Newton's papers. It differed from the manuscript in sense as well as spelling, and silently dropped a gloss of Newton's from inside quotation marks. It has been reset from the manuscript transcription. A book that spends a chapter on how the Emerald Tablet was misattributed for eight hundred years is not entitled to be careless about where it got its copy of the Emerald Tablet.

Where the record is genuinely unsettled — who assembled the Lesser Banishing Ritual and when, the precise origin of individual Golden Dawn exercises, the relative priority of the Greek and Latin Solomonic texts, the ownership of the Theban Magical Library, the meaning of *ludibrium* — the relevant chapter reports the dispute rather than choosing a convenient answer. Claims in the body text that carry no citation are ones where a specific attribution could not be verified; they are written as general

statements for that reason. A bibliography's usefulness depends entirely on the reader being able to trust that nothing was added to make it look longer.

### **Ancient: the primary material (c. 100 BCE – c. 400 CE)**

*Corpus Hermeticum* — seventeen Greek treatises, composed c. 100–300 CE. The collection's date and compiler are unknown; first attested in Byzantium in Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078), with surviving manuscripts late medieval and later.

Nag Hammadi Hermetica — three tractates in Codex VI: *The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6), the Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with its Scribal Note (VI,7a), and *Asclepius* 21–29 (VI,8) — a single continuous excerpt, not scattered fragments. The Coptic is ancient, but there is no public-domain edition or translation: the codices were found in 1945 and first published in the 1970s.

*Asclepius* — surviving mainly in Latin translation, with Greek and Coptic fragments.

*Papyri Graecae Magicae* (PGM) — extant texts from the late 4th c. BCE (PGM XL, the curse of Artemisia, an isolated outlier) and 1st c. BCE down to the 5th c. CE, Christian magical texts into the 6th; the bulk 3rd–5th c. CE. In Greek, Demotic and Old Coptic. Provenance largely the Theban material assembled by Jean d'Anastasi — vice-consul and from 1828 Consul-General of Sweden and Norway at Alexandria — acquired through agents before 1828 and dispersed to Leiden (Dutch government purchase, 1828), the British Museum, the Louvre, the Bibliothèque Nationale and Berlin. Ownership of the "Theban Magical Library" is disputed; Betz's single-collector suggestion is hedged, and Dosoo argues for multiple collectors.

Leyden papyrus X (P. Leid. I 397) and the Stockholm papyrus (P. Holm., Kungliga Biblioteket) — alchemical texts of the 4th c. CE from the same reconstructed Theban group, in the same hand or very nearly as PGM XIII. Not to be confused with Leiden W (P. Leid. I 395), which is PGM XIII itself. Both are edited in Berthelot and Ruelle, *Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs* (Paris: Steinheil, 1887–88). EDITION PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Defixiones* (curse and binding tablets) — the earliest from the late 6th and early 5th centuries BCE, the oldest of them Sicilian; recovered from Sicily, Athens, Asia Minor, Rome and Egypt, over a thousand texts in all. Jessica L. Lamont, *Greece & Rome* 69, no. 1 (2022), 27–51, for the dating. Audollent, *Defixionum tabellae* (1904), remains the standard corpus. EDITION PUBLIC DOMAIN

Zosimos of Panopolis (fl. c. 300 CE) — the earliest alchemical writer whose substantial corpus survives under his own name; the source for the colour stages and for Mary the Jewess.

Pseudo-Democritus, *Physika kai mystika* — often described as among the oldest surviving alchemical writings. Ancient testimony names four books under the name, on gold, silver, stones and purple. Whether the Greek stage-names *melanosis*, *leukosis*, *xanthosis* and *iosis* all occur in it was not checked for this edition against Matteo Martelli, *The Four Books of Pseudo-Democritus* (2013), which could not be obtained. Liddell–Scott's citations for *iosis* are the Leiden magical papyrus, Olympiodorus and Zosimos, not Democritus.

Mary the Jewess (Maria Hebraea), Greco-Roman Egypt, most likely between the 1st and 3rd centuries CE — the specialist literature declines to name a city (some scholars: no later than the 1st) — credited via Zosimos with the *tribikos*, the *kerotakis* and the *bain-marie*; the Axiom of Maria. Named among the alchemists listed in Ibn al-Nadīm, *Kitāb al-Fihrist* (10th c.) — the figure of fifty-two that popular accounts give was not checked against Dodge's translation for this edition. The claim in George Syncellus (active c. 800; the *Chronography* c. 808–810) that she was among the initiators of Democritus is chronologically impossible.

## Medieval and Arabic (8th – 15th centuries)

*Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣanʿat al-Ṭabīʿa* (Book of the Secret of Creation and the Art of Nature) — compiled in Arabic in the late 8th or early 9th century; contains the oldest known recension of the Emerald Tablet. Dating contested: Ruska (1926) 6th–8th c.; Kraus (1942–43) c. 813–833; Weisser (1980) c. 750–800. Presents itself as a translation of a treatise by Apollonius of Tyana (Balīnūs).

Pseudo-Jābir ibn Ḥayyān, *Kitāb Uṣūqus al-Uss al-Thānī* (Second Book of the Element of the Foundation) — a shorter version of the Tablet: nine lines against the *Sirr al-khalīqa*'s fifteen, with lines 6, 8 and 11–15 absent and other parts corrupt. Published and analysed in Holmyard, "The Emerald Table," *Nature* 112 (1923), 525–26, and Ruska (1926), p. 121, who takes this version to be dependent on the *Sirr al-khalīqa* rather than earlier than it.

Ibn Umayl (Abū ʿAbd Allāh Muḥammad ibn Umayl al-Tamīmī, c. 900–960; Latin "Senior Zadith filius Hamuel"), *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth* — c. 10th century; later translated into Latin as the *Tabula Chemica*. Quotes the Tablet and glosses it clause by clause (Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, *Ambix* 3 (1949), 69–90, sect. XXI at p. 81). Its own frame story — a seated figure in a *birbā*, rendered "the

Pyramid" in Stapleton's translation, holding a stone slab — concerns a different object; the Tablet text appears separately later in the treatise. He is **not** the source of the discovery narrative, which belongs to the *Sirr al-khalīqa*.

Pseudo-Aristotle, *Sirr al-Asrār* (*Secretum Secretorum*, Secret of Secrets) — 10th century; the long version carries the Tablet toward its end. Latin text in Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Oxford, 1920), pp. 115–17, where it is described as appearing "in its earliest known form."

Jābir ibn Ḥayyān; Abū Bakr al-Rāzī — the Arabic-Islamic alchemical tradition through which much of this material reached Latin Europe. Note that al-Rāzī wrote his own *Kitāb Sirr al-asrār*, which is a different work from the pseudo-Aristotelian *Sirr al-Asrār* above.

Latin transmission of the Emerald Tablet: Robert of Chester (1144), *Book on the Composition of Alchemy* — generally considered the first Latin translation of an Arabic alchemical treatise, though the attribution to Robert rests only on a prologue that Marion Dapsens, *Studia graeco-arabica* 6 (2016), 121–40, concludes is genuinely his yet probably not written for this text; the **vulgate version**, probably 12th century, tentatively attributed to Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–45), surviving embedded in an anonymous Latin compilation of commentaries on the Tablet and itself the most circulated version and the basis of all later editions; Hugo of Santalla (c. 1145–51), from the *Secret of Creation* itself, surviving in a single contemporary manuscript (Paris, BnF lat. 13951) and one copy; Philip of Tripoli (13th c.), via the *Secret of Secrets*, whose more than six hundred manuscript witnesses (Williams, 2003, p. 349) are what give "by some measures" its content.

Commentaries on the Emerald Tablet: Hortulanus (Ortolanus), probably active in the first half of the 14th century — the commentary that circulated most widely in print (1541, 1545, 1560 as the *Compendium alchimiae* under Johannes de Garlandia's name, and 1571), reading the text as laboratory recipe; Albertus Magnus, *On Minerals*, c. 1250; Roger Bacon, c. 1275–80, who believed the *Secret of Secrets* genuinely Aristotle's; Johannes Trithemius, early 16th century, who shifted the reading toward the Pythagorean monad and the *anima mundi*.

*Ars Notoria* — 13th century (Véronèse's version A); the glossed version at the end of the 13th, surviving in three 14th-century MSS; the core *Flores aurei* possibly later 12th. Later absorbed as book five of the *Lemegeton*.

*Clavicula Salomonis* (*Key of Solomon*) — the Latin/Italian *Clavicula* is now generally placed in the **16th century**, possibly the 15th: Mathiesen (2007) argues it was translated in Italy from a Greek original that had reached Italy by the 15th century, and that no Western manuscript is securely earlier than the 16th. The older attribution to the 14th or

15th century derives from A. E. Waite rather than from modern scholarship. Surviving Western MSS are chiefly late 16th–18th century — of 122 recorded by Mathiesen only eight are 16th-century. Notable witnesses: Bodleian MS Michael 276 (Italian; undated by Mathiesen, 17th c. per Peterson) and BL Sloane MS 3847 (English, 1572). Pseudepigraphic.

*Magical Treatise of Solomon* (*Apotelesmatikē pragmateia Solomōntos*), also circulating as *The Little Key of the Whole Art of Hygromancy* — known from sixteen or seventeen Greek manuscripts, six of them 15th-century, including BL Harley MS 5596. Priority against the *Clavicula* is not finally settled, but the specialist literature leans to the Greek as the ancestral form, from which the earliest Western version was almost certainly translated. Armand Delatte transcribed **one Athens manuscript** in *Anecdota Atheniensia* (Liège/Paris, 1927), pp. 397–445 — not the Harley manuscript. Fuller editions: Pablo A. Torijano, *Solomon the Esoteric King* (Brill, 2002); Ioannis Marathakis, *The Magical Treatise of Solomon or Hygromanteia* (Golden Hoard, 2011).

## Renaissance and early modern (15th – 17th centuries)

Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) — Latin translation of the *Corpus Hermeticum* (treatises I–XIV), *Liber de potestate et sapientia Dei / Pimander*, completed 1463 on Cosimo de' Medici's order and dedicated to him (d. 1464), from Laurentianus LXXI, 33; first printed at Treviso by Gerardus de Lisa, 18 December 1471, in an edition Ficino neither prepared nor authorised. Lodovico Lazzarelli (1447–1500).

Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486–1535), *De occulta philosophia libri tres* — Book I 1531 (Paris: Christian Wechel; Antwerp: Johannes Grapheus — the Cologne 1531 imprint often listed alongside these is unattested in the catalogues); complete three books [Cologne]: Johannes Soter, July 1533 (VD16 A 1180). English translation by "J.F." (probably John French), 1651. PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* — earliest imprint Marburg, 1559 (VD16 A 1185), twenty-four years after Agrippa's death; **spurious**, denounced as a forgery by Johann Weyer, who called it an "abominabilis libellus" foisted on a man some twenty-seven years dead. PUBLIC DOMAIN

George Ripley, *Compound of Alchymy* (1471) — the Twelve Gates. Samuel Norton (16th century) — fourteen stages.

*De Alchemia*, ed. "Chrysogonus Polydorus" (probably a pseudonym for Andreas Osiander), Johann Petreius, Nuremberg, **1541** — the *editio princeps* of the Tablet as a free-standing alchemical text, and the first to print it with Hortulanus's commentary; a different Latin version was already in print inside the *Secretum secretorum* by 1501 at the latest

(Achillini's Bologna edition), and possibly in the incunables of the 1480s. PUBLIC DOMAIN

John Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564). Dee and Kelley's Enochian diaries (1580s).

Johann Weyer (1515–1588), *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563, *libri V*) — argued against the witch persecutions and criticised the *Malleus Maleficarum*. The *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum* was **not** in the first edition: it was appended to the fifth (Basel, March 1577) and retained in the sixth (1583), and Weyer edited rather than authored the list. Weyer became a live-in *famulus* of Agrippa's at fifteen.

Paracelsus (1493 or 1494–1541; the birth year is inferred rather than documented) — iatrochemistry and the medical application of alchemy. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Heinrich Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* — first printing Hamburg, **1595**; the familiar Hanau 1609 edition is the second and last, published posthumously (Khunrath d. 1605), edited by Erasmus Wolfart, with nine engraved plates. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Isaac Casaubon (1559–1614), *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, 1614), written against Baronius's *Annales* — argued the Greek Hermetica were composed partly out of Plato and the Platonists and partly out of Christian scripture, in Greek later than that current around the birth of Christ. His own formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*; he gives no numeric range. PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Fama Fraternitatis Rosae Crucis* — MS circulating c. 1610; published Cassel, **1614**. PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Confessio Fraternitatis* — Cassel: Wilhelm Wessel, **1615**, appended to Philippus a Gabella, *Secretioris Philosophiae Consideratio brevis* (reissued 1616). PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (*Chymical Wedding*) — **1616**; acknowledged by Johann Valentin Andreae (1586–1654) in his posthumous autobiography, and described by him as a *ludibrium*. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Johann Valentin Andreae, *Vita ab ipso conscripta* — unpublished in his lifetime; first printed in German translation by D. C. Seybold, *Selbstbiographie Joh. Valentin Andreae's* (Winterthur, 1799), the Latin original ed. F. H. Rheinwald (Berlin, 1849). Lib. I, p. 10 for the *ludibrium* passage; Lib. II, p. 46 for "that Rosicrucian *ludibrium*." PUBLIC DOMAIN

Michael Maier (1568?–1622; VD17 and GND give 1569), *Atalanta fugiens* (Oppenheim: Hieronymus Galler for Johann Theodor de Bry, 1617, plates engraved by Matthäus Merian the Elder; a further Oppenheim printing followed in 1618, neither title page carrying an edition statement); *Silentium Post Clamores* (Frankfurt am Main: Lucas

Jennis, 1617, with a German translation the same year). Robert Fludd (1574–1637); Elias Ashmole (1617–1692). PUBLIC DOMAIN

*Lemegeton (Lesser Key of Solomon)* — compiled mid-17th century from older materials; five books: *Ars Goetia*, *Ars Theurgica Goetia*, *Ars Paulina*, *Ars Almadel*, *Ars Notoria*.

## Modern: orders, editions and interpretation (19th – 21st centuries)

A. E. Waite, *The Real History of the Rosicrucians* (London: George Redway, 1887) — source of the "reprehensible hoax" verdict on Andreae (p. 240) and of "before he was sixteen" (p. 232) PUBLIC DOMAIN; *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (London: William Rider & Son, 1924) — where Waite argues at length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped (pp. 122 n., 207), a position already implicit in 1887 (pp. 225, 234). Citations of either book for the hoax reading misread him.

S. L. MacGregor Mathers (trans.), *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) — "first Translated and Edited from Ancient MSS. in the British Museum" (the British Library did not exist until 1973); seven codices, incl. Add. MS 10,862, Sloane 1307 and 3091, Harleian 3981, King's 288, Lansdowne 1202–1203. Limited to 500 copies. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn — founded 1887–88 by William Robert Woodman, William Wynn Westcott and S. L. MacGregor Mathers; Isis-Urania Temple, London, 1888; the original order fractured in 1903, successor bodies continuing for decades. Cipher Manuscripts in Trithemius cipher, decoded by Westcott in 1887.

[S. L. MacGregor Mathers (trans., uncredited)] and Aleister Crowley (ed.), *The Book of the Goetia of Solomon the King, Translated into the English Tongue by a Dead Hand ... The Whole Edited, Verified, Introduced and Commented by Aleister Crowley* (Boleskine, Foyers, Inverness: Society for the Propagation of Religious Truth, 1904) — Book One of the *Lemegeton* only, not the complete *Lesser Key*. Mathers, the uncredited translator, was alive until 1918; "a dead hand" is Crowley's insult. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Joseph H. Peterson (ed.), *The Lesser Key of Solomon: Lemegeton Clavicula Salomonis Regis* (2001), based on BL Sloane MS 3825 — the authority for the dating and manuscript basis of the whole five-book work. IN COPYRIGHT

G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes*, 3 vols (London and Benares: Theosophical Publishing Society, 1906) — Theosophically inflected; scholarly superseded, but the most accessible free route to the Hermetica. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Three Initiates [William Walker Atkinson, 1862–1932], *The Kybalion* (Chicago, 1908) — New Thought; source of the Seven Hermetic Principles. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Karl Preisendanz, *Papyri Graecae Magicae. Die Griechischen Zauberpapyri*, 2 vols (1928, 1931) — the critical edition; vol. 1 available at the Internet Archive. A third volume was set and reached galley proof, its preface dated Pentecost 1941, when Teubner's Leipzig house was bombed on 4 December 1943; the proofs survived and circulate in photocopy, and the 1941 preface is reprinted in the second edition. 2nd edition with Albert Henrichs, 1973–74. IN COPYRIGHT — Preisendanz d. 1968, Henrichs d. 2017; in the United States only volume 1 has entered the public domain (1 January 2024), volume 2 following in 2027, so the Internet Archive recommendation above is sound for US readers only. Superseded for the formularies by Faraone and Torallas Tovar (2022).

Walter Scott, *Hermetica*, 4 vols (1924–36) — foundational; editorial choices now contested. Scott died in 1925 after only vol. 1 had appeared; A. S. Ferguson (1883–1958) saw vols 2–3 through the press and wholly authored vol. 4, the *Testimonia*. Catalogue hazard: some records misattribute the work to Walter Scott the novelist (1771–1832). MIXED — Scott's own matter is public domain, but Ferguson d. 1958, so volume 4 entire and his additions to volumes 2–3 remain in copyright in the UK and EU until 1 January 2029.

Israel Regardie, *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order*, 4 vols (1937–40) — the publication of the order's reserved material. IN COPYRIGHT — Regardie d. 1985, so protected in the UK and EU until 2056; scans on the Internet Archive are not evidence to the contrary. The underlying Golden Dawn documents are themselves out of copyright (Mathers d. 1918, Westcott d. 1925, Woodman d. 1891); Regardie's compilation and commentary are a separate protected layer.

Bernard Gorceix, *La Bible des Rose-Croix* (1970) — translations and commentary on all three manifestos.

Paul Arnold, *Histoire des Rose-Croix* (Paris, 1935), p. 50 — renders *ludibrium* "une farce." Charles Webster, "Macaria: Samuel Hartlib and the Great Reformation," *Acta Comeniana* 26 (1970), p. 149 — "derisive terms." Against these, Yates (pp. 68, 184–85) reads it as theatrical fiction: "not a hoax, but a dramatic presentation." Lexicography: Lewis & Short, s.v. *ludibrium*.

Renko Geffarth — archive-based study of the Gold- und Rosenkreuzer; its reviewer (Michael Driedger, *H-German*, Feb. 2010) describes it as covering circles existing "from around 1760 until sometime after 1790" — a statement of duration, not a founding date.

Frances A. Yates, *The Rosicrucian Enlightenment* (1972) — the standard modern treatment; see Brian Vickers's critique, *Journal of Modern History* 51:2 (1979). IN COPYRIGHT

Alan F. Segal, "Hellenistic Magic: Some Questions of Definition" (1981).

Garth Fowden, *The Egyptian Hermes: A Historical Approach to the Late Pagan Mind* (1986).

Hans Dieter Betz (ed.), *The Greek Magical Papyri in Translation, Including the Demotic Spells* (University of Chicago Press, **1986**; 2nd ed. 1992) — the standard English translation. IN COPYRIGHT

Brian P. Copenhaver, *Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius* (Cambridge, **1992**) — the standard modern scholarly translation. IN COPYRIGHT

David Frankfurter, "Ritual Expertise in Roman Egypt and the Problem of the Category 'Magician'" (1997).

Roland Edighoffer, "Rosicrucianism I: First half of the 17th Century," in Wouter J. Hanegraaff (ed.), in collaboration with Antoine Faivre, Roelof van den Broek and Jean-Pierre Brach, *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, **2005**), 1009–1014, at 1009 and 1014; and Edighoffer, "Rosicrucianism II: 18th Century," *ibid.*, 1014–1017, at 1015, for the 1763 date. IN COPYRIGHT

M. David Litwa, *Hermetica II: The Excerpts of Stobaeus, Papyrus Fragments, and Ancient Testimonies* (2018). IN COPYRIGHT

Nicholas E. Chapel, "The Kybalion's New Clothes," *Journal of the Western Mystery Tradition* No. 24, Vol. 3 (2013) — the detailed study of the work's relation to the historical Hermetic current; source of the David Hartley (1705–1757) origin for the principle of vibration — a derivation that is Chapel's own reconstruction, his only supporting citation being Barbara Oberg, "David Hartley and the Association of Ideas," *Journal of the History of Ideas* 37, no. 3 (1976), 442–43, a study of associationism that does not mention Hermeticism.

C. G. Jung — the reading of the alchemical corpus as a symbolic account of individuation; 20th-century interpretation. IN COPYRIGHT

Isaac Newton — English rendering of the Emerald Tablet, Keynes MS. 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v; text from *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), ALCH00017, transcribed by John A. Johnson. His Latin copy on a later leaf of the same manuscript reads *pater omnis perfectionis* where the vulgate has *telesmi*; B. J. T. Dobbs argued the English was made from a French version, probably the *Bibliothèque des philosophes* (1672–8). NEWTON'S WORDING  
PUBLIC DOMAIN

Helena Blavatsky, *Isis Unveiled* (New York: J. W. Bouton, 1877), vol. 1, pp. 294, 306, 507; *The Secret Doctrine* (1888) — popularised the paraphrase "as above, so below," which she quotes as an existing "Hermetic axiom" rather than presenting as her own. The earliest attestation of the maxim in this Hermetic sense is not established; the words occur in English before 1877 in unrelated devotional use, which makes "the wording is hers" harder to assert rather than easier. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Robert Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Opera hactenus inedita Rogeri Baconi, fasc. V; Oxford: Clarendon, 1920) — the critical edition of the Latin *Secret of Secrets*; the Emerald Table at pp. 115–17, described there as appearing in its earliest known form. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer, "The Emerald Table," *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine* 21 (1928), 485–501 — the source of the English of the vulgate's second verse quoted in Chapter 5. A separate Steele and Singer article on the Tablet appeared in the *Journal of Chemical Education* 3, no. 8 (1926); the two should not be merged. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Françoise Hudry (ed.), "Le *De secretis nature* du ps.-Apollonius de Tyane, traduction latine par Hugues de Santalla du *Kitāb sirr al-ḥalīqa*," *Chrysopoeia* 6 (1997–99), 1–154 — the critical edition of Hugo of Santalla's translation. IN COPYRIGHT

Marion Dapsens, "De la *Risālat Maryānus* au *De Compositione alchemiae*," *Studia graeco-arabica* 6 (2016), 121–40 — the current specialist treatment of the Robert of Chester attribution. Open access, not public domain.

Steven J. Williams, *The Secret of Secrets: The Scholarly Career of a Pseudo-Aristotelian Text in the Latin Middle Ages* (University of Michigan Press, 2003) — p. 349 for the manuscript count; and "Roger Bacon and His Edition of the Pseudo-Aristotelian *Secretum secretorum*," *Speculum* 69, no. 1 (1994), 57–73. IN COPYRIGHT

Lawrence M. Principe and William R. Newman, "Some Problems with the Historiography of Alchemy," in *Secrets of Nature: Astrology and Alchemy in Early Modern Europe*, ed. Newman and Anthony Grafton (MIT Press, 2001), 385–431; and Principe, *The Secrets of Alchemy* (Chicago, 2013), pp. 90–105, 98 — the argument that the inner-discipline reading descends from Mary Anne Atwood (1850) and Ethan Allen Hitchcock. Neither was reached directly for this edition; both are reported from Zuber. IN COPYRIGHT

Mike A. Zuber, *Spiritual Alchemy from the Age of Jacob Boehme to Mary Anne Atwood, 1600–1900* (PhD diss., Universiteit van Amsterdam, 2017), Introduction — the route by which the Principe–Newman positions, the list of their critics (p. 24) and the Khunrath material (pp. 50–51) were verified for this book. Open access, which is not the same as public domain.

Hereward Tilton, "Michael Maier: An Itinerant Alchemist in Late Renaissance Germany," in *Furnace and Fugue: A Digital Edition of Michael Maier's "Atalanta fugiens" (1618) with Scholarly Commentary*, ed. Tara Nummedal and Donna Bilak (University of Virginia Press, 2020) — the source for Maier's laboratory work, the Carpathian mines, the *aurum potabile*, and his judgement of Khunrath. Open access, in copyright. Tilton's *The Quest for the Phoenix* (de Gruyter, 2003) is cited at p. 97 through Forshaw's note and was not reached directly.

Peter J. Forshaw, "Michael Maier and Mythoalchemy," in the same volume — for gold-making as part of Maier's repertoire and against relegating *Atalanta fugiens* to a "spiritual quest." Open access, in copyright.

Lawrence M. Principe, *The Aspiring Adept: Robert Boyle and His Alchemical Quest* (Princeton, 1998) — not reached directly; quoted through Linden, p. 234. William R. Newman, *Newton the Alchemist* (Princeton, 2019) — not reached; the 1936 Sotheby's sale and the "experimental chymistry" characterisation come from the publisher's description page, which is marketing copy rather than scholarship. The word count and the composition of the corpus are better anchored: *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton* project (W. R. Newman, gen. ed., Indiana University) gives about a million words across some hundred and thirty manuscripts, and describes the 1936 Sotheby's sale as three hundred twenty-nine lots, over a third of them alchemical. The project's own pages decline to settle what the papers were for. IN COPYRIGHT

Stanton J. Linden (ed.), *The Alchemy Reader: From Hermes Trismegistus to Isaac Newton* (Cambridge, 2003) — Introduction, p. 17, for the caution on the alchemical operations in Chapter 4; p. 16 for the coexistence of the metallic, medical and spiritual goals; p. 234, reporting Principe on Boyle. Verified for this edition from a full-text scan rather than the Cambridge printing, with the page fixed from the running heads of the adjacent leaves. IN COPYRIGHT

*The Mirror of Alchimy* (London: printed by Thomas Creede for Richard Olive, 1597) — the Elizabethan English of Hortulanus's commentary. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, "The Sayings of Hermes Quoted in the *Mā' al-Waraqī* of Ibn Umail," *Ambix* 3, nos 3–4 (1949), 69–90. IN COPYRIGHT

Allen G. Debus, *Alchemy and Early Modern Chemistry: Papers from Ambix* (Jeremy Mills, 2004), p. 415 — for Trithemius's metaphysical reading and its adoption by Dee, Agrippa and Gerhard Dorn. IN COPYRIGHT

*The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010) — diplomatic and normalised transcriptions of Newton's alchemical manuscripts, including

Keynes MS. 28 (ALCH00017). Newton's wording is public domain; the project asserts rights over its editorial matter.

Julius Ruska, *Tabula smaragdina: ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der hermetischen Literatur* (Heidelberg: Winter, 1926), pp. 121, 166–67 — dates the *Sirr al-Khalīqa* 6th–8th c. Paul Kraus, *Jābir ibn Hayyān*, vol. II (Cairo: IFAO, 1942), pp. 274–75 — c. 813–833. Ursula Weisser, *Das "Buch über das Geheimnis der Schöpfung" von Pseudo-Apollonios von Tyana* (Berlin/New York: de Gruyter, 1980), p. 54 — c. 750–800. Three datings, not two; "Kraus 1926" conflates Kraus with Ruska. Weisser's text was not reached for this edition; the dating is reported from the literature.

Ronald Hutton, "Modern Pagan Festivals: A Study in the Nature of Tradition," *Folklore* 119, no. 3 (2008), 251–74 — the standard account of the eightfold Wheel of the Year as a staged mid-20th-century assembly: quarter days alone in the 1940s liturgy, solstices c. 1953, equinoxes after 1954, equal status early 1958; Nichols instituting the Wiccan eight in his Druid order in 1964; Aidan Kelly applying Ostara, Litha and Mabon (his own account dates the calendar to 1974), spreading via *Green Egg* and reaching British usage in the 1980s. Only Yule is an old festival name. IN COPYRIGHT

Ethan Doyle White, *Wicca: History, Belief, and Community in Modern Pagan Witchcraft* (Sussex Academic, 2015), ch. 13. IN COPYRIGHT

Christian H. Bull, *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus: The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom* (Brill, 2018) — for the dating of the *Hermetica*, the older underlying material, and Psellos as reader rather than compiler. IN COPYRIGHT

Ellic Howe, *The Magicians of the Golden Dawn* (1972) — for the Cipher Manuscripts, the grade numbering and the order's documentary problems. IN COPYRIGHT

Graham John Wheeler, "A Microcosm of the Esoteric Revival: The Histories of the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram," *Correspondences: Journal for the Study of Esotericism* 8, no. 1 (2020), 5–44 — the first detailed source-analysis of the ritual, and the authority for the derivations given in Chapter 12. Open access under CC BY-NC 4.0, which is not the same as public domain.

Christopher A. Faraone and Sofia Torallas Tovar (eds), *Greek and Egyptian Magical Formularies*, vol. I (California Classical Studies, 2022) — renumbers the formularies, joins PGM VI to II, re-dates PGM I to the 3rd century, and describes Preisendanz's second edition as obsolete. Open access, not public domain, and it qualifies the "numbering runs to LXXXI" framing above.

Jessica L. Lamont, "Orality, Written Literacy, and Early Sicilian Curse Tablets," *Greece & Rome* 69, no. 1 (2022), 27–51 — open access (CC BY-NC-ND), not public domain.

Marcellin Berthelot and Charles-Émile Ruelle, *Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs* (Paris: Steinheil, 1887–88) — Zosimos, pseudo-Democritus, Leyden X and the Stockholm papyrus. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Auguste Audollent, *Defixionum tabellae* (Paris, 1904) — the curse tablets. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Paul Oskar Kristeller, *Studies in Renaissance Thought and Letters*, p. 223 — the pioneering study of Ficino's Hermetic translation. IN COPYRIGHT

## Where to begin

A reader who wants to go to the primary sources rather than to summaries should start with Copenhaver for the *Hermetica*, Betz for the *Papyri*, Gorceix or a modern edition for the manifestos, and Yates for the historical context of the Rosicrucian episode. Of the public-domain texts, Mathers's *Key of Solomon* (1889) and Waite's *Real History* (1887) are freely available and remain worth reading, with the caveat that both are over a century old and neither reflects current scholarship. Preisendanz's first volume is on the Internet Archive for anyone who reads Greek, though only US readers can rely on that being lawful. Three further public-domain routes are worth naming: Mead's *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) for the *Hermetica*, Berthelot and Ruelle (1887–88) for the Greek alchemists, and Audollent (1904) for the curse tablets.

One caution about free texts, since this book has just spent a bibliography insisting on precision: **open access is not public domain**. Several of the works recommended here — Lamont, Wheeler, Bull, the Faraone and Torallas Tovar volume — are free to read and still fully in copyright, and one carries no licence at all. Free to read is a permission to read, not a permission to reproduce.

The single most useful habit, in this field more than most: when a source tells you a text is ancient, check the date yourself. It is often findable in a few minutes, and it is frequently not what you were told.

### **Final Warning**

This grimoire contains material that should be used responsibly and ethically. Approach these practices with respect, humility and proper preparation. The path of Hermetic study is a long one, and it rewards patience far more than enthusiasm.

*May this grimoire serve as a guide to Hermetic wisdom and Rosicrucian practice — and to the histories from which both were made. Use it wisely and with pure intention.*